YEAR 1 · UNIT 13 · DAYS 421-495

Exile: Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel

Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel

Judgment falls. But God promises a New Covenant written on the heart.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts."

JEREMIAH 31:33

Laments of exile (89:38-52, 137, 79), songs of hope (85, 102, 103, 106, 107), and ten of the fifteen Songs of Ascents.

UNIT 13

In this unit

WEEK 61

421	2 Kings 21:1-23:37	*Reading*
422	2 Kings 24:1-25:30	*Reading*
423	Psalm 89:38-52	*Psalm*
424	Psalm 137	*Psalm*
425	Jeremiah 1:1-3:5	*Reading*
426	Jeremiah 3:6-6:30	*Reading*
427	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 62

428	Jeremiah 7:1-9:26	*Reading*
429	Psalm 79	*Psalm*
430	Psalm 85	*Psalm*
431	Jeremiah 10:1-13:27	*Reading*
432	Jeremiah 14:1-17:27	*Reading*
433	Jeremiah 18:1-20:18	*Reading*
434	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 63

435	Psalm 102	*Psalm*
436	Psalm 103	*Psalm*
437	Jeremiah 21:1-24:10	*Reading*
438	Jeremiah 25:1-27:22	*Reading*
439	Jeremiah 28:1-29:32	*Reading*
440	Psalm 106	*Psalm*
441	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 64

442	Psalm 107:1-22	*Psalm*

443	Jeremiah 30:1-31:40	*Reading*
444	Jeremiah 32:1-33:26	*Reading*
445	Jeremiah 34:1-36:32	*Reading*
446	Jeremiah 37:1-39:18	*Reading*
447	Psalm 107:23-43	*Psalm*
448	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 65

449	Psalm 108	*Psalm*
450	Jeremiah 40:1-42:22	*Reading*
451	Jeremiah 43:1-45:5	*Reading*
452	Jeremiah 46:1-48:47	*Reading*
453	Jeremiah 49:1-51:64	*Reading*
454	Jeremiah 52:1-34	*Reading*
455	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 66

456	Psalm 119:145-176	*Psalm*
457	Psalm 120; Psalm 121	*Psalm*
458	Lamentations 1:1-2:22	*Reading*
459	Lamentations 3:1-66	*Reading*
460	Lamentations 4:1-5:22	*Reading*
461	Ezekiel 1:1-3:27	*Reading*
462	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 67

463	Psalm 73	*Psalm*
464	Psalm 77	*Psalm*
465	Ezekiel 4:1-7:27	*Reading*
466	Ezekiel 8:1-11:25	*Reading*
467	Ezekiel 12:1-14:23	*Reading*
468	Ezekiel 15:1-17:24	*Reading*

469	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 68

470	Psalm 122	*Psalm*
471	Psalm 123; Psalm 126	*Psalm*
472	Ezekiel 18:1-20:49	*Reading*
473	Ezekiel 21:1-24:27	*Reading*
474	Ezekiel 25:1-28:26	*Reading*
475	Ezekiel 29:1-32:32	*Reading*
476	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 69

477	Psalm 128; Psalm 129	*Psalm*
478	Psalm 131; Psalm 133; Psalm 134	*Psalm*
479	Ezekiel 33:1-35:15	*Reading*
480	Ezekiel 36:1-37:28	*Reading*
481	Ezekiel 38:1-39:29	*Reading*
482	Ezekiel 40:1-43:27	*Reading*
483	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 70

484	Ezekiel 44:1-46:24	*Reading*
485	Ezekiel 47:1-48:35	*Reading*
486	Daniel 1:1-2:49	*Reading*
487	Daniel 3:1-4:37	*Reading*
488	Psalm 135	*Psalm*
489	Psalm 136	*Psalm*
490	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 71

491	Daniel 5:1-6:28	*Reading*
492	Daniel 7:1-8:27	*Reading*
493	Daniel 9:1-10:21	*Reading*

494	Daniel 11:1-12:13	*Reading*
495	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 421 · WEEK 61

2 Kings 21:1-23:37

Manasseh; Josiah's reform; the Book of the Law found

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 95 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 21:1-23:37. Judah's worst king is followed by one of its best, and yet the judgment does not turn back. Read chapter 22 slowly, and notice what happens when the Book of the Law is found.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This unit begins the last chapter of Judah's story. Manasseh reigned fifty-five years, the longest of any king, and the Bible calls his reign the cause of Judah's fall. His grandson Josiah then led the greatest reform in the nation's history, and still the sentence of exile stood. Jeremiah began to prophesy in Josiah's thirteenth year, so the prophet you are about to meet stands inside this story.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Manasseh "did what was evil in the sight of the LORD, according to the despicable practices of the nations" (21:2).
2. He "burned his son as an offering" and "shed very much innocent blood" (21:6, 16).
3. "I am bringing such disaster upon Jerusalem and Judah that the ears of everyone who hears of it will tingle" (21:12).
4. Josiah "did what was right in the eyes of the LORD" at eight years old (22:1-2).
5. "I have found the Book of the Law in the house of the LORD" (22:8).
6. "When the king heard the words of the Book of the Law, he tore his clothes" (22:11).
7. "Because your heart was tender and you humbled yourself before the LORD… I also have heard you" (22:19).

8 “Before him there was no king like him, who turned to the LORD with all his heart… Still the LORD did not turn from the burning of his great anger” (23:25-26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Manasseh rebuilt the high places, set up altars to the host of heaven inside the temple courts, practiced sorcery, and sacrificed his own son. The writer says he led the people astray to do more evil than the nations God had destroyed before Israel. The sentence given in chapter 21 is clear: Jerusalem will be wiped out like a dish turned upside down.

Then Josiah. When the Book of the Law is found during temple repairs, it has been lost so long that its words come as a shock. The king hears it read and tears his clothes. This is the right response to Scripture: not curiosity but fear and humility. God tells him that judgment will come, but not in his days, because his heart was tender.

Josiah then does everything the book requires. He reads it to all the people and renews the covenant. He tears down the high places, destroys the altars, defiles Topheth where children were burned, and keeps the greatest Passover since the judges. The writer gives him the highest praise: no king turned to the LORD with all his heart, soul, and might like him.

And yet. “Still the LORD did not turn from the burning of his great anger.” Reform could slow the judgment but could not undo a generation’s habits. The people had cleaned the house, but their hearts had not changed. That is the problem the rest of this unit will face, and why Jeremiah will promise a covenant written on the heart. Josiah dies at Megiddo in 609 BC, and within a few years the nation is under Egypt and then Babylon.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus rebuked leaders who “neglect the weightier matters of the law” (Matthew 23:23). Hebrews 8:7-13 says that the first covenant was faulty because the people did not continue in it, and quotes Jeremiah’s promise of a new one. Romans 7:7-25 shows the law exposing sin without being able to change the heart. Luke 4:17 shows Jesus finding the scroll of Isaiah and reading, a better finding of the Word.

STEP 6

Application

Open your Bible today as if you had just found it. Ask what you would do if you really heard it.

Consider whether you have been tidying up outward habits while your heart stays the same.

Pray for a tender heart, one that trembles at God's word.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make you tremble at his word as Josiah did.
- Ask him not to let you settle for outward reform.
- Confess where your heart has been hard.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 422 · WEEK 61

2 Kings 24:1-25:30

Jerusalem falls; the exile, covenant curses fulfilled

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 24:1-25:30. This is the end of the kingdom of Judah. Read it as the fulfillment of the covenant curses you saw in Deuteronomy, and look for the small sign of hope in the last verses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After Josiah's death, Judah's last four kings ruled for about twenty-three years under the shadow of Egypt and Babylon. Nebuchadnezzar took the first exiles, including Daniel and Ezekiel, in 605 and 597 BC. The final siege ended in 586 BC, when Jerusalem and the temple were burned. This chapter is the historical backdrop for all the prophets you will read in this unit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Surely this came upon Judah at the command of the LORD, to remove them out of his sight" (24:3).
2. Nebuchadnezzar carried off "all Jerusalem… ten thousand captives" in 597 BC (24:14).
3. Zedekiah "rebelled against the king of Babylon" (24:20).
4. "On the seventh day of the fifth month… Nebuzaradan… burned the house of the LORD and the king's house and all the houses of Jerusalem" (25:8-9).
5. They killed Zedekiah's sons before his eyes and then blinded him (25:7).
6. The bronze pillars, the sea, and the temple vessels were broken up and carried to Babylon (25:13-17).
7. "So Judah was taken into exile out of its land" (25:21).

8 “Evil-merodach king of Babylon… graciously freed Jehoiachin from prison… and Jehoiachin dined regularly at the king’s table” (25:27-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story is told with terrible plainness. The writer does not shout or linger. He lists the steps: the siege, the famine, the breach in the wall, the flight of the king, the burning of the temple, the stripping of the bronze, the deportation. The curses of Deuteronomy 28 have come true in order. The nation that was brought out of Egypt is carried back into foreign captivity.

The blame is placed squarely on Judah’s sin, and especially Manasseh’s. But the Lord is the one who sends the Babylonians. This is a point the prophets will make again and again: Babylon is God’s instrument, not his master. Exile is not a sign that God lost. It is a sign that God keeps his word.

Notice the loss of everything that Judah trusted in. The temple is destroyed, which they believed could never fall. The king is blinded and bound. The land is emptied. The articles of worship are melted down. There is nothing left to stand on except God himself.

And then the last four verses. After thirty-seven years in prison, Jehoiachin, the king of David’s line, is released and given a seat at Babylon’s table. It is a small thing. But it shows that David’s line is not extinct. The promise of 2 Samuel 7 has not been cancelled. The writer ends the book with a candle in the dark, and the prophets will light more.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 1:11-12 includes the exile in the genealogy of Jesus: “Jechoniah and his brothers, at the time of the deportation to Babylon.” Jesus predicted another fall of Jerusalem (Luke 21:20-24), and Hebrews 12:27-28 speaks of a kingdom that cannot be shaken. Romans 11:22 pairs God’s kindness and severity. Lamentations will give voice to this grief in a few days.

STEP 6

Application

Take a moment to sit with the weight of this chapter. Judgment is real, and God means what he says.

Ask what you have trusted in as unshakeable: a building, a position, a routine. Where does your security come from?

Remember the small candle at the end, and look for small signs of God's faithfulness in dark times.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to fear him and not presume on his patience.
- Ask him to hold you when everything is lost.
- Thank him that he keeps his word in judgment and mercy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 423 · WEEK 61

Psalm 89:38-52

You have renounced the covenant

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 89:38-52. Last unit you read the first half of this psalm, which celebrates God's covenant with David. Today comes the second half, which seems to contradict it. Read it as the prayer of someone living the fall of Jerusalem.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 89 changes in verse 38. After thirty-seven verses of praise for God's oath to David, the psalmist turns and says, "But now you have cast off and rejected." The king is humiliated, the crown is in the dust, the walls are broken. This is the psalm that fits the end of 2 Kings: the line of David has fallen, and the promise seems to have failed.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But now you have cast off and rejected; you are full of wrath against your anointed" (v. 38).
2. "You have renounced the covenant with your servant; you have defiled his crown in the dust" (v. 39).
3. "You have breached all his walls; you have laid his strongholds in ruins" (v. 40).
4. "You have not made him stand in battle" (v. 43).
5. "You have cut short the days of his youth; you have covered him with shame" (v. 45).
6. "How long, O LORD? Will you hide yourself forever? How long will your wrath burn like fire?" (v. 46).
7. "Lord, where is your steadfast love of old, which by your faithfulness you swore to David?" (v. 49).

8 “Blessed be the LORD forever! Amen and Amen” (v. 52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The contrast between the two halves is deliberate and honest. The first half quotes God’s oath: “I will not violate my covenant.” The second half describes what it looks like to live as though God had violated it. The psalmist does not pretend that the promise and the experience match. He says, “You have renounced the covenant.” It is the language of a person who is not hiding his confusion.

Yet he does not walk away. Every complaint is addressed to God. That is the mark of faith in this psalm: the very God who seems to have broken his word is the one the psalmist keeps speaking to. “Lord, where is your steadfast love of old, which by your faithfulness you swore to David?” He holds God to his own promise.

The ending is one of the most surprising in the Psalter. After forty verses of lament, the psalm closes with praise: “Blessed be the LORD forever! Amen and Amen.” This is a doxology that marks the end of Book 3. Nothing has been resolved. The question is still open. But the psalmist blesses God anyway. Sometimes faith is the choice to bless when you cannot see how the story will end.

For Israel, the answer was long in coming. The line of David looked dead for six hundred years. But the answer came in Bethlehem, in a son of David who would never be removed.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 13:32-34 says that God fulfilled the promise to David by raising Jesus from the dead. Luke 1:32-33 announces that the Lord will give him the throne of his father David. Romans 1:3-4 says Jesus was descended from David according to the flesh and declared Son of God by the resurrection. Revelation 5:5 says the Lion of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered. Romans 15:13 prays for hope in the God of hope.

STEP 6

Application

When your experience does not match God’s promise, pray as the psalmist did: honestly, and to God.

Choose to bless the LORD even in an unanswered season. Say “Blessed be the LORD forever” aloud.

Thank God for Jesus, the answer to the question of Psalm 89.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God where his steadfast love is, in your own honest words.

Bring him your questions because you have nowhere else to go.

Bless him even in the hard questions.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 424 · WEEK 61

Psalm 137

By the waters of Babylon we sat down and wept

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 137. It is the most famous psalm of the exile. Read it slowly. It begins with tears and ends with a prayer that is hard to read. Ask why it is in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 137 was written by someone who had been to Babylon. The exiles sat beside the canals of the Euphrates, and their captors asked them to sing the songs of Zion for entertainment. The psalm is about memory, grief, and the burning of anger. It was probably written after the return, as the memory was still raw. It is paired here with the end of the kingdom.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “By the waters of Babylon, there we sat down and wept, when we remembered Zion” (v. 1).
2. “On the willows there we hung up our lyres” (v. 2).
3. “For there our captors required of us songs, and our tormentors, mirth” (v. 3).
4. “How shall we sing the LORD’s song in a foreign land?” (v. 4).
5. “If I forget you, O Jerusalem, let my right hand forget its skill!” (v. 5).
6. “Let my tongue stick to the roof of my mouth, if I do not remember you” (v. 6).
7. “Remember, O LORD, against the Edomites the day of Jerusalem” (v. 7).
8. “Blessed shall he be who takes your little ones and dashes them against the rock!” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a scene. The exiles sit by the river and weep. The lyres hang on the poplars. They cannot sing. The captors want songs of Zion as entertainment, and to do so would be to treat the worship of the living God as a performance. “How shall we sing the LORD’s song in a foreign land?” The question carries a deeper one: how can we worship when everything is gone?

The answer is memory. In verses 5 and 6 the singer vows to remember Jerusalem above his highest joy. This is not nostalgia. Jerusalem is where God has put his name. To forget Zion would be to forget God’s promises. The singer binds himself with a vow.

Then the psalm erupts in a cry for vengeance. He asks God to remember the Edomites, who cheered on the destruction. And he addresses Babylon with a curse that includes the killing of infants, in the same way that Babylon had treated others. This is shocking. It is a raw expression of the rage of the grieving, and it is there in Scripture without any softening.

Why is it in the Bible? Because honest prayer includes anger. The Bible does not tell us to hide our worst feelings from God. It gives us a place to pour them out. The psalmist does not take up a weapon. He lays the burning desire for justice before the one who will judge. We should not pray these words as our own wish for revenge, but they teach us that God can bear our rage, and that justice belongs to him. And they point us to the cross, where the justice we cannot execute was carried out in a way that included mercy.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 12:19 says, “Never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God.” Jesus on the cross prayed, “Father, forgive them” (Luke 23:34). Revelation 18 shows the fall of Babylon the great, the answer to this psalm’s prayer. 1 Peter 2:11 calls Christians “sojourners and exiles.” Hebrews 13:14 says we seek the city that is to come. Philippians 3:20 says our citizenship is in heaven.

STEP 6

Application

Think about what you refuse to forget about God and his people. Name it.

If you carry anger over a wrong, bring it to God by name, without acting on it.

Pray for Christians who are in exile in a hostile place.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you grieve and what anger you carry.
- Ask him to teach you to sing his song in a foreign land.
- Hand your grief over to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 425 · WEEK 61

Jeremiah 1:1-3:5

Jeremiah called; the two evils; broken cisterns

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 1:1-3:5. Jeremiah is the longest book in the Bible by word count, and it is the story of a reluctant prophet. Read his call in chapter 1, and then notice the two evils that God names in chapter 2.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jeremiah was a priest from Anathoth, a village near Jerusalem. He was called as a young man in the thirteenth year of Josiah, around 627 BC, and he prophesied for over forty years, through the reform, the fall of Jerusalem, and the flight to Egypt. His message was unpopular. He was beaten, imprisoned, and thrown into a cistern. He is called the weeping prophet, but he was also a man of great courage.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, and before you were born I consecrated you; I appointed you a prophet to the nations” (1:5).
2. “Ah, Lord GOD! Behold, I do not know how to speak, for I am only a youth” (1:6).
3. “Do not say, I am only a youth; for to all to whom I send you, you shall go” (1:7).
4. “Behold, I have put my words in your mouth” (1:9).
5. “For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water” (2:13).
6. “What wrong did your fathers find in me that they went far from me?” (2:5).
7. “My people have changed their glory for that which does not profit” (2:11).

8 “Have you not just now called to me, My father, you are the friend of my youth?” (3:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jeremiah’s call is among the most intimate in Scripture. God says he knew him before he was formed. Before birth, he was set apart. The call is not an accident or a career. It is the purpose of his existence. Jeremiah objects at once: “I am only a youth.” God’s reply is typical: don’t say that. Go where I send you, speak what I command, and “be not afraid of them, for I am with you to deliver you.” God then touches his mouth. The word of the LORD is something God puts in the prophet.

His commission has two sides: “to pluck up and to break down, to destroy and to overthrow, to build and to plant.” Four verbs of judgment and two of restoration. Judgment comes first.

Chapter 2 is one of the great statements of sin in the Bible. God remembers the devotion of Israel’s youth, like a bride following him in the wilderness. Then he asks, “What wrong did your fathers find in me?” It is the question of a husband who cannot understand why his wife left. Then the two evils. First, they forsook the fountain of living waters. A spring is endless, fresh, and free. Second, they dug their own cisterns, cracked and leaking. Idolatry is both ingratitude and folly. The nations do not change their gods, and Israel has changed its glory for what does not profit.

The pattern is the human heart: to leave the source of life and then to spend all our energy on things that cannot hold what we put in them. Every generation digs cisterns. Money, approval, success, and pleasure are broken cisterns.

Yet the chapter ends with an invitation. God says, “Return.” The door is still open.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said to the woman at the well, “Whoever drinks of the water that I will give him will never be thirsty again” (John 4:14), and “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (John 7:37). Paul says he was set apart before he was born (Galatians 1:15). Matthew 16:14 notes that some thought Jesus was Jeremiah. Ephesians 2:10 says we are God’s workmanship, created for good works.

STEP 6

Application

Name one “broken cistern” that you have gone to for satisfaction. Bring your thirst to Christ.

If you have felt too young, too inexperienced, or too weak for what God has asked, hear his words, “I am with you.”

Pray for a fresh sense of being known and called by God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the cisterns you have dug for yourself.
- Ask him to draw you back to the fountain of living waters.
- Thank him that he knew you before you were formed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

“For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water.”

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 426 · WEEK 61

Jeremiah 3:6-6:30

Israel and Judah's unfaithfulness; the foe from the north

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 3:6-6:30. God calls two faithless sisters, Israel and Judah, to return, and then announces a foe from the north. Read the call to return in 3:12-4:4 slowly, and then notice how the people respond to the warning in chapter 6.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters belong to the early part of Jeremiah's ministry, in the days of Josiah. The northern kingdom had already been destroyed. Judah had seen what happened to her sister and had not learned. Jeremiah mixes pleading and warning. The enemy is a nation from the north, which is Babylon. The people were in the middle of Josiah's reform, and yet the prophet says that the heart has not changed.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Faithless Israel has shown herself more righteous than treacherous Judah" (3:11).
2. "Return, faithless Israel, declares the LORD. I will not look on you in anger, for I am merciful" (3:12).
3. "Return, O faithless sons; I will heal your faithlessness" (3:22).
4. "Circumcise yourselves to the LORD; remove the foreskin of your hearts" (4:4).
5. "My anguish, my anguish! I writhe in pain! Oh the walls of my heart!" (4:19).
6. "They are wise to do evil, but how to do good they know not" (4:22).
7. "They have healed the wound of my people lightly, saying, Peace, peace, when there is no peace" (6:14).

8 “Stand by the roads, and look, and ask for the ancient paths, where the good way is; and walk in it, and find rest for your souls. But they said, We will not walk in it” (6:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The call to return in chapter 3 is full of mercy. God compares Israel and Judah to two unfaithful wives. The northern kingdom had been sent away, and Judah had seen it and kept sinning, and with only a pretense of returning to God. Even so, he pleads: “Return, O faithless sons; I will heal your faithlessness.” The invitation contains the words to say, and the promise of shepherds after God’s own heart.

But the heart of chapter 4 is a demand for inward change: “Circumcise yourselves to the LORD; remove the foreskin of your hearts.” The outward sign of the covenant meant nothing if the heart remained closed. This is the main complaint of the prophets. Josiah could reform worship, but he could not circumcise the hearts of the nation.

Then the alarm. A lion has come up from his thicket. Jeremiah describes the invasion as if he were living it, and his own heart breaks. “My anguish, my anguish!” The prophet does not speak coldly about judgment. He feels it in his body. He is a true intercessor, identifying with the people he warns.

Chapter 6 identifies the problem. The leaders have “healed the wound of my people lightly, saying, Peace, peace, when there is no peace.” False comfort is cruel. They are not even ashamed of their abominations. God offers one more chance: “Stand by the roads, and look, and ask for the ancient paths… and find rest for your souls.” The answer is the saddest in the chapter: “We will not walk in it.” They are refusing an offer of rest.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest” (Matthew 11:28-29), alluding to Jeremiah 6:16. Paul says that real circumcision is of the heart, by the Spirit (Romans 2:28-29; Colossians 2:11). Jesus wept over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41), as Jeremiah wept. Hebrews 3:7-8 warns, “Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts.”

STEP 6

Application

Where do you hear “peace, peace” where there is no peace? Be honest about what needs to be dealt with.

Ask God for a circumcised heart, one that is open and responsive to him.

Look for an “ancient path” that you have neglected: Scripture, prayer, fellowship, Sabbath.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to circumcise your heart.
- Keep yourself from false peace, and tell him where you want truth.
- Thank him for promising to heal your faithlessness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

“For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water.”

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 427 · WEEK 61

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jeremiah 2:13 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."

JEREMIAH 2:13

REST

Meditation

God diagnoses the whole human problem in one verse, and he calls it two evils.

The first evil is leaving the fountain. God describes himself as "the fountain of living waters." In a dry land, a spring of living water is life. It does not run out or need to be dug. It simply flows. Every good thing we need comes from him, and he offers it freely. To forsake him is to walk away from the one source that cannot fail.

The second evil is building our own cisterns. A cistern is a hole cut in rock to collect rainwater. It is man-made, limited, and dependent on circumstances. And these are "broken" cisterns, cracked, so they cannot even hold what they collect. The picture is of tremendous effort invested in something that cannot deliver. We chisel away at success, approval, comfort, and control, and each time the water drains out.

What stands out is the tone. God is not only angry. He is astonished. Earlier in the chapter he says, “Be appalled, O heavens, at this.” It is baffling to him that anyone would trade a spring for a leaky tank. And behind the astonishment is grief. He loves his people and wants them to have what satisfies.

Jesus claimed to be this fountain. “Let the one who is thirsty come.” The remedy for broken cisterns is not trying harder but turning back. Say this verse when you feel empty, and ask what cistern you have been drinking from.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the exile unit by reading the last days of the kingdom of Judah. You saw Manasseh’s evil, Josiah’s tender-hearted reform, and the sobering line that the LORD still did not turn from his anger. You read the account of Jerusalem’s fall in 2 Kings, with the small candle of Jehoiachin’s release at the end. You prayed Psalm 89’s painful second half and the grief of Psalm 137, learning that honest prayer includes lament. And you met Jeremiah, called before he was born, who named the two evils of his people: forsaking the fountain of living waters and digging broken cisterns. His early preaching called them to return and to circumcise their hearts. The week taught that outward reform is not enough, that God invites us to return, and that he is the only source of life.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Josiah found the Book of the Law and tore his clothes. How do you respond when God’s word exposes something in your life?

Jeremiah describes forsaking the fountain and digging broken cisterns. What is one cistern you tend to drink from instead of God?

Jesus calls himself the source of living water (John 7:37-38). What would it look like to come to him as thirsty this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess the cisterns you have dug.

Thank Jesus for giving water that satisfies.

Rest in him today.

DAY 428 · WEEK 62

Jeremiah 7:1-9:26

The Temple sermon; false security condemned

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 87 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 7:1-9:26. Jeremiah stands in the gate of the temple and preaches the most dangerous sermon of his life. Read it as a warning to people who think that being near the right building makes them safe.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the Temple Sermon, delivered early in the reign of Jehoiakim, around 609 BC (see Jeremiah 26). The people believed that Jerusalem could never fall because the temple of the LORD was there. After the Assyrian army was destroyed in Hezekiah's day, that belief hardened into superstition. Jeremiah tells them it is a lie. Chapters 8 and 9 add the prophet's tears over the nation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Do not trust in these deceptive words: This is the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD" (7:4).
2. "If you truly amend your ways and your deeds… if you do not oppress the sojourner, the fatherless, or the widow" (7:5-6).
3. "Has this house, which is called by my name, become a den of robbers in your eyes?" (7:11).
4. "Go now to my place that was in Shiloh… and see what I did to it" (7:12).
5. "For in the day that I brought them out of the land of Egypt, I did not speak to your fathers… concerning burnt offerings and sacrifices. But this command I gave them: Obey my voice" (7:22-23).

6. “Is there no balm in Gilead? Is there no physician there?” (8:22).
7. “Oh that my head were a spring of water, and my eyes a fountain of tears, that I might weep day and night” (9:1).
8. “Let not the wise man boast in his wisdom… but let him who boasts boast in this, that he understands and knows me” (9:23-24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sermon begins with a trap. The people repeat a slogan: “The temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD.” They treat the building as a charm. Jeremiah says that if they are going to live there, they must act justly: no oppression of the foreigner, the orphan, or the widow, no shedding of innocent blood, no following other gods. They steal, murder, commit adultery, swear falsely, and then come into the temple and say, “We are delivered!” That is, they think the temple frees them to keep doing evil.

God’s reply is that they have turned his house into “a den of robbers.” A den is where robbers hide after their crimes. Jesus quotes this very line when he clears the temple. Then God points to Shiloh, where the tabernacle once stood, and which had been destroyed. If he allowed that, he can allow this.

Verses 21 to 23 are a shock. God says that when he brought them out of Egypt, his main command was not about sacrifices but about obedience. The sacrifices were meant to express the relationship, not replace it.

Chapter 8 contains one of the most poignant questions in the Bible: “Is there no balm in Gilead?” Gilead was known for healing ointment. The prophet asks why his people are not healed, since there is a physician. The answer is that they will not be healed. And chapter 9 shows the prophet weeping. “Oh that my head were a spring of water.” He is the true intercessor.

The chapter ends with a great statement of what matters: let no one boast in wisdom, might, or riches, but in knowing the LORD, “who practices steadfast love, justice, and righteousness.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus quoted Jeremiah 7:11 when he cleansed the temple (Mark 11:17), and then said that not one stone would be left on another (Mark 13:2). Paul quotes Jeremiah 9:24 in 1 Corinthians 1:31 and 2 Corinthians 10:17. Jesus is the true physician (Mark 2:17). Acts 7:48 reminds us that

the Most High does not dwell in houses made by hands. 1 Corinthians 3:16 says that the believers are God's temple.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any place, ritual, or tradition has become a "temple of the LORD" slogan for you.

Look at how you treat the foreigner, the orphan, and the widow. Is there something to change?

Memorize Jeremiah 9:23-24 and ask what you are tempted to boast in.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from trusting deceptive words.
- Ask him not to let you hide in his house while sin remains.
- Ask him to make you just and merciful toward the weak.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 429 · WEEK 62

Psalm 79

O God, the nations have come into your inheritance

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 79. It is a communal lament written after the destruction of Jerusalem. Read it as the congregation's cry after reading 2 Kings 25, and notice the way it moves from catastrophe to confession and to a request for forgiveness.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 79 is a psalm of Asaph. It is one of the clearest psalms about the Babylonian destruction of Jerusalem, with the temple defiled, the city in ruins, and the bodies unburied. It pairs naturally with Jeremiah's temple sermon, which warned this would happen. It is a prayer of those who know that part of the blame is their own.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, the nations have come into your inheritance; they have defiled your holy temple; they have laid Jerusalem in ruins" (v. 1).
2. "They have given the bodies of your servants to the birds of the heavens for food" (v. 2).
3. "We have become a taunt to our neighbors, mocked and derided by those around us" (v. 4).
4. "How long, O LORD? Will you be angry forever?" (v. 5).
5. "Do not remember against us our former iniquities; let your compassion come speedily to meet us, for we are brought very low" (v. 8).
6. "Help us, O God of our salvation, for the glory of your name" (v. 9).
7. "Why should the nations say, Where is their God?" (v. 10).

8 “But we your people, the sheep of your pasture, will give thanks to you forever; from generation to generation we will recount your praise” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with an inventory of ruin. The temple is defiled, the city is rubble, the dead are left unburied. The psalmist holds nothing back. The people have become a mockery to the neighbors, a taunt, and he asks the question every grieving believer asks: “How long, O LORD? Will you be angry forever?”

But notice what the prayer does not do. It does not claim that Judah is innocent. “Do not remember against us our former iniquities.” The people know why this happened. The prophets had told them. The psalm joins confession with the cry for help. “Help us… deliver us, and atone for our sins, for your name’s sake.” The word “atone” is the language of the temple, and it comes from a people who have lost their temple. They ask God himself to cover their sin.

The reason given for the appeal is God’s name. “Why should the nations say, Where is their God?” The people are not asking to be rescued because they deserve it, but because God’s reputation is bound up with theirs. This is the way of intercession in the Bible: to ask God to act for the sake of his own glory.

The psalm ends with a vow of praise. The people are “the sheep of your pasture.” The shepherd has allowed the wolves in, but the sheep still belong to him. They promise to give thanks forever and to tell the story from generation to generation. Even this psalm of ruin ends with testimony, since praise does not depend on circumstances.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus wept over Jerusalem and foretold its destruction (Luke 19:41-44). Hebrews 9:26 says Christ has appeared “to put away sin by the sacrifice of himself,” the atonement for which this psalm cries. 1 John 1:9 promises forgiveness to those who confess. John 10:11-16 shows Jesus as the shepherd who gathers his sheep. 1 Peter 2:25 says we have returned to the Shepherd.

STEP 6

Application

Practice confession as part of lament. Name your sins and ask God to atone for them.

Ask for God’s help for the sake of his name, not just your own comfort.

Tell someone younger the story of one thing God has done for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help for the glory of his name.
- Ask him not to remember your former iniquities.
- Ask him to let his compassion come to meet you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 430 · WEEK 62

Psalm 85

LORD, you were favorable to your land

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 85. It is a prayer for revival that remembers past forgiveness and looks for a future where righteousness and peace meet. Read verses 10 to 13 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 85 is a psalm of the sons of Korah. It begins by recalling that God has restored the fortunes of Jacob, and then asks him to do it again. It may have been written after the return from Babylon, when the people were back in the land but the glory had not returned. It will be read again in Unit 14 with an emphasis on the return. Here it is a prayer from the dark side of the exile, asking God to revive his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "LORD, you were favorable to your land; you restored the fortunes of Jacob" (v. 1).
2. "You forgave the iniquity of your people; you covered all their sin" (v. 2).
3. "Restore us again, O God of our salvation, and put away your indignation toward us!" (v. 4).
4. "Will you not revive us again, that your people may rejoice in you?" (v. 6).
5. "Show us your steadfast love, O LORD, and grant us your salvation" (v. 7).
6. "Steadfast love and faithfulness meet; righteousness and peace kiss each other" (v. 10).
7. "Faithfulness springs up from the ground, and righteousness looks down from the sky" (v. 11).
8. "Righteousness will go before him and make his footsteps a way" (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with memory: God has been favorable before. He forgave and covered sin and turned away from his fierce anger. This past mercy is the basis of the plea. When we do not know what to pray, we can start by recalling what God has already done.

The prayer is for revival. “Will you not revive us again, that your people may rejoice in you?” Joy in God is the goal. Revival here is not an event or a program but a renewal of the people’s delight in the LORD. It assumes that left alone, we dry out.

Then the psalmist does something striking. He says, “Let me hear what God the LORD will speak.” He stops talking and listens. And the word that comes is peace, for those who turn their hearts to him. God’s salvation is near to those who fear him, “that glory may dwell in our land.”

The center of the psalm is its beautiful picture in verses 10 and 11. Four qualities, which usually seem to pull against each other, are brought together: steadfast love and faithfulness, righteousness and peace. They meet and kiss. This is a picture of the gospel. How can God be both loving and just? How can he bring peace without compromising righteousness? In the cross, these meet. Steadfast love forgives, and faithfulness keeps the promise to punish sin. Righteousness is satisfied, and peace is made.

The psalm ends with the hope of the Lord’s appearance: “Righteousness will go before him and make his footsteps a way.” The good that will come will come from heaven and from the earth together.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 3:25-26 shows how God is both just and the justifier, where love and righteousness meet. Colossians 1:20 says that God was pleased “to reconcile to himself all things, making peace by the blood of his cross.” Romans 5:1 says that we have peace with God. John 1:14 says that the Word became flesh, full of grace and truth. Luke 2:14 announces “peace among those with whom he is pleased.”

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of the ways God has been “favorable to your land” in your life.

Pray “Will you not revive us again?” for your church and for yourself.

Sit in silence and say, “Let me hear what God the LORD will speak.” Listen for a few minutes.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to revive you.
- Tell him you want steadfast love and faithfulness to meet in your life.
- Thank him for his salvation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 431 · WEEK 62

Jeremiah 10:1-13:27

Idols vs. the living God; the linen loincloth

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 75 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 10:1-13:27. These chapters include a satire on idols, the covenant that was broken, Jeremiah's first complaint, and two sign-acts: a linen loincloth and wine jars. Look for how God uses ordinary objects to teach.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The setting continues in the reign of Jehoiakim. The people have been worshiping the gods of the surrounding nations, and Jeremiah mocks them. Chapters 11 and 12 reveal a personal crisis: his own village of Anathoth plots to kill him, and he asks God why the wicked prosper. Chapter 13 contains one of Jeremiah's most visual sermons.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Their idols are like scarecrows in a cucumber field, and they cannot speak" (10:5).
2. "But the LORD is the true God; he is the living God and the everlasting King" (10:10).
3. "It is he who made the earth by his power, who established the world by his wisdom" (10:12).
4. "Cursed be the man who does not hear the words of this covenant" (11:3).
5. "But I was like a gentle lamb led to the slaughter" (11:19).
6. "Why does the way of the wicked prosper? Why do all who are treacherous thrive?" (12:1).
7. "If you have raced with men on foot, and they have wearied you, how will you compete with horses?" (12:5).
8. "So I bought a loincloth… it was spoiled; it was good for nothing" (13:1-7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 10 mocks the idols with a bit of humor. They are like scarecrows. They have to be carried because they cannot walk, and they cannot do good or harm. The contrast with the LORD is sharp: “There is none like you, O LORD.” The idols are made by hands. The LORD made the earth by his power. The call is to reverent fear before the King of the nations.

Chapter 11 turns to the covenant. The people heard the covenant words at Sinai and agreed, but then broke them. Jeremiah’s own townsmen of Anathoth plot to kill him if he does not stop prophesying. Then he opens a window into his heart. In chapter 12, he does what Habakkuk did: he complains to God. “Why does the way of the wicked prosper?” He wants answers. God does not give him a neat theology. He tells him that things will get harder. If racing with men on foot has worn him out, how will he cope with horses? God is preparing him for worse. It is not comforting, but it is honest. God does not coddle his servants.

Chapter 13 shows a sign. God tells Jeremiah to buy a linen loincloth, wear it, bury it by the Euphrates, and later dig it up. It is ruined. The meaning is that Israel was meant to cling to God like a loincloth to a man’s waist, “for a people, a name, a praise, and a glory.” But they would not listen, and so they became useless. The proud will be broken. The chapter ends with a question that pierces: “Can the Ethiopian change his skin or the leopard his spots? Then also you can do good who are accustomed to do evil.” Human nature cannot reform itself. Only God can change a heart, which is why the new covenant is so needed.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 14:15 and 17:22-31 draw on this critique of idols. Jesus was led like a lamb to the slaughter (Isaiah 53:7; Acts 8:32). 1 Corinthians 8:4-6 says there is one God and one Lord, Jesus Christ. John 3:3-7 says no one can see the kingdom without being born again. Romans 7:18 says that nothing good dwells in me, that is, in my flesh. Ezekiel 36:26 promises a new heart.

STEP 6

Application

Name any “scarecrow” idol in your life that cannot speak or act. Turn from it.

If you are weary, remember God’s honesty with Jeremiah: he prepares us for what is ahead.

Ask whether you cling to God like a loincloth, close and for his glory.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God as the true, living God.

Confess where you have trusted scarecrows.

Ask him to strengthen you when you feel worn.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 432 · WEEK 62

Jeremiah 14:1-17:27

Drought and sword; the deceitful heart; the Sabbath

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 104 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 14:1-17:27. A drought and a sword fall on Judah, Jeremiah refuses to marry or celebrate, and God exposes the human heart. Read 17:5-10 slowly, which contrasts the person who trusts in man with the one who trusts in the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters begin with a drought and a series of dialogues between Jeremiah and God. God tells him three times not to intercede for the people. The prophet's personal life becomes part of the message: he is not to marry, mourn, or feast. Chapter 17 contains the famous passage on the deceitful heart, the blessed man, and a call to keep the Sabbath.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Though our iniquities testify against us, act, O LORD, for your name's sake" (14:7).
2. "Then the LORD said to me, Though Moses and Samuel stood before me, yet my heart would not turn toward this people" (15:1).
3. "Your words were found, and I ate them, and your words became to me a joy and the delight of my heart" (15:16).
4. "Why is my pain unceasing, my wound incurable?" (15:18).
5. "If you return, I will restore you, and you shall stand before me" (15:19).
6. "Cursed is the man who trusts in man and makes flesh his strength, whose heart turns away from the LORD" (17:5).
7. "Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD" (17:7).

8 “The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick; who can understand it?” (17:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The drought is a covenant curse. The land is parched, the cisterns are empty, the deer abandon their fawns. The people pray, but God says they love to wander. Even if Moses and Samuel interceded, he would not turn. The time for the warning is past. It is a hard thing for a prophet who loves his people. In chapter 15, Jeremiah is deeply wounded. His one consolation was God’s word: “Your words were found, and I ate them.” He consumed the word like food, and it was joy. But his joy led to isolation: he sat alone because God’s hand was on him. His complaint about God’s apparent unreliability, “like a deceitful brook,” draws a sharp reply: “If you return, I will restore you.” Even the prophet needs to repent.

Chapter 16 forbids Jeremiah to marry, mourn, or feast. His loneliness is a sermon: life as they know it is ending. And yet, in the middle, a promise that the people will be brought back from the north, and that a new exodus will eclipse the old one.

Chapter 17 is the heart of this section. The sin of Judah is written with an iron pen, engraved on the tablet of their heart. Then a pair of contrasting trees. The person who trusts in man is like a shrub in the desert, unaware of when good comes. The one who trusts in the LORD is like a tree planted by water, unafraid in the heat, still bearing fruit in drought. And the reason: “The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick.” No one can fully know his own heart. But the LORD searches it. This is why we need a new heart, not just better habits.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I am the vine; you are the branches” (John 15:5), and drew on the picture of fruitfulness. Psalm 1:3 describes the same tree. Mark 7:21-23 says that out of the heart come evil thoughts. Hebrews 4:12 says the word of God discerns the thoughts and intentions of the heart. Revelation 10:9-10 shows John eating the scroll, as Jeremiah ate the words. Proverbs 4:23 says to guard your heart.

STEP 6

Application

Ask God to search your heart and show you what you cannot see (Jeremiah 17:10).

Consider where you are trusting in “flesh” this week. Redirect your trust to the LORD.

Receive the word of God as food. Spend time today with a short passage and “eat” it slowly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess that your heart is deceitful, and ask him to search it.
- Ask him to lead you in the way everlasting.
- Thank him that he tests the mind.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 433 · WEEK 62

Jeremiah 18:1-20:18

The potter's house; the broken flask; Jeremiah beaten

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 18:1-20:18. Jeremiah visits a potter's house, smashes a clay jar in front of the elders, and is beaten and put in stocks. Then he writes one of the darkest prayers in the Bible. Read the potter scene first, then chapter 20.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Two sign-acts mark these chapters: the potter at his wheel (chapter 18) and the shattered flask in the Valley of Hinnom (chapter 19). The second one costs him dearly. The priest Pashhur, chief officer of the temple, has Jeremiah beaten and put in the stocks. When he is released, Jeremiah gives his harshest complaint to God, and the book shows us how a faithful prophet feels when faithfulness seems to ruin his life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, like the clay in the potter's hand, so are you in my hand, O house of Israel" (18:6).
2. "If that nation concerning which I have spoken turns from its evil, I will relent of the disaster that I intended to do to it" (18:8).
3. "But they say, That is in vain! We will follow our own plans" (18:12).
4. "So you shall break the flask in the sight of the men who go with you" (19:10).
5. "Thus will I break this people and this city, as one breaks a potter's vessel" (19:11).
6. "Then Pashhur… struck Jeremiah the prophet, and put him in the stocks" (20:2).
7. "O LORD, you have deceived me, and I was deceived; you are stronger than I, and you have prevailed" (20:7).

8 “If I say, I will not mention him, or speak any more in his name, there is in my heart as it were a burning fire shut up in my bones, and I am weary with holding it in, and I cannot” (20:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

At the potter’s house, Jeremiah watches a vessel spoil in the potter’s hands, and the potter reshapes it into another. God’s lesson is about sovereignty and responsiveness. The potter has the right to shape the clay. But the passage also teaches that God responds to repentance. If a nation under judgment turns, he will relent. If a nation that was promised blessing turns to evil, he will withdraw it. The warnings and promises of the prophets are not fixed in stone but are addressed to human response. And yet the people reply, “We will follow our own plans.”

In chapter 19, Jeremiah is told to buy a finished clay jar and take the elders to the Valley of Hinnom, where children had been burned to Baal, and smash it. A clay pot that has been fired cannot be remade. The first sign-act showed that a repentant clay could be reshaped. The second shows that stubborn clay will be broken beyond repair. The message: God has been patient, but there is a point at which the vessel is hardened.

The punishment comes at once. Pashhur strikes him and puts him in the stocks overnight. Jeremiah’s reply is a blazing prophecy of exile. Then he is alone with God, and he prays one of the most honest prayers in Scripture. “You have deceived me.” He feels that God has trapped him. The word of the LORD has become a reproach and derision. Yet he cannot quit: “There is in my heart as it were a burning fire shut up in my bones.” He cannot stop speaking.

He ends with trust, “the LORD is with me as a dread warrior,” and then with despair, “Cursed be the day on which I was born.” Both are in one chapter. The Bible does not tidy faith. It shows a servant of God who is faithful and in agony.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 9:20-21 draws on the potter and clay. Isaiah 64:8 says, “You are the potter; we are the clay.” Matthew 27:7-10 connects the potter’s field to the death of Judas, with a quotation attributed to Jeremiah. Paul speaks of treasure in jars of clay (2 Corinthians 4:7). Acts 5:40-41 shows the apostles rejoicing when beaten. Luke 24:32 describes hearts burning within as Jesus opened the Scriptures.

STEP 6

Application

Place one area of your life in the potter's hands, and ask him to reshape it.

If you are discouraged in serving God, pray honestly like Jeremiah. God can handle it.

Ask for the "burning fire" of the word in your heart, and for courage to share it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you are clay and he is the potter, and let him reshape you.
- Ask him to help you when serving him hurts.
- Thank him for his faithfulness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 434 · WEEK 62

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jeremiah 17:7-8 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

REST

Meditation

Jeremiah wrote these words in a land of drought, to a people who were trusting in everything but God. It is a promise that holds in hard seasons.

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD." The word "blessed" means deeply happy, in a good place. The Bible links this blessing not to circumstances but to trust. And the trust is placed in a person: "whose trust is the LORD." He himself is the trust. It is not trust in a technique, a doctrine as such, or a strategy for success. It is a relationship with a person.

"He is like a tree planted by water." The picture is of a tree whose roots go to the stream. In a dry country, the tree by the water has a source that does not depend on rainfall. The roots do the hidden work, "sending out" toward the water. So much of the Christian life is hidden roots: time in prayer, reading Scripture, quiet obedience, worship.

“Does not fear when heat comes.” Notice that heat does come. The blessed person is not spared the heat. But they do not fear it, because the roots are in the stream. The next verse adds, “Its leaves remain green, and is not anxious in the year of drought, for it does not cease to bear fruit.” In the drought it keeps bearing fruit.

Contrast the previous verses: the person who trusts in man is a shrub in the desert. The difference is not in the climate but in the source. Say this verse and ask where your roots are going this week.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you stood in the temple gate with Jeremiah and heard the sermon that said a building cannot save you. You read the great questions: “Is there no balm in Gilead?” and the invitation to boast only in knowing the LORD. You prayed Psalms 79 and 85, a lament over the ruined city and a prayer for revival in which steadfast love and faithfulness meet. You read Jeremiah’s mockery of idols, his own struggle when the wicked prosper, and the ruined loincloth. You read the deceitful heart and the two trees. You watched the potter, the shattered jar, and Jeremiah in the stocks, burning with the word he could not hold in. The week taught that God’s patience has limits, that religion without obedience is empty, and that the one who trusts in the LORD is like a tree by the stream.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jeremiah warned people not to trust in the temple as a charm. What “temple of the LORD” slogan might you be leaning on instead of obedience?

Jeremiah’s prayers are honest, even angry. What do you need to bring honestly to God that you have been holding back?

The blessed man in Jeremiah 17 is like a tree planted by water. What are the “roots” you are sending out each week, and where might they be shallow?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you send roots deep into him.

Tell him how you want to trust him in heat and drought.

Thank Jesus in whom you are blessed.

DAY 435 · WEEK 63

Psalm 102

A prayer of the afflicted

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 102. It is headed "A prayer of one afflicted, when he is faint and pours out his complaint before the LORD." Notice how the psalm moves from personal misery to the eternal reign of God, and how the New Testament quotes the end.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 102 is one of the seven penitential psalms in church tradition. It has no named author. It is the cry of an individual who feels his life vanishing like smoke, and at the same time a prayer for Zion's restoration, which fits the exile. It sets private suffering inside the story of God's people and the story of creation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear my prayer, O LORD; let my cry come to you!" (v. 1).
2. "For my days pass away like smoke, and my bones burn like a furnace" (v. 3).
3. "I am like a lonely sparrow on the housetop" (v. 7).
4. "For I eat ashes like bread, and mingle tears with my drink" (vv. 9).
5. "My days are like an evening shadow; I wither away like grass" (v. 11).
6. "But you, O LORD, are enthroned forever; you are remembered throughout all generations" (v. 12).
7. "You will arise and have pity on Zion; it is the time to favor her" (v. 13).
8. "Of old you laid the foundation of the earth… They will perish, but you will remain… but you are the same, and your years have no end" (vv. 25-27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a rush of need: hear me, do not hide your face, answer me speedily. The description that follows is vivid and bodily. His days vanish like smoke. His bones burn. His heart is struck down like grass. He forgets to eat. He is wasted by groaning. He is like a pelican in the wilderness or an owl among ruins, a sleepless bird alone on a roof. And he feels that God has lifted him up only to throw him down. Few passages in the Bible describe depression and isolation so plainly.

The turning point is a single word at verse 12: “But you, O LORD.” Against all that is passing and fading, the psalmist sets the One who is enthroned forever. The shadow of his life lengthens, but God’s name endures to all generations. The change of view then opens his prayer outward. He asks that God will have pity on Zion. “The nations will fear the name of the LORD,” and a people yet to be created will praise him.

The psalm ends with creation itself. The heavens and earth will wear out like a garment, but God is the same. This is the final consolation for the dying and discouraged: the one in whom we trust does not change. “The children of your servants shall dwell secure.” The prayer of one man’s faintness is carried by the unchanging God.

Hebrews 1:10-12 quotes verses 25 to 27 and applies them to the Son. The one who laid the foundation of the earth and who will remain when it perishes is Jesus. So the faint and afflicted worshiper in the psalm is praying to Christ, whose years have no end.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 1:10-12 attributes Psalm 102:25-27 to the Son, showing his eternal deity. Hebrews 13:8 says, “Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever.” 2 Corinthians 4:16-18 speaks of the outer self wasting away while the inner self is renewed. Romans 8:18 says the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory to be revealed. Malachi 3:6 says, “I the LORD do not change.”

STEP 6

Application

If you are weary or lonely, pray the first eleven verses honestly, then pray verse 12 as a turning point.

Name something that is fading in your life, and remember who remains.

Pray for the church in the places where it seems to be in ruins.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry out to God from your affliction.
- Tell him that he is enthroned forever.
- Ask him to arise and have pity.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 436 · WEEK 63

Psalm 103

Bless the LORD, O my soul, steadfast love as high as heaven

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 103. After a psalm of exhaustion, here is a psalm of praise, one of the most loved in the whole Psalter. You may have read it before. Read it slowly, and let every phrase about forgiveness sink in.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 103 is a psalm of David. It is an individual's call to himself to bless the LORD, which widens out to include all God's people and all creation. After Jeremiah's relentless warnings and Psalm 102's affliction, it stands as a declaration of what the God of the exile is really like. It will appear again later in the plan. Today read it as the answer to what Jeremiah and the psalmists have been asking: what is God like when we have failed?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Bless the LORD, O my soul, and all that is within me, bless his holy name!" (v. 1).
2. "Forget not all his benefits" (v. 2).
3. "Who forgives all your iniquity, who heals all your diseases" (v. 3).
4. "The LORD works righteousness and justice for all who are oppressed" (v. 6).
5. "The LORD is merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love" (v. 8).
6. "He does not deal with us according to our sins, nor repay us according to our iniquities" (v. 10).
7. "As far as the east is from the west, so far does he remove our transgressions from us" (v. 12).

8 “As a father shows compassion to his children, so the LORD shows compassion to those who fear him. For he knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust” (vv. 13-14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins by speaking to his own soul. He commands himself to bless the LORD, and to remember. “Forget not all his benefits.” The psalm’s work is remembering, since we are forgetful. Then he lists them: forgiveness, healing, redemption from the pit, a crown of steadfast love, and satisfaction with good, so that your youth is renewed like the eagle’s. Forgiveness is the first item, and it is the benefit that makes the rest possible.

In verses 6 to 8, David recalls the way God made himself known to Moses: merciful and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in steadfast love. This is the self-description from Exodus 34:6, which Jonah quoted, and which echoes through the Bible. And the psalm unpacks it. God does not keep his anger forever. He does not deal with us according to our sins. The heavens are high above the earth, but his steadfast love is greater than that. The east is far from the west, and that is how far he has removed our transgressions.

Here is the point for the unit. This psalm is true even in exile. The exile was real judgment, and it was a sign that God deals with sin. But it was not the whole story. He did not repay them according to their iniquities. He kept a remnant. He promised to bring them back.

Verses 13 to 14 give the reason: God is like a father who knows his children. “He knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust.” God is not surprised by our weakness. He is gentle with it. The psalm ends by calling the angels, the mighty ones, and all creation to bless the LORD, and then returns to the beginning: “Bless the LORD, O my soul.”

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 1:7 says that in Christ we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses. Hebrews 8:12 and 10:17 promise that God will remember our sins no more. Romans 8:15 says that we cry, “Abba! Father!” Luke 15:20 shows the father who ran to meet his son. 1 John 1:9 promises forgiveness and cleansing. Micah 7:18-19 says he casts all our sins into the depths of the sea.

STEP 6

Application

Write down five of God’s benefits to you, and thank him for each.

Preach to your own soul: say aloud “Bless the LORD, O my soul” when you feel low.

Rest in the truth that God remembers that you are dust. Bring your weakness to him without fear.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bless the LORD with all that is within you.
- Name a benefit of his that you do not want to forget.
- Thank him for his love as high as the heavens.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 437 · WEEK 63

Jeremiah 21:1-24:10

Kings condemned; the good and bad figs; the 70 years

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 21:1-24:10. Jeremiah speaks to the last kings of Judah, promises a righteous Branch, condemns the false shepherds, and sees two baskets of figs. Read 23:1-8 and chapter 24 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters mostly date to the reign of Zedekiah, the last king, around 590 BC, while Babylon was closing in. The king sends messengers to Jeremiah asking for a miracle, and the prophet answers that God himself is fighting against Jerusalem. Then he describes the failure of the kings of Judah. In the midst of the gloom come some of the book's most important promises of a coming king and a restored remnant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, I set before you the way of life and the way of death" (21:8).
2. "Woe to him who builds his house by unrighteousness… who makes his neighbor serve him for nothing" (22:13).
3. "Did not your father eat and drink and do justice and righteousness? … He judged the cause of the poor and needy; then it was well. Is not this to know me?" (22:15-16).
4. "Woe to the shepherds who destroy and scatter the sheep of my pasture!" (23:1).
5. "Behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when I will raise up for David a righteous Branch" (23:5).
6. "And this is the name by which he will be called: The LORD is our righteousness" (23:6).
7. "Am I a God at hand, declares the LORD, and not a God far away?" (23:23).

8 “Like these good figs, so I will regard as good the exiles from Judah” (24:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The king asks for a miracle, as Hezekiah once received. But this time there is no deliverance. God says, “I myself will fight against you.” The choice for the people is stark: go out and surrender to Babylon and live, or stay and die. It sounds like treason, and Jeremiah is treated that way. It was actually a call to humble submission to God’s chastening.

Chapters 22 and 23 deal with the kings. Shallum, Jehoiakim, and Jehoiachin are in turn condemned. Jehoiakim built a luxurious palace with forced labor. God contrasts him with his father Josiah, who did justice and righteousness and judged the cause of the poor and needy. The key line: “Is not this to know me?” To know God is to care for the vulnerable. Knowledge of God is shown in justice.

Then the shepherds. God accuses the leaders of scattering his flock. But he will gather the remnant himself and give them shepherds who will feed them. And then the promise: “I will raise up for David a righteous Branch.” This king will reign wisely and do justice. His name is “The LORD is our righteousness.” Zedekiah means “The LORD is my righteousness,” but the last king of Judah did not live up to his name. The Branch will.

The chapter then attacks the false prophets who speak visions of their own minds and say, “It shall be well with you.” They have not stood in the council of the LORD. God’s word is like fire and like a hammer.

Chapter 24 gives a vision of two baskets of figs: good figs and bad. The surprise is who is who. The good figs are the exiles in Babylon, and the bad figs are those left in Jerusalem. God says the exiles are his remnant: “I will build them up, and not tear down.” “I will give them a heart to know that I am the LORD.” What looks like judgment is the path to new life.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 1:21 gives the name Jesus: he will save his people. 1 Corinthians 1:30 says Christ became for us righteousness. Ezekiel 34 develops the shepherd image, and Jesus fulfills it in John 10:11. Matthew 7:15-20 warns about false prophets who are known by their fruit. Philippians 2:12-13 says God works in us to will and to do his good pleasure. Romans 8:28 says that God works all things for good.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your knowledge of God is shown in how you treat the poor and needy, as Jeremiah says it should be.

Pray for church leaders to be faithful shepherds, and for your own shepherding of those in your care.

Consider a season in your life that seemed like exile. How did God use it to give you a heart to know him?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is our righteousness.

Thank him for the righteous Branch of David.

Ask him to give his people shepherds after his own heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 438 · WEEK 63

Jeremiah 25:1-27:22

The cup of wrath; false prophets; the yoke of Babylon

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 25:1-27:22. Jeremiah announces seventy years of captivity, passes a cup of wrath to the nations, and nearly loses his life for the temple sermon. Then he wears a wooden yoke. Look for what God says about Nebuchadnezzar.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 25 dates to 605 BC, the fourth year of Jehoiakim, the year of the Battle of Carchemish when Babylon became the dominant power and Nebuchadnezzar took the first exiles, including Daniel. Chapter 26 records the trial that followed the temple sermon. Chapter 27 jumps to the reign of Zedekiah, with Jeremiah wearing a yoke of straps and bars, a living picture of submission to Babylon.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “For twenty-three years… the word of the LORD has come to me, and I have spoken persistently to you, but you have not listened” (25:3).
2. “Behold, I will send for all the tribes of the north… and for Nebuchadnezzar the king of Babylon, my servant” (25:9).
3. “This whole land shall become a ruin and a waste, and these nations shall serve the king of Babylon seventy years” (25:11).
4. “Take from my hand this cup of the wine of wrath” (25:15).
5. “You will surely die! … This man deserves the sentence of death” (26:8, 11).
6. “Behold, I am in your hands. Do with me as seems good and right to you. Only know for certain that if you put me to death, you will bring innocent blood upon yourselves”

(26:14-15).

7. “Make yourself straps and yoke bars, and put them on your neck” (27:2).

8. “But any nation that will bring its neck under the yoke of the king of Babylon and serve him, I will leave on its own land” (27:11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 25 is the summary of Jeremiah’s ministry so far. For twenty-three years he spoke and the people did not listen. Now God declares the sentence: seventy years of Babylonian rule. Remarkably, he calls Nebuchadnezzar “my servant.” The pagan king is a tool in God’s hand, used for his purposes. After the seventy years, Babylon too will be judged. Daniel would later read this passage in prayer (Daniel 9:2).

God then gives Jeremiah a cup of the wine of his wrath to pass to all the nations. The picture is of a drunken stagger. No one is exempt, from Jerusalem to Egypt to Sheshach, a code word for Babylon. Judgment begins with God’s own people (“the city that is called by my name”) and extends to everyone.

Chapter 26 shows what it costs Jeremiah to preach this. The priests and prophets demand his death. But the officials and some elders defend him, pointing to Micah, who prophesied judgment in Hezekiah’s day and was not killed, because the king repented. Jeremiah’s calm defense is moving. He is in their hands, but he warns them not to shed innocent blood. The word of God does not change to suit the listener.

Chapter 27 is the yoke. He wears it publicly and sends models to the neighboring kings. His message: serve Babylon, and live. False prophets say that the vessels of the temple will soon come back. Jeremiah says that they will go. It is the harder message because it is true. Faith here means accepting what God says even when popular prophets say otherwise.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 9:2 says that Daniel understood from the books the number of years that must pass for the desolation of Jerusalem, “seventy years.” Isaiah 51:17 and Revelation 14:10 use the cup of wrath imagery. Jesus prayed in Gethsemane, “Let this cup pass from me” (Matthew 26:39), and drank it for us. Romans 13:1 says that governing authorities are instituted by God. Acts 5:29 says we must obey God rather than men.

STEP 6

Application

Consider whether you resist a hard message because it is not what you want to hear. Ask God for ears to hear.

Remember that God can use a Nebuchadnezzar. Look for how he is using something you did not choose.

Pray for courage like Jeremiah's before an angry crowd.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you ears to hear his word even when it is hard.
- Thank Jesus for drinking the cup of wrath for you.
- Pray for nations and leaders.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 439 · WEEK 63

Jeremiah 28:1-29:32

Hananiah; the letter to the exiles, seek the city's peace

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 28:1-29:32. A false prophet breaks Jeremiah's yoke, and Jeremiah writes a letter to the exiles. Pay close attention to 29:4-14. This is one of the most important passages in the Bible on how to live in a foreign place.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In 594 BC, a few years after the first exile, a prophet named Hananiah announced in the temple that Babylon's power would be broken in two years. Jeremiah answered, and then Hananiah died. Meanwhile, the exiles in Babylon were being told by false prophets that their stay would be short. Jeremiah sent them a letter with a different message: settle in, because you will be there for seventy years.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Thus says the LORD of hosts… I have broken the yoke of the king of Babylon" (28:2).
2. "Amen! May the LORD do so" (28:6).
3. "The prophet who prophesies peace, when the word of that prophet comes to pass, then it will be known that the LORD has truly sent the prophet" (28:9).
4. "You have broken wooden bars, but you have made in their place bars of iron" (28:13).
5. "Build houses and live in them; plant gardens and eat their produce. Take wives and have sons and daughters" (29:5-6).
6. "But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the LORD on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare" (29:7).

7. “For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope” (29:11).

8. “You will seek me and find me, when you seek me with all your heart” (29:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Hananiah’s prophecy was exactly what the people wanted to hear. Jeremiah’s first response is irony: “Amen! May the LORD do so.” He would love for the prophecy to be true. But he reminds Hananiah that true prophets have always spoken of war, famine, and plague, and a message of peace must be proved by its fulfillment. Hananiah breaks the wooden yoke from Jeremiah’s neck, and God replaces it with one of iron. Hananiah dies within two months. A message that contradicts God’s word is not only wrong but dangerous.

Chapter 29 is the exiles’ letter. It must have been a surprise. They were hoping to go home soon. Instead, Jeremiah says to settle: build houses, plant gardens, marry, and have children. Do not shrink. Even more surprising: “Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the LORD on its behalf.” Pray for Babylon! Because in its welfare is your welfare. The people of God are called to be faithful and good neighbors in a place that is not their home.

Then comes the famous promise, 29:11, so often quoted alone. Read in context, it is not a promise of quick comfort. It was given to people who would spend seventy years in exile. The plans are for welfare and a future, but the timeline is long. The next verses give the way: call on me, pray, seek me with all your heart, and I will be found.

This is an important teaching for all Christians, since we are exiles and sojourners. We are not to withdraw, and we are not to be absorbed. We are to build, plant, pray, and wait for the promised return.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Peter 2:11-17 calls believers “sojourners and exiles” who are to honor everyone and live good lives among the Gentiles. 1 Timothy 2:1-2 urges prayer for kings and all in authority. Matthew 7:15-23 warns against false prophets. Hebrews 11:13-16 says that the faithful were strangers and exiles on the earth, seeking a better country. John 17:15-18 shows Jesus praying that his disciples be kept in the world, not removed from it.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for your city and its leaders by name this week, including those you disagree with.

Think about how you can build and plant where you are rather than waiting for something better.

Read Jeremiah 29:11 with 29:10 and 29:13, and trust that God's plans are long and good.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for his plans for welfare and a future and hope.
- Ask him to teach you to seek the welfare of where you live.
- Ask him for patience in the waiting.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 440 · WEEK 63

Psalm 106

We have sinned like our fathers

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 106. It is a long review of Israel's history of rebellion, from the Red Sea to the exile, told as a confession. You have seen this theme in earlier units. This time read it as a prayer from within the exile.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 106 is a companion to Psalm 105, which told the story of God's faithfulness. This psalm tells the story of the people's unfaithfulness. It ends with a prayer from the exile, "Save us, O LORD our God, and gather us from among the nations." It closes Book 4 of the Psalter with a doxology. It is a good psalm to pray with Jeremiah, because it confesses the very sin he accuses.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever!" (v. 1).
2. "Both we and our fathers have sinned; we have committed iniquity; we have done wickedly" (v. 6).
3. "Yet he saved them for his name's sake, that he might make known his mighty power" (v. 8).
4. "But they soon forgot his works; they did not wait for his counsel" (v. 13).
5. "They exchanged the glory of God for the image of an ox that eats grass" (v. 20).
6. "Therefore he said he would destroy them, had not Moses, his chosen one, stood in the breach before him" (v. 23).

7. “They served their idols, which became a snare to them. They sacrificed their sons and their daughters to the demons” (vv. 36-37).

8. “Save us, O LORD our God, and gather us from among the nations, that we may give thanks to your holy name and glory in your praise” (v. 47).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins as praise but quickly becomes confession. “Both we and our fathers have sinned.” The writer does not blame the fathers or hide behind history. He includes himself. And he goes through the story: at the Red Sea, the people forgot the miracles. In the wilderness, they craved meat and tested God. At Sinai, they made a golden calf. At the border of Canaan, they refused to enter. At Baal-peor, they joined in the worship of Baal. At Meribah, they provoked Moses. In the land, they mingled with the nations, worshiped their idols, and even sacrificed their children.

The pattern is repeated, and so is God’s response. Again and again, he saves “for his name’s sake.” He hears their cry. He remembers his covenant and relents “according to the abundance of his steadfast love.” Even when he disciplines, he shows compassion. The turning point in several stories is a mediator: Moses stood in the breach, and Phinehas stood up and intervened.

In the context of the exile, the psalm is the historical confession of a generation that realizes where it stands. The nation did not suddenly fall. It was the end of a long habit. And yet the closing prayer is a hopeful one: “Save us, O LORD our God, and gather us from among the nations.” The psalmist asks for what God has always done: save for his name’s sake.

The psalm ends with a doxology: “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting! And let all the people say, Amen!” The history of failure does not silence praise.

STEP 5

Connection

Stephen’s speech in Acts 7 retells the same history, showing the persistent resistance to the Holy Spirit. 1 Corinthians 10:1-12 uses the wilderness stories as warnings: “These things happened to them as an example.” Romans 1:23 echoes verse 20: exchanging the glory of God for images. Hebrews 7:25 says that Jesus always lives to make intercession, the greater Moses who stands in the breach.

STEP 6

Application

Practice the kind of confession this psalm models: name specific sins, and include yourself in the patterns of your family, church, and culture.

Thank God for the mediators who have stood in the breach for you, and for Christ above all.

Pray the last verse for scattered believers around the world.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess your own forgetting of God's works.
- Thank him for saving you for his name's sake.
- Thank him for the greater Mediator who stands in the breach.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 441 · WEEK 63

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jeremiah 29:11 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

REST

Meditation

This is one of the most quoted verses in the Bible, and it is often quoted out of context. To hear it as Jeremiah's first readers did, remember who it was written to.

It was written to exiles, people who had lost their city, their temple, and their king. They were in a foreign land with no sign of returning. False prophets were telling them it would be over soon. Then Jeremiah's letter arrived, and it said that they would be there for seventy years. After that, this promise: "For I know the plans I have for you."

The first thing it says is that God has plans. The exile was not an accident. It was part of what he was doing. The second is that he knows them. We often do not know the plans, and we do not need to, because he knows them. The third is that they are "plans for welfare," shalom, wholeness, "and not for evil." The word for evil is the word for calamity. The exile looked like calamity, but God's purpose was good.

Finally, “to give you a future and a hope.” The future is real. The hope is not a wish but an expectation based on God’s word. In the same chapter, God says he will bring them back. The promise does not remove the seventy years. It gives them meaning.

This verse does not promise an easy life. It promises that the one who holds your future is good. For Christians, the ultimate fulfillment is in Christ, in whom all of God’s promises are “Yes.” Say this verse when you do not know what comes next.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed Jeremiah through the rest of his early ministry. You read the king’s last warnings and the promise of a righteous Branch whose name is “The LORD is our righteousness.” You saw the vision of two baskets of figs, in which the exiles were the good figs. You read about the cup of wrath, the seventy years, the yoke of Babylon, and the false prophet Hananiah. Then you read the letter to the exiles, which told them to build, plant, and seek the welfare of the city. You prayed Psalms 102 and 103, the cry of the afflicted and the praise of the God who removes our sins as far as the east is from the west, and Psalm 106, a history of rebellion and mercy. The week taught that God is sovereign over exile, that false hope is dangerous, and that his plans for his people are for welfare and a future.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jeremiah told the exiles to seek the welfare of Babylon. How can you seek the good of the place where God has put you this week?

Psalm 103 says God removes our transgressions as far as the east is from the west. Where do you still carry guilt that Christ has already carried?

The false prophets promised quick relief, and Jeremiah promised a long road with a sure hope. Which do you tend to want, and how does Jeremiah 29:11 speak to that?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his plans for your welfare and a future and a hope.

Ask him to teach you to seek the good of the place he has put you.

Rest in his faithfulness this Sabbath.

DAY 442 · WEEK 64

Psalm 107:1-22

He redeems from every adversity

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 107:1-22. It begins Book 5 of the Psalter, and it is a song for the redeemed, those gathered from the lands. Notice the refrain that repeats in each scene.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 107 opens the last book of the Psalms. It has no author but clearly looks back on the return from exile: "those he redeemed from trouble and gathered in from the lands." The psalm tells four stories of people in distress: wanderers, prisoners, the sick, and sailors. The first three are in today's reading. The psalm appears several times in this plan, with different parts. Here read it as a thanksgiving song for those who know what it is to be rescued.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever!" (v. 1).
2. "Let the redeemed of the LORD say so, whom he has redeemed from trouble and gathered in from the lands" (vv. 2-3).
3. "Some wandered in desert wastes... hungry and thirsty, their soul fainted within them" (vv. 4-5).
4. "Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress" (v. 6).
5. "Some sat in darkness and in the shadow of death, prisoners in affliction and in irons" (v. 10).

6. “He brought them out of darkness and the shadow of death, and burst their bonds apart” (v. 14).
7. “Some were fools through their sinful ways… they drew near to the gates of death” (vv. 17-18).
8. “He sent out his word and healed them, and delivered them from their destruction” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm follows a pattern in each of its stories. First, people are in trouble: lost, imprisoned, sick, or at sea. Second, they cry to the LORD in their trouble. Third, he delivers them. And fourth, a refrain: “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of men.” The repetition teaches us to see all rescue as grace.

The first group are wanderers. They are lost in the desert, hungry, with no city to dwell in. The exiles, scattered across Babylon, would have recognized themselves. God leads them by a straight way to a city to live in. The second are prisoners. They sit in darkness because they rebelled against the words of God. Their bondage is a result of sin. Yet when they cry, he breaks the doors of bronze and cuts the bars of iron. The third are the sick, “fools through their sinful ways,” who suffer affliction because of their iniquities. And again, when they cry, “he sent out his word and healed them.”

Notice the phrase, “He sent out his word and healed them.” The word of God is the instrument of healing. It reminds us of creation, where God spoke, and of the gospel, where Jesus speaks and the sick are healed.

Who are the redeemed? The psalm says: everyone who has been in distress and cried out. Not only Israel, but “the children of men.” Redemption in the Bible is not for the strong or the clean, but for those who cry.

The psalm ends this part with an invitation to offer thank offerings and “tell of his deeds in songs of joy.” Gratitude is the right response to rescue.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 8:5-13 shows Jesus healing the centurion’s servant with a word, as in verse 20. Luke 4:18 says Jesus came to proclaim liberty to the captives. Colossians 1:13 says God “has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son.” Ephesians 2:1-5 speaks of being dead in trespasses and made alive. Acts 16:25-26 shows prison doors opened as Paul and Silas prayed.

STEP 6

Application

Think about which of the four pictures fits your story: wanderer, prisoner, sick, or sailor. Thank God for his rescue.

Say the refrain aloud: “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love.”

Tell someone a story of God’s rescue in your life this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for a way he has redeemed you from adversity.
- Thank him that his steadfast love endures forever.
- Tell him whom you want to share this thanks with.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

“I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you.”

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 443 · WEEK 64

Jeremiah 30:1-31:40

The Book of Consolation, the New Covenant promise

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 30:1-31:40. This is the Book of Consolation, the center of Jeremiah and one of the most important passages in the Old Testament. Read chapter 31 slowly, especially verses 31 to 34. Today's reading contains the New Covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After many chapters of judgment, God tells Jeremiah to write in a book all the words he has spoken, and the tone turns to comfort. These chapters were probably written around 587 BC, as Jerusalem was under siege. They promise restoration, a return from exile, and above all, a new covenant. They are the hinge on which the whole unit turns, and the New Testament quotes them more than any other part of Jeremiah.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Alas! That day is so great there is none like it; it is a time of distress for Jacob; yet he shall be saved out of it" (30:7).
2. "They shall serve the LORD their God and David their king, whom I will raise up for them" (30:9).
3. "For I will restore health to you, and your wounds I will heal, declares the LORD" (30:17).
4. "I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you" (31:3).
5. "A voice is heard in Ramah, lamentation and bitter weeping. Rachel is weeping for her children" (31:15).

6. “Behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah” (31:31).

7. “I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people” (31:33).

8. “For I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more” (31:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 30 begins with distress, “a time of trouble for Jacob,” but quickly turns to salvation. God will break the yoke from their neck. They will serve the LORD and a king from David’s line. “For I will restore health to you.” The wound is incurable, but God says he will heal it. The people thought their situation was hopeless. God says that he is the one who made the wound, and he is the one who will heal it.

Chapter 31 opens with a love poem. “I have loved you with an everlasting love.” Before there was a covenant, there was love. “Therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you.” The exile has not ended his love. He promises to build them up again, with joy and dancing. The weeping at Ramah, where the exiles gathered on their way to Babylon, will turn to hope: “There is hope for your future.” Matthew later applies this verse to the weeping of Bethlehem’s mothers.

Then, in verses 31 to 34, the climax. A new covenant. It will not be like the covenant made at Sinai, which the people broke. This time, God himself will write the law on their hearts. The old covenant was written on stone and often kept externally. The new will be internal. There will be four promises: a new heart (“I will write it on their hearts”), a new relationship (“I will be their God, and they shall be my people”), a new knowledge (“they shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest”), and a new forgiveness (“I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more”).

The closing verses guarantee it. As certain as the sun, moon, and stars, God will not cast off Israel. The new covenant is as secure as creation. It is the heart of the gospel, and it is the memory verse of this unit.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said at the Last Supper, “This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood” (Luke 22:20). Hebrews 8:6-13 and 10:15-18 quote this passage in full, saying that Christ is the mediator of the new covenant. 2 Corinthians 3:3-6 says believers are “a letter from Christ… written not with ink but with the Spirit.” Matthew 2:17-18 quotes Jeremiah 31:15. Romans 11:26-27 speaks of the covenant with Israel.

STEP 6

Application

Take Jeremiah 31:33 with you, and ask what it means that God writes rather than demands.

Take the cup at the Lord's Supper, and see in it the fulfillment of verse 31.

Ask God to write his law on your heart, so that obedience becomes your desire.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he has loved you with an everlasting love.
- Thank him for the new covenant sealed in Jesus' blood.
- Ask him to write his law on your heart so that obedience becomes your desire.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

"I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you."

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 444 · WEEK 64

Jeremiah 32:1-33:26

Jeremiah buys a field; the Branch of David

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 32:1-33:26. While Babylon is besieging the city, God tells Jeremiah to buy a field. Read it as an act of faith. Then read the promise of the Branch and the covenant with David and the Levites.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is 587 BC, the tenth year of Zedekiah. Jerusalem is under siege, and Jeremiah is imprisoned in the court of the guard for predicting its fall. God tells him that his cousin will come and offer to sell him the family field at Anathoth, which is now in enemy territory. He buys it. The scene is among the most striking acts of faith in Scripture.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Buy my field that is at Anathoth, for you have the right of redemption by purchase" (32:7).
2. "I signed the deed, sealed it, got witnesses, and weighed the money on scales" (32:10).
3. "Ah, Lord GOD! It is you who have made the heavens and the earth by your great power... Nothing is too hard for you" (32:17).
4. "Behold, I am the LORD, the God of all flesh. Is anything too hard for me?" (32:27).
5. "I will make with them an everlasting covenant, that I will not turn away from doing good to them" (32:40).
6. "Fields shall be bought in this land of which you are saying, It is a desolation" (32:43).
7. "Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known" (33:3).

8 “In those days and at that time I will cause a righteous Branch to spring up for David” (33:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jeremiah’s act is a visible sermon. The Babylonian army is at the gate. Anyone who buys land in the country is wasting money. But God says: buy it. The deed is signed, sealed, witnessed, and placed in a clay jar to last a long time. The meaning: “Houses and fields and vineyards shall again be bought in this land.” Jeremiah invests in a future he cannot see. His purchase is a pledge of God’s promise.

Afterward, Jeremiah prays, and he is honest about his confusion. “Behold, the siege mounds have come up to the city… and the city is given into the hands of the Chaldeans. What you spoke has come to pass, and behold, you see it. Yet you, O Lord GOD, have said to me, Buy the field.” How can both be true? God answers with a question: “Is anything too hard for me?” He confirms the judgment, but promises restoration. “I will gather them from all the countries.” He will give them one heart and one way, “that they may fear me forever.” And again the promise of the everlasting covenant, “that I will not turn away from doing good to them.”

Chapter 33 continues the theme from a prison. God says, “Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things.” It is a promise to those who pray in impossible situations. The city will be healed and cleansed. The sounds of joy and gladness will return, “the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride,” and of those who bring thank offerings.

The center is the promise of the Branch: “I will cause a righteous Branch to spring up for David.” The covenant with David will not fail. As sure as day and night, God’s promises stand. Even in the siege, Jeremiah’s hope is not in the army but in the word of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:37 says, “For nothing will be impossible with God,” echoing Jeremiah 32:17 and 27. Mark 10:27 says that all things are possible with God. Hebrews 11:1 says faith is the assurance of things hoped for. Jeremiah’s purchase of the field fits Ephesians 1:13-14, where the Spirit is the guarantee of our inheritance. Romans 4:17-21 describes Abraham believing against hope. Psalm 50:15 invites us to call on God in the day of trouble.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where God may be asking you to act in faith toward a future you cannot yet see.

Memorize Jeremiah 33:3 and pray it in a situation that seems impossible.

Pray the question, “Is anything too hard for the LORD?” for a specific need.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that nothing is too hard for him, and name the thing you have been afraid to ask.

Ask him to teach you to “buy fields” in faith, trusting his promises.

Thank him for the Branch of David.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

“I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you.”

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 445 · WEEK 64

Jeremiah 34:1-36:32

Zedekiah; the Rechabites; Baruch's scroll burned

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 84 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 34:1-36:32. The king breaks a covenant to free slaves. A family called the Rechabites keeps its vow. And King Jehoiakim burns Jeremiah's scroll in a fire. Read these three stories as a contrast between faithful and unfaithful responses to God's word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters are arranged by theme, not chronology. Chapter 34 is during the siege, when Zedekiah freed the slaves as a covenant and then took them back. Chapters 35 and 36 go back to the days of Jehoiakim, about 605 BC. They show a series of contrasts: a nation that would not keep its word, a clan that did, and a king who could not bear to hear God's word.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You recently repented and did what was right in my eyes... but then you turned around and profaned my name when each of you took back his male servant and his female servant" (34:15-16).
2. "You have not obeyed me by proclaiming liberty, every one to his brother" (34:17).
3. "The Rechabites, the descendants of Jonadab the son of Rechab, have kept the command that their father gave them, but this people has not obeyed me" (35:16).
4. "Because you have obeyed the command of Jonadab your father... Jonadab the son of Rechab shall never lack a man to stand before me" (35:18-19).
5. "Take a scroll and write on it all the words that I have spoken to you" (36:2).

6. “It may be that the house of Judah will hear all the disaster that I intend to do to them” (36:3).
7. “Neither the king nor any of his servants who heard all these words was afraid, nor did they tear their garments” (36:24).
8. “Then Jeremiah took another scroll and gave it to Baruch… who wrote on it all the words of the scroll that Jehoiakim king of Judah had burned in the fire” (36:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In chapter 34, the people showed a flash of obedience. Under siege, they freed their Hebrew slaves, as the law of Exodus 21 and Deuteronomy 15 required. They made a covenant in the temple, passing between the pieces of a calf. Then, when the Babylonian army withdrew for a moment, they took the slaves back. They had made a vow and broken it. God’s reaction is sharp: they profaned his name. The punishment fits the crime: you did not proclaim liberty, so I proclaim liberty to the sword, the pestilence, and the famine.

Chapter 35 offers a contrast. The Rechabites were a clan who, for generations, had obeyed their ancestor’s rule not to drink wine or build houses. Jeremiah sets wine before them in the temple and invites them to drink. They refuse. They have kept the word of a human father for two hundred years. And God says: you, my people, have not kept the word of your divine Father, spoken persistently. The point is not that abstaining from wine is holy, but that obedience to a spoken word is possible. If a family can keep a command for generations, God’s people should be able to keep his.

In chapter 36, Baruch writes Jeremiah’s words on a scroll and reads it in the temple. Officials are afraid and report it to the king. Jehoiakim sits by the fire in the winter house, and as the scroll is read he cuts it up with a knife and throws it in the fire, column by column. The contrast with Josiah, who tore his clothes at the Book of the Law, could not be clearer. But burning the scroll does not destroy the word. God tells Jeremiah to write it again “and many similar words were added to them.” The word of the LORD is indestructible.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 40:8 says, “The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God will stand forever.” Matthew 24:35: “Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away.” Hebrews 4:12 says the word of God is living and active. John 14:15 says, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” James 1:22 says to be doers of the word. Luke 4:18-19 shows Jesus proclaiming liberty to captives.

STEP 6

Application

Examine whether there is a commitment you have made to God or to others that you have taken back.

Ask what you could do to be as faithful to God's word as the Rechabites were to their father's.

Pray for the preservation and spread of Scripture, and thank God for your own copy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his word cannot be burned.

Confess vows you have broken.

Ask him to make you faithful in the small commitments.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

"I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you."

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 446 · WEEK 64

Jeremiah 37:1-39:18

Jeremiah in the cistern; Jerusalem falls; he is freed

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 59 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 37:1-39:18. These are the chapters of the final siege. Jeremiah is arrested, thrown into a cistern, rescued by a foreigner, and finally freed when Jerusalem falls. Read it as a story of faithfulness costing everything and being vindicated.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The final siege of Jerusalem lasted about eighteen months, from 588 to 586 BC. Jeremiah was accused of deserting to the enemy because he told people to surrender. He was beaten and imprisoned. The officials then dropped him into a muddy cistern to die. Chapter 39 records the city's fall, which the prophet had announced for forty years.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You are going over to the Chaldeans!" (37:13).
2. "Is there any word from the LORD? ... There is... You shall be delivered into the hand of the king of Babylon" (37:17).
3. "Then they took Jeremiah and cast him into the cistern... and Jeremiah sank in the mud" (38:6).
4. "Ebed-melech the Ethiopian, a eunuch... went from the king's house and said to the king, My lord the king, these men have done evil in all that they did to Jeremiah" (38:7-9).
5. "Obey now the voice of the LORD in what I say to you, and it shall be well with you" (38:20).
6. "In the ninth year of Zedekiah... a breach was made in the city" (39:1-2).

7. “The king of Babylon slaughtered the sons of Zedekiah at Riblah before his eyes… and put out the eyes of Zedekiah” (39:6-7).

8. “I will deliver you on that day, declares the LORD… because you have put your trust in me” (39:17-18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Zedekiah is the central tragic figure. He is afraid of the officials, afraid of the people, and afraid of the Babylonians. He wants Jeremiah’s counsel but will not follow it. He meets the prophet secretly and asks, “Is there any word from the LORD?” The answer is the same: surrender. “If you will go out… your life shall be spared.” But the fear of men is a snare. He says, “I am afraid of the Judeans who have deserted to the Chaldeans.” The king who might have saved the city is paralyzed.

The cistern scene is vivid. The officials, angry that Jeremiah is weakening morale, drop him in a muddy pit to die. He sinks into the mire. It is a picture of a righteous person abandoned. Then comes an unlikely rescuer: Ebed-melech, an Ethiopian official in the palace. He risks his own position to speak to the king, and he pulls Jeremiah out with ropes padded with old rags so that they do not cut his arms. A foreigner shows more mercy than the leaders of God’s people. He is promised in return: “I will surely save you.”

Chapter 39 is the long-awaited end. The wall is breached, the temple burned, Zedekiah’s sons killed before his eyes, and then his eyes put out. The prophet’s words come true in detail. Yet the Babylonian commander treats Jeremiah kindly. He is released and stays among the poor who are left in the land.

The story shows that faithfulness to God’s word can be costly, and that vindication, though sometimes slow, is sure. And it shows how God honors acts of faith and mercy, even from an outsider.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus was condemned by religious leaders who feared the people (Luke 22:2), and by Pilate who feared the crowd (John 19:12-16). A foreigner, Simon of Cyrene, carried his cross (Luke 23:26). Matthew 25:40 says that what you do for the least of these you do for him. Acts 8:26-39 records an Ethiopian official’s conversion. Proverbs 29:25 says, “The fear of man lays a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is safe.”

STEP 6

Application

Ask where the fear of man holds you back from obeying God.

Be an Ebed-melech this week: act on behalf of someone who is being treated unjustly, even at some cost.

Remember Jeremiah when you are faithful and it costs you. God sees.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the fear of man that has trapped you.
- Ask him for courage like Jeremiah's and compassion like Ebed-melech's.
- Thank him for delivering his servants.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

"I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you."

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 447 · WEEK 64

Psalm 107:23-43

Those who go down to the sea

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 107:23-43. Here are the sailors in the storm, and then a series of reversals in which God turns deserts into pools and the proud into the humble. Notice how the psalm ends with a wisdom saying.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second half of Psalm 107, which you began five days ago. The first half told of wanderers, prisoners, and the sick. This half begins with the sailors and then moves to a hymn of reversals. It is a fitting close to the story of Jeremiah's siege and fall, since it shows God as the one who humbles the proud and lifts the lowly. The psalm will return again later in the plan.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Some went down to the sea in ships, doing business on the great waters" (v. 23).
2. "They saw the deeds of the LORD, his wondrous works in the deep" (v. 24).
3. "He commanded and raised the stormy wind, which lifted up the waves of the sea" (v. 25).
4. "They reeled and staggered like drunken men and were at their wits" end' (v. 27).
5. "Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress. He made the storm be still" (vv. 28-29).
6. "Then they were glad that need be still, and he brought them to their desired haven" (v. 30).
7. "He turns rivers into a desert, springs of water into thirsty ground" (v. 33).

8 “Whoever is wise, let him attend to these things; let them consider the steadfast love of the LORD” (v. 43).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sailors are the fourth group. Unlike the others, they are not in trouble by sin or by accident. They are doing their work, “doing business on the great waters,” and a storm comes. God himself “commanded and raised the stormy wind.” This reminds us that not all trouble is a punishment for sin. Sometimes God brings storms to show his deeds in the deep. The sailors reel like drunks and their courage melts. They are at their wits’ end, literally, “all their wisdom was swallowed up.” Then they cry out, and he stills the storm to a whisper. The haven they long for is his gift.

From verse 33, the psalm shifts to a broader picture of God’s rule. He turns rivers into deserts and deserts into pools. The change depends on the moral condition of the people: a fruitful land becomes salt because of the wickedness of its inhabitants. And he settles the hungry in a desert turned to pools. He blesses them so that they multiply. This is God’s rule of reversal: he brings princes into contempt and lifts the needy out of affliction and makes their families like flocks.

The statement in verse 42 is clear: “The upright see it and are glad, and all wickedness shuts its mouth.” The psalm closes with a wisdom call. “Whoever is wise, let him attend to these things.” The wise person reads history and life as the story of God’s steadfast love. In the context of the exile, the lesson is that the return will be a work of God, in the same pattern of rescue after crying out.

All four of the psalm’s stories describe the same truth: when we are at our wits’ end, we can cry out to the LORD, and he hears.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus calmed the storm with a word: “Peace! Be still!” (Mark 4:39), and the disciples asked, “Who then is this?” Psalm 107:29 gives the answer: the LORD. Jesus walked on water (Matthew 14:22-33). Luke 1:52-53 echoes the reversals: he has brought down the mighty and exalted the humble. 2 Corinthians 1:8-10 describes being so utterly burdened that we despaired of life, and God delivering us.

STEP 6

Application

Think about a storm you are in. Pray, “Lord, I am at my wits” end,’ and ask him to still it.

Consider that not every storm is a punishment. Look for what God may be showing you in it.

Take time to “attend to these things” by reviewing the rescues of this psalm, and thank God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God about the storm you are in and that you are at your wits’ end.
- Ask him to bring you to your desired haven.
- Thank Jesus, who stilled the storm.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

“I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you.”

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 448 · WEEK 64

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jeremiah 31:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you."

JEREMIAH 31:3

REST

Meditation

This verse stands at the front of the great chapter of the new covenant. It is spoken to a people who have just lost everything. They had broken the covenant, and the covenant curses had fallen. Here is what God says first: "I have loved you."

"I have loved you with an everlasting love." The word "everlasting" goes back before time and extends beyond it. It is not a love that began when Israel obeyed or ended when they failed. It was there before they did anything. Paul says the same of believers: God chose us in Christ before the foundation of the world. His love is not based on our performance.

"Therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you." The word "therefore" is important. Because of his love, he continues to be faithful. The word for "continued" means to draw out or extend, like drawing a long line. God has stretched his faithfulness over the whole history of their rebellion. He has not given up. Judgment was a form of faithfulness to the covenant, and the promise of restoration is too.

Think of the context. The exiles heard this in Babylon. They might have thought that God's love had ended with the destruction of the temple. This verse says no. The love is everlasting. The exile does not change it.

For the Christian, the cross is the proof. "God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us." Romans 8:38-39 says that nothing can separate us from the love of God. Say this verse whenever you doubt that you are loved.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the heart of Jeremiah: the Book of Consolation. You read the promise of a new covenant, in which God will write his law on the hearts of his people, bring them all to know him, and forgive their sin and remember it no more. You read of Jeremiah's purchase of a field while the Babylonians besieged the city, a picture of faith in a future he could not see. You watched King Zedekiah's fear of men, Jeremiah in the cistern, and Ebed-melech's courage. You saw the Rechabites keep their vow, and a king burn God's word in a fire while the word survived. And you finished the first part with the fall of Jerusalem. In the psalms, you prayed Psalm 107, a song for the redeemed from every kind of trouble. The week taught that God keeps his promises even when everything seems lost, and that his love is everlasting.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The new covenant promises that God will write his law on our hearts. What part of obedience still feels like an outward duty to you rather than a desire, and how might you ask God to change that?

Jeremiah bought a field when the city was falling. What step of faith might God be asking you to take toward a future you cannot see?

Psalm 107 asks the redeemed to say so. Whose story of rescue could you tell this week, and who needs to hear it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his everlasting love and continued faithfulness.

Thank him for the new covenant in Jesus' blood.

Rest in him today.

DAY 449 · WEEK 65

Psalm 108

My heart is steadfast, O God

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 108. It is a psalm made of two earlier psalms, joined together. Notice the confident praise at the beginning and the honest need at the end.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 108 is a psalm of David, made from parts of two other psalms: verses 1 to 5 are almost identical to Psalm 57:7-11, and verses 6 to 13 are almost identical to Psalm 60:5-12. This was used in worship as a song for a nation facing enemies and hoping for God's help. It is a fitting prayer after the fall of Jerusalem, since it begins with praise and ends with trust in God alone when human help fails.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "My heart is steadfast, O God! I will sing and make melody with all my being!" (v. 1).
2. "Awake, O harp and lyre! I will awake the dawn!" (v. 2).
3. "I will give thanks to you, O LORD, among the peoples" (v. 3).
4. "For your steadfast love is great above the heavens; your faithfulness reaches to the clouds" (v. 4).
5. "Be exalted, O God, above the heavens! Let your glory be over all the earth!" (v. 5).
6. "That your beloved ones may be delivered, give salvation by your right hand and answer me!" (v. 6).
7. "Have you not rejected us, O God? You do not go out, O God, with our armies" (v. 11).
8. "Through God we will do valiantly; it is he who will tread down our foes" (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a vow. “My heart is steadfast.” The word means firm, fixed, established. Whatever is happening around him, his heart is anchored in God. And the result is song, with all his being. He even says he will wake the dawn, rather than waiting for morning to wake him. His praise is not tied to circumstances.

The praise then widens to include the nations: “among the peoples… among the nations.” God’s steadfast love is above the heavens, and so his praise must be heard everywhere. The psalmist’s confidence rests on God’s character. Notice the two terms again: steadfast love and faithfulness. They are the pillars of God’s covenant.

Then the psalm shifts to prayer and to a series of divine promises. God has spoken in his holiness: he will divide Shechem, measure the Valley of Succoth, and claim Gilead, Manasseh, Ephraim, and Judah. Moab is his washbasin, Edom his slave. These are the promises of the land, spoken to David. God will give victory.

But the last part is honest. “Who will lead me to the fortified city? Who will lead me to Edom? Have you not rejected us, O God?” The psalmist admits that the people are in trouble, that God does not seem to be going out with their armies. He pleads: “Oh grant us help against the foe, for vain is the salvation of man!” Human help fails. “Through God we will do valiantly.” The psalm ends with a statement of faith in the middle of weakness.

This is a good prayer for the exile and for every believer who is both confident and needy. We can praise the God whose love is above the heavens even as we ask for help in a world where our own strength fails.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 108’s praise among the nations is picked up in Romans 15:9-11. Ephesians 3:20 says God is able to do far more abundantly than all that we ask or think. Philippians 4:13 says, “I can do all things through him who strengthens me.” Psalm 20:7 says some trust in chariots, but we trust in the name of the LORD. John 15:5 says that apart from Christ we can do nothing.

STEP 6

Application

Start tomorrow morning with the vow of verse 2: “I will awake the dawn.” Sing or pray aloud before anything else.

Trust God, not human help, in an area where you have been leaning on your own plans.

Praise the LORD among someone who does not know him, by telling them one thing he has done.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God your heart is steadfast, or ask him to make it so.
- Sing or speak your praise to him in your own words.
- Ask him to be exalted above the heavens.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 450 · WEEK 65

Jeremiah 40:1-42:22

Gedaliah the governor; the people ask Jeremiah

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 59 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 40:1-42:22. After Jerusalem falls, a Babylonian-appointed governor is murdered, and the survivors ask Jeremiah what to do. Read their promise to obey in chapter 42, and notice what happens in chapter 43, which you will read tomorrow.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the destruction of 586 BC, Nebuchadnezzar appointed a Jewish governor, Gedaliah, at Mizpah to oversee the people who remained. Jeremiah chose to stay with them. Then a member of the royal family, Ishmael, assassinated Gedaliah and others. The remaining leaders were afraid of Babylonian reprisal and thought of fleeing to Egypt. They came to Jeremiah and asked for God's guidance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The captain of the guard says, "The LORD your God pronounced this disaster against this place" (40:2).
2. Jeremiah chooses to stay: "Jeremiah went to Gedaliah... and lived with him among the people who were left in the land" (40:6).
3. "But Gedaliah the son of Ahikam would not believe them" (40:16).
4. Ishmael kills Gedaliah (41:2).
5. "Let the LORD your God show us the way we should go, and the thing that we should do" (42:3).
6. "Whether it is pleasant or unpleasant, we will obey the voice of the LORD our God" (42:6).

7. “If you will remain in this land, then I will build you up and not pull you down” (42:10).
8. “Do not go to Egypt… I solemnly warn you this day that you have gone astray at the cost of your lives” (42:19-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Babylonian captain gives Jeremiah a choice: come to Babylon and be cared for, or stay in the land. Jeremiah stays with the poor. He had been faithful to God’s word in the city, and he stays faithful among the remnant. For a moment, there is hope. Gedaliah, a good man who protects the people, calls them to settle, serve Babylon, and gather the harvest of the land. The people return from the countries where they had fled, and for a short time there is a summer harvest of wine and fruit.

Then Ishmael, who had been warned, murders Gedaliah at a meal. The murder of the governor and the group around him is shocking, and Ishmael kills pilgrims on their way to the temple as well. Johanan rescues the captives, but he fears Babylon’s reaction.

Johanan and the people come to Jeremiah. Their request sounds pious: “Pray for us to the LORD your God… that the LORD your God may show us the way.” They promise to obey, whether it is good or bad. Jeremiah prays, and after ten days, God answers: stay. “Do not fear the king of Babylon.” If they stay, God will build them up. If they go to Egypt, the sword and famine they fear will follow them there.

The problem is in the heart. Jeremiah says, “You have deceived yourselves.” They had already decided to go to Egypt. They asked for God’s word, but they only wanted his approval. Asking for guidance when you have already decided is not seeking God. The promise to obey whatever he says is easy to make before you know the answer. True obedience begins when what God says is unwelcome.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said in Luke 6:46, “Why do you call me Lord, Lord, and not do what I tell you?” James 1:22-25 warns against hearing without doing. Proverbs 3:5-6 says to trust in the LORD with all your heart and to lean not on your own understanding. Matthew 7:21 says that not everyone who says “Lord, Lord” will enter the kingdom. John 7:17 says that anyone who wills to do God’s will shall know.

STEP 6

Application

Before you ask God for guidance on a decision, tell him honestly that you will obey whatever he says.

Notice whether you have already decided what you will do and are only asking for confirmation.

Be like Jeremiah this week: stay faithful in a hard place with those who have little.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to show you the way you should go.
- Tell him you will obey, whether pleasant or unpleasant.
- Ask him to keep you from deciding first and asking later.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 451 · WEEK 65

Jeremiah 43:1-45:5

Disobedience; the flight to Egypt; Baruch's consolation

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 43:1-45:5. The leaders refuse God's answer and flee to Egypt, taking Jeremiah with them. Then Jeremiah faces the people's idolatry in Egypt, and a short word is given to Baruch, his scribe. Read chapter 45 carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After God's answer in chapter 42, the leaders accuse Jeremiah of lying and carry off the whole remnant to Egypt. In Tahpanhes, a border town, they settle among other Judean refugees. Even there, they take up the worship of the Queen of Heaven. The prophet's last recorded sermons are directed at their stubbornness. Chapter 45 is a gentle word to Baruch, who had grown discouraged.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You are telling a lie. The LORD our God did not send you to say, Do not go to Egypt to live there" (43:2).
2. "So Johanan... and all the people did not obey the voice of the LORD" (43:4).
3. "Take some large stones and hide them in the mortar... in front of Pharaoh's palace in Tahpanhes" (43:9).
4. "Why do you provoke me to anger with the work of your hands, making offerings to other gods in the land of Egypt?" (44:8).
5. "We will not listen to you... we will do everything that we have vowed, make offerings to the queen of heaven" (44:16-17).
6. "For then we had plenty of bread, and prospered, and saw no disaster" (44:17).

7. “Behold, I am watching over them for disaster and not for good” (44:27).
8. “And do you seek great things for yourself? Seek them not, for behold, I am bringing disaster upon all flesh… but I will give you your life as a prize of war in all places to which you may go” (45:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The people’s refusal is blunt. Having asked for God’s word and promised to obey, they now call Jeremiah a liar. The sin of unbelief is compounded by the sin of disobedience. They go to Egypt, the land God had delivered them from. It is a reversal of the exodus. The prophet is taken with them, and even there he continues to speak.

God’s word comes in the form of a sign: Jeremiah buries stones in the pavement in front of Pharaoh’s palace and says that Nebuchadnezzar will set his throne over them. The refuge they chose will not hold.

In chapter 44, the people in Egypt are defiant. When Jeremiah reproaches them for their idolatry, they give a revealing response. They claim that when they worshiped the Queen of Heaven, they had food and no disaster. It was only when they stopped, in Josiah’s reform, that trouble came. This is a classic example of misreading history. They say that the gods worked and the LORD did not. They are reading their own lives with no reference to God’s word. They refuse to repent and vow to continue.

Against this, chapter 45 is a short, tender word to Baruch. He had been in the thick of the struggle with Jeremiah, writing the scrolls and being threatened. He is weary and says, “Woe is me! For the LORD has added sorrow to my pain.” God’s reply is gentle but firm: “Do you seek great things for yourself? Seek them not.” This is not a time for personal ambition. Yet there is a promise: your life will be spared. Baruch’s life is a quiet example of faithful service in a time of collapse.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 6:46-49 contrasts the person who hears and does not act with the one who builds on rock. Matthew 6:33 says to seek first the kingdom of God, which echoes “seek not great things.” Luke 9:23-25 says that whoever would save his life will lose it. Philippians 2:3-4 calls us to count others more significant than ourselves. Hebrews 3:12-13 warns against an evil, unbelieving heart.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you ever read your life only through your own experience and not through God's word.

Think about whether you are "seeking great things" for yourself. What would it mean to be content with faithful, hidden service?

Encourage someone who is faithfully serving in a quiet role.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from a hard heart that calls his word a lie.
- Ask him to teach you to read your life through his word.
- Thank him for his patience.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 452 · WEEK 65

Jeremiah 46:1-48:47

Oracles against Egypt and Moab [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 46:1-48:47. This is a survey day. These are oracles against Egypt, the Philistines, and Moab. Do not worry about every name. Read for the repeated message: God is Lord of the nations, and pride is judged.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapters 46 to 51 are Jeremiah's oracles against the nations. Like Isaiah 13-23 and Ezekiel 25-32, they place the story of Judah inside God's rule over the world. The first oracle is against Egypt, tied to the battle of Carchemish in 605 BC. The next ones concern the Philistines and Moab, with echoes of Isaiah's earlier oracles on Moab. These oracles show that no nation escapes God's judgment and that some of them receive a promise of restoration.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Who is this, rising like the Nile, like rivers whose waters surge?" (46:7).
2. "Egypt rises like the Nile... I will surely punish Amon of Thebes, and Pharaoh" (46:8, 25).
3. "But fear not, O Jacob my servant, nor be dismayed, O Israel" (46:27).
4. "I will make a full end of all the nations among whom I have scattered you, but of you I will not make a full end" (46:28).
5. "Because you trusted in your works and your treasures, you also shall be taken" (48:7).
6. "We have heard of the pride of Moab... his insolence, his pride, and his arrogance" (48:29).
7. "Cursed is he who does the work of the LORD with slackness" (48:10).
8. "Yet I will restore the fortunes of Moab in the latter days, declares the LORD" (48:47).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The oracle against Egypt begins with a military scene: the Egyptian army at Carchemish, preparing for battle, and then fleeing in defeat. “Who is this, rising like the Nile?” The question has the same shape as Isaiah’s against Babylon. Egypt rose in pride, as a flood that covers the earth, but the LORD is greater. The oracle ends in 46:27-28 with comfort for Israel: “Fear not, O Jacob my servant.” God will discipline in just measure, but will not destroy his people.

The oracle against the Philistines in chapter 47 pictures waters from the north that sweep over the land, and the cries of fathers who do not turn to help their children. It is a picture of utter terror.

Chapter 48 is a long lament over Moab, the nation descended from Lot and often hostile to Israel. The reason for its fall is stated clearly: it trusted in its works and treasures, and in its pride. “Moab has been at ease from his youth… like wine left on its dregs.” A people that has never been disturbed grows complacent. The prophet’s sorrow is real: “Therefore I wail for Moab; I cry out for all Moab.” This is no gloating.

Notice 48:10: “Cursed is he who does the work of the LORD with slackness.” It is a warning to the executioners of judgment, but also to everyone. The work of the LORD is serious.

The chapter ends with a surprise. “Yet I will restore the fortunes of Moab in the latter days.” Even this enemy nation has a future. The God who judges the nations is the God who will bring them back. Jeremiah’s prophecies of judgment are never the last word.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 18 and 19 draw on the oracles against the nations for the fall of Babylon. Colossians 3:23 says, “Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord.” Revelation 21:24-26 says that the nations will bring their glory into the new Jerusalem. Ruth, a Moabite, was an ancestor of David and Jesus (Matthew 1:5). Acts 17:26-27 says God made all nations that they should seek him.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for a nation that is facing disaster or war.

Consider whether you have grown complacent, like wine left on its dregs, from too much ease.

Do one thing for the Lord with wholehearted effort today and not in slackness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as God of all nations.
- Pray for those who suffer under proud powers.
- Ask him not to let you grow complacent.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 453 · WEEK 65

Jeremiah 49:1-51:64

Oracles against Ammon, Edom, Babylon [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 117 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 49:1-51:64. This is another survey day, with oracles against Ammon, Edom, Damascus, Elam, and above all, Babylon. Read the Babylon oracle for its main theme: the empire that destroyed Jerusalem will itself be destroyed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The long section of oracles ends with Babylon. Jeremiah's message to the exiles is that Babylon, God's instrument, will be punished for its own pride and cruelty. In 51:59-64, Jeremiah sends a scroll with Seraiah, a Judean official, who is to read the oracle in Babylon and then tie a stone to it and throw it into the Euphrates. Babylon fell in 539 BC, though not as dramatically as the prophecies suggest. The final fall is a symbol still awaited.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The pride of your heart has deceived you, you who live in the clefts of the rock" (49:16).
2. "I have heard a message from the LORD, and an envoy has been sent among the nations" (49:14).
3. "Declare among the nations and proclaim… Babylon is taken, Bel is put to shame, Merodach is dismayed" (50:2).
4. "In those days and in that time, declares the LORD, the people of Israel and the people of Judah shall come together, weeping as they come" (50:4).
5. "They shall ask the way to Zion, with faces turned toward it, saying, Come, let us join ourselves to the LORD in an everlasting covenant" (50:5).
6. "Their Redeemer is strong; the LORD of hosts is his name" (50:34).

7. “Babylon was a golden cup in the LORD’s hand, making all the earth drunken” (51:7).
8. “Flee from the midst of Babylon; let every one save his life!” (51:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The oracles against the nations in chapter 49 follow familiar notes. Edom’s pride in its mountain strongholds will not save it. “Though you make your nest as high as the eagle’s, from there I will bring you down.” Damascus and Hazor and Elam will also fall.

Chapters 50 and 51 are a long poem on Babylon. The great empire that carried God’s people into exile is now the target. The reason is stated: Babylon sinned against the LORD, the Holy One of Israel. It exulted in its destruction of his heritage. Its gods, Bel and Merodach, will be put to shame. God uses a nation from the north, the Medes and Persians, to do it. Babylon will become a desolation.

But the poem is also about Israel. In the middle of the destruction, there is a promise for God’s people: they will come together, weeping, and seek the way to Zion. “Come, let us join ourselves to the LORD in an everlasting covenant that will never be forgotten.” This is the language of the new covenant. The prophet says that their sins will be sought for and not found: “For I will pardon those whom I leave as a remnant.” The people are called to leave Babylon. “Flee from the midst of Babylon… Be not cut off in her punishment.”

The image of Babylon as a golden cup in the LORD’s hand shows God’s control. The empire was an instrument, and when it has done its work, it is broken. The scroll sunk in the Euphrates ends the prophecy with an act of faith: “Thus shall Babylon sink, to rise no more.” The last line of the section is simple: “Thus far are the words of Jeremiah.”

In Scripture, Babylon is more than a city. It becomes the symbol of the world system in opposition to God. Revelation echoes these chapters in its portrayal of the fall of Babylon the great.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 18:4 says, “Come out of her, my people, lest you take part in her sins,” echoing Jeremiah 51:45. Revelation 14:8 and 18:2 declare “Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great.” Revelation 18:21 describes a millstone thrown into the sea, like Jeremiah’s scroll. Hebrews 8:8-12 confirms the “everlasting covenant” in Christ. 2 Corinthians 6:17 calls us to come out and be separate.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what “Babylon” looks like in your context: a system or value that opposes God. How are you called to live as a faithful exile?

Join in the prayer of Jeremiah 50:5: “Come, let us join ourselves to the LORD in an everlasting covenant.”

Remember that no empire lasts forever. Place your hope in the kingdom of God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he is the Redeemer who judges proud powers.
- Ask him to help you come out of whatever he calls you to leave.
- Pray for his people living among empires.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

“Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known.”

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 454 · WEEK 65

Jeremiah 52:1-34

Jerusalem's fall retold, the historical anchor

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 52:1-34. This last chapter retells the fall of Jerusalem and ends with a spark of hope. It is almost the same as 2 Kings 24-25. Read it as the book's historical anchor, proof that everything Jeremiah said came true.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The book of Jeremiah ends with this appendix, taken from 2 Kings. It does not add new teaching. It confirms that the prophecies were fulfilled in history. The date, the details, and even the numbers of the exiles are recorded. It ends where 2 Kings ends, with Jehoiachin released from prison. The writer wanted to show the reader that God's word is reliable, and that the exile is not the end.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Zedekiah was twenty-one years old when he began to reign... And he did what was evil in the sight of the LORD" (52:1-2).
2. "For because of the anger of the LORD it came to the point in Jerusalem and Judah that he cast them out from his presence" (52:3).
3. "In the ninth year of his reign... Nebuchadnezzar... came with all his army against Jerusalem" (52:4).
4. "So the city was besieged till the eleventh year of King Zedekiah" (52:5).
5. "And he burned the house of the LORD and the king's house and all the houses of Jerusalem" (52:13).

6. “The Chaldeans broke the bronze pillars… and carried all the bronze to Babylon” (52:17).
7. “Thus Judah was taken into exile out of its land” (52:27).
8. “Jehoiachin king of Judah… was released from prison… and he dined regularly at the king’s table all the days of his life” (52:31-33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter is almost dry in its detail: the dates, the lists, the weights of the bronze. This is the point. The prophecies of Jeremiah were not vague. They were specific, and the specifics came true. A prophet is tested by whether his words come to pass (Deuteronomy 18:22), and by this test, Jeremiah is vindicated, despite the opposition he faced.

The chapter reports the same terrible sequence as 2 Kings: the siege, the famine, the breach in the wall, the flight and capture of the king, the blinding, the burning of the temple, the breaking of the bronze pillars called Jachin and Boaz, and the deportation. The bronze pillars at the temple’s entrance, which had symbolized stability, are chopped up. The vessels of the temple are carried off. The number of those taken into exile in three waves is recorded: 3,023, then 832, then 745. These numbers are small. The nation has been reduced to a remnant.

There is one difference from 2 Kings: the date of the final release is stated, the twenty-fifth day of the twelfth month in the thirty-seventh year of exile, when Evil-merodach released Jehoiachin from prison. He is given a seat above the other kings in Babylon, a new set of clothes, and a daily allowance. It is a small mercy, and yet a sign. The line of David is alive.

Why end here? The book has told the whole story of judgment, but it wants the reader to see the tiny signs of hope. The final image is of a king in exile eating at a table. It is a promise in miniature: the God who judged is the God who preserves. For the faithful reader, this is the foretaste of the great feast that is coming.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 1:12 lists Jehoiachin (Jechoniah) in Jesus’ genealogy, and the line of David that seemed to end was continued in the one who is called Christ. Deuteronomy 18:21-22 gives the test of a true prophet. Hebrews 6:18-19 speaks of a hope that anchors the soul. Psalm 23:5 says, “You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies.” Revelation 19:9 says, “Blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb.”

STEP 6

Application

Thank God that his word is always reliable, down to the last detail.

Look for the small signs of hope in a hard season: a table set in exile.

Reflect on how the line of David, nearly lost, led to Jesus. What does this teach you about God's faithfulness?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his word is true and comes to pass.

Thank him that in judgment he kept David's line alive.

Ask him to teach you to trust his promises.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 455 · WEEK 65

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jeremiah 33:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

REST

Meditation

This verse was spoken to a man in prison. Jeremiah was locked in the court of the guard while Jerusalem burned. He had nothing: no freedom, no city, and no apparent future. And God said, "Call to me."

It is an invitation. The first thing God asks of someone in trouble is not to fix it but to call. Prayer is the simple act of speaking to God. No special words are required. The one who is in prison, who is at the end of his strength, can call.

"And I will answer you." It is a promise. The word for answer includes the sense of responding to someone who has spoken. God is not deaf or distant. He hears and replies. Not every answer comes in the form or on the schedule we expect. But he answers. He had already answered Jeremiah's earlier question by telling him to buy the field.

“And will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known.” This is a surprise. God offers more than relief. He offers revelation. “Great and hidden” might also be translated “fortified, inaccessible.” There are things that human wisdom cannot reach. In Jeremiah’s case, God goes on to reveal the restoration of Israel, the righteous Branch, and the everlasting covenant. They are the most glorious promises of the book, and they came in prison.

Say this verse when you feel confined. God often does his greatest teaching in the narrowest places. Call to him. He will answer, and he will show you more than you thought to ask.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Jeremiah. You prayed Psalm 108, a song that begins with a steadfast heart and ends with trust in God because human help is vain. You read about the tragedy that followed the fall of Jerusalem: Gedaliah’s murder, the people’s request for God’s guidance that was already settled in their hearts, and their flight to Egypt in disobedience, where they took up idolatry again. You heard God’s quiet word to Baruch not to seek great things for himself. You read the oracles against Egypt, Moab, Edom, and above all Babylon, learning that no empire stands forever and even enemies have a future. And you read the closing chapter, which confirmed in history everything Jeremiah said and ended with Jehoiachin eating at the king’s table. The week taught that God’s word is reliable, that guidance requires willingness to obey, and that hope survives the fall.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The people asked Jeremiah for God’s guidance but had already decided. Is there a decision in your life where you are asking God but have not truly surrendered the answer?

Baruch was told not to seek great things for himself. Where do you struggle with wanting recognition for your service?

Jeremiah’s longest prophecies ended with a king eating at a table in exile. Where might God be giving you a small sign of hope in a difficult season?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Call to God and ask him to tell you great and hidden things.

Thank him for his reliable word.

Rest in him today.

DAY 456 · WEEK 66

Psalm 119:145-176

I cry with my whole heart; your word is my hope

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:145-176. This is the last two stanzas of the long acrostic psalm on God's word. You have read parts of Psalm 119 several times. Today read it as the prayer of a believer in exile, far from home but holding on to the word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 119 is the longest chapter in the Bible, a poem of 176 verses in twenty-two stanzas, one for each letter of the Hebrew alphabet. Every verse speaks of God's word, using eight or so words for it: law, testimonies, precepts, statutes, commandments, rules, word, and promise. The last stanzas are written as a cry. The psalmist is pursued by persecutors and ends with an image of a lost sheep. It is a good psalm for the exile, as people without a temple clung to the written word.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "With my whole heart I cry; answer me, O LORD! I will keep your statutes" (v. 145).
2. "I rise before dawn and cry for help; I hope in your words" (v. 147).
3. "My eyes are awake before the watches of the night, that I may meditate on your promise" (v. 148).
4. "Those who persecute me with evil purpose draw near; they are far from your law. But you are near, O LORD" (vv. 150-151).
5. "Long have I known from your testimonies that you have founded them forever" (v. 152).

6. “The sum of your word is truth, and every one of your righteous rules endures forever” (v. 160).
7. “Great peace have those who love your law; nothing can make them stumble” (v. 165).
8. “I have gone astray like a lost sheep; seek your servant, for I do not forget your commandments” (v. 176).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalmist prays with his whole heart. He gets up before dawn and stays awake through the night, because his hope is in God’s word. In exile, the word of God was what remained. The temple was gone, the sacrifices ceased, but the written word could still be read, meditated on, and prayed. Many scholars believe the Scriptures became central to Jewish life in exile for this reason.

The situation is not easy. Persecutors are near, but the psalmist notes that “you are near, O LORD.” The enemy is close, but God is closer. The contrast is a source of strength. And he adds, “All your commandments are true.” Even when circumstances are hostile, the word does not change.

There is a beautiful summary in verse 160: “The sum of your word is truth.” The whole is true, and every part is true. The psalmist is not picking out the verses he likes. He has taken all of it. And the result is verse 165: “Great peace have those who love your law.” Peace, shalom, belongs to those who love the word. Nothing makes them stumble.

The last verse is surprising. After 175 verses of praise for the word, the psalmist confesses: “I have gone astray like a lost sheep.” It is an honest ending. He loves the word, and yet he knows he wanders. And his request is, “Seek your servant.” He does not say, “I will find my way back.” He asks the shepherd to find him. The word of God does not make us self-sufficient. It leads us to depend on the God who seeks.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I am the good shepherd” (John 10:11), and told the story of the shepherd who leaves ninety-nine sheep to seek the one that is lost (Luke 15:3-7). “I have come to seek and to save the lost” (Luke 19:10). 2 Timothy 3:16-17 says that all Scripture is breathed out by God. John 17:17 says, “Your word is truth.” John 14:27 gives Christ’s peace. 1 Peter 2:25: “You were straying like sheep, but have now returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls.”

STEP 6

Application

Set aside time before dawn this week, as the psalmist did, and cry to God from Scripture.

Memorize one verse of Psalm 119 that speaks to your situation.

Pray verse 176 as your own: “Seek your servant.” Thank Jesus for being the shepherd who finds.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry out to God with your whole heart.
- Tell him your hope is in his word.
- Thank him that he is near.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

“The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness.”

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 457 · WEEK 66

Psalm 120; Psalm 121

In my distress I called; I lift my eyes to the hills

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 120 and Psalm 121. These are the first two Songs of Ascents, which pilgrims sang on the way up to Jerusalem. Psalm 120 starts in distress far from home, and Psalm 121 lifts its eyes to the hills.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalms 120 to 134 are the Songs of Ascents, sung by pilgrims climbing to Jerusalem for the festivals. After the exile, they may also have been the songs of those returning. Psalm 120 begins in a foreign place: "Too long have I had my dwelling among those who hate peace." Psalm 121 is the voice of someone on the journey who asks where help comes from. They belong at this point in the plan as songs for exiles on the road home.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In my distress I called to the LORD, and he answered me" (120:1).
2. "Deliver me, O LORD, from lying lips, from a deceitful tongue" (120:2).
3. "Woe is me, that I sojourn in Meshech, that I dwell among the tents of Kedar!" (120:5).
4. "Too long have I had my dwelling among those who hate peace. I am for peace, but when I speak, they are for war" (120:6-7).
5. "I lift up my eyes to the hills. From where does my help come?" (121:1).
6. "My help comes from the LORD, who made heaven and earth" (121:2).
7. "He will not let your foot be moved; he who keeps you will not slumber" (121:3).
8. "The LORD will keep your going out and your coming in from this time forth and forevermore" (121:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 120 begins with a testimony and then a prayer. “In my distress I called to the LORD, and he answered me.” The psalmist remembers a time of rescue, and in the present he again needs it. His troubles are liars. Deceitful tongues surround him. He asks God to deal with them as arrows and burning coals. He is in a foreign place, Meshech and Kedar, far-off lands, a symbolic way of saying that he is among people who do not share his values. His last line is poignant: “I am for peace, but when I speak, they are for war.” It is the lament of anyone who longs for peace and meets hostility.

Psalm 121 is the answer. The pilgrim looks up at the hills of Judea. Some read the question as fear: the hills held pagan shrines and bandits. Others read it as longing for Zion. Either way, the answer is clear: “My help comes from the LORD, who made heaven and earth.” The one who made the hills is greater than they are. Help does not come from the landscape, but from its Creator.

Then the psalm uses a word again and again: keep. The LORD is your keeper. He will not let your foot slip. He does not sleep. He is your shade at your right hand. The sun will not strike you by day, nor the moon by night. He will keep your life. He will keep your going out and your coming in.

Together the two psalms give the journey of faith: from the foreign land of distress to the God who keeps. The travelers learn that their security does not depend on the road but on the one who walks it with them.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I will never leave you nor forsake you” (Hebrews 13:5, paraphrasing Deuteronomy 31:6), and “I am with you always” (Matthew 28:20). John 10:28 says that no one will snatch his sheep out of his hand. Jude 24 says he is able to keep you from stumbling. 1 Peter 1:5 says we are guarded by God’s power. Psalm 127 and Mark 4:38 remind us that Jesus slept in the boat, but the Father does not slumber. Romans 12:18 says, “If possible, so far as it depends on you, live peaceably with all.”

STEP 6

Application

When you are in distress, begin as Psalm 120 does: remember a past time that God answered you.

Pray Psalm 121 as a blessing over someone who is traveling or starting a new job.

When you feel surrounded by hostility, say aloud, “My help comes from the LORD, who made heaven and earth.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what distresses you and ask him to answer.
- Lift your eyes to him as your help.
- Thank him that he will keep you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

“The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness.”

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 458 · WEEK 66

Lamentations 1:1-2:22

Jerusalem's mourning; the city as widow

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Lamentations 1:1-2:22. The book of Lamentations is a collection of five poems of grief over the fall of Jerusalem. Read it slowly and honestly, without hurrying to the good news. Notice who is speaking in each part.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Lamentations was traditionally written by Jeremiah, though the text does not name an author. It follows the destruction of Jerusalem in 586 BC, and the five poems are written as acrostics: the first four use the Hebrew alphabet as a frame, a way of giving order to disorder. The book shows how to grieve in faith. It does not offer quick answers. It gives words for sorrow so that the people can bring it to God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "How lonely sits the city that was full of people! How like a widow has she become" (1:1).
2. "She weeps bitterly in the night, with tears on her cheeks; among all her lovers she has none to comfort her" (1:2).
3. "The LORD has afflicted her for the multitude of her transgressions" (1:5).
4. "Is it nothing to you, all you who pass by? Look and see if there is any sorrow like my sorrow" (1:12).
5. "The LORD is in the right, for I have rebelled against his word" (1:18).
6. "The Lord has become like an enemy; he has swallowed up Israel" (2:5).

7. “My eyes are spent with weeping; my stomach churns; my bile is poured out to the ground” (2:11).
8. “Arise, cry out in the night, at the beginning of the night watches! Pour out your heart like water before the presence of the Lord!” (2:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening line is among the saddest in the Bible. “How lonely sits the city that was full of people!” Jerusalem is pictured as a widow, once great among the nations and now a slave. She weeps in the night. Her friends have betrayed her. Her roads mourn because no one comes to the festivals. Her priests groan, her young women grieve. And no one comforts her.

The poem speaks in two voices: the narrator, who looks at the city and describes her pain, and Jerusalem herself, who speaks from verse 9 on. “Look, O LORD, and see, for I am despised.” The most piercing cry is in verse 12: “Is it nothing to you, all you who pass by?” It is the cry of someone suffering whose pain is invisible to the busy.

Yet already in chapter 1 there is honesty about the cause. “The LORD is in the right, for I have rebelled against his word.” The poet does not blame God for injustice. He confesses, and still he cries for help. Grief and repentance go together.

Chapter 2 is more shocking. The speaker says that the Lord himself has become like an enemy. The language is of God’s anger: he has torn down the stronghold, rejected his altar, and scorned his sanctuary. This was the hardest thing for the exiles to accept: God had done this. Yet the point of the poem is that God is real and his word is true.

The turning point is verse 19: “Arise, cry out in the night… pour out your heart like water before the presence of the Lord!” The right response to sorrow is to bring it to God. Lamentations teaches us that lament is a form of prayer, and that to pour out our hearts to God is itself an act of faith.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus wept over Jerusalem and said, “How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you were not willing!” (Luke 13:34). On the road to Golgotha, he told the women, “Do not weep for me, but weep for yourselves” (Luke 23:28). Romans 12:15 says, “Weep with those who weep.” Hebrews 5:7 says Jesus offered up prayers with loud cries and tears. Matthew 5:4: “Blessed are those who mourn, for they shall be comforted.”

STEP 6

Application

Spend time grieving something you have lost, without trying to fix it. Pour it out to God.

Be present with someone who is suffering. Do not hurry them. Sit with them.

Pray with the words of Lamentations 2:19 when you cannot find your own.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pour out your heart to God, naming a sorrow.
- Confess where you have rebelled against his word.
- Ask him to look on your affliction.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 459 · WEEK 66

Lamentations 3:1-66

"Great is your faithfulness", hope in the midst of suffering

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Lamentations 3:1-66. This is the center of the book, a long poem in which the poet moves from despair to a stunning declaration of hope. Read verses 19 to 33 slowly. They are the heart of the book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 3 is the only chapter in which the speaker is an individual, "the man who has seen affliction." It is a triple acrostic, in which three verses in a row begin with each letter of the Hebrew alphabet, making 66 verses. Its structure of increasing order is placed over its disorder. At the center, the poet speaks of hope in the middle of suffering.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I am the man who has seen affliction under the rod of his wrath" (v. 1).
2. "He has driven and brought me into darkness without any light" (v. 2).
3. "He has besieged me and surrounded me with bitterness and tribulation" (v. 5).
4. "So I say, My endurance has perished; so has my hope from the LORD" (v. 18).
5. "But this I call to mind, and therefore I have hope" (v. 21).
6. "The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness" (vv. 22-23).
7. "The LORD is my portion, says my soul, therefore I will hope in him" (v. 24).
8. "For he does not afflict from his heart or grieve the children of men" (v. 33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter opens in complete darkness. The speaker catalogs his suffering: God has walled him in, bound him with heavy chains, shut out his prayer, made his path crooked. He is like a bear or a lion lying in wait. The images are of a person who feels that God himself has become his enemy. And he reaches the bottom in verse 18: "My endurance has perished; so has my hope from the LORD."

Then comes the hinge: "But this I call to mind." The word "call to mind" means to bring back to the heart. He does not argue himself out of his pain. He remembers something. And what he remembers is the character of God. "The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

This is among the best known passages in Lamentations, and it is worth noting where it appears: in the center of the book of grief, in the aftermath of the destruction of Jerusalem. These are not words from a place of comfort. They are words from the ashes. The faithfulness of God is great precisely when everything else is gone.

The poet continues: "The LORD is my portion... therefore I will hope in him." He has lost everything but has God. It is good to wait quietly for the salvation of the LORD. It is good to bear the yoke in youth. God's discipline is not endless: "Though he cause grief, he will have compassion according to the abundance of his steadfast love." And he adds a statement that gives light to everything: "He does not afflict from his heart." Judgment is God's "strange work." His heart is mercy.

The rest of the chapter returns to prayer and to a plea for justice. But the poem has made its point: hope is a decision to remember who God is.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 4:15-16 says we have a high priest who can sympathize with our weaknesses. 2 Corinthians 4:8-9 says we are afflicted but not crushed. Hebrews 12:5-11 explains that the Lord disciplines the one he loves. Romans 5:3-5 says that suffering produces endurance, character, and hope. Isaiah 53:3 describes Jesus as a man of sorrows. The hymn "Great Is Thy Faithfulness" is based on verses 22 and 23.

STEP 6

Application

Start each day this week by saying, "His mercies are new every morning."

Think of a time of affliction when you remembered something about God that gave you hope. Write it down.

Wait quietly before God for a few minutes, as verse 26 teaches.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God how weary you are.

Call to mind his steadfast love and mercies, and name one.

Tell him you wait for him because he is good.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 460 · WEEK 66

Lamentations 4:1-5:22

The city's degradation; the final plea, restore us

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Lamentations 4:1-5:22. The last two poems describe the siege in horrifying detail and end with a communal prayer. Read the last chapter as a prayer for the people to say together, and notice the unsettled final verses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 4 is a fourth acrostic and a description of the city's degradation: children starving, nobles in rags, prophets and priests defiled. Chapter 5 is not an acrostic, though it has 22 verses. It is a prayer for the whole community, a plea to remember what has happened and restore them. It ends without resolution, with a question. The book of Lamentations is meant to be read in its brokenness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "How the gold has grown dim, how the pure gold is changed!" (4:1).
2. "The tongue of the nursing infant sticks to the roof of its mouth for thirst; the children beg for food, but no one gives to them" (4:4).
3. "The punishment of the daughter of my people has been greater than the punishment of Sodom" (4:6).
4. "This was for the sins of her prophets and the iniquities of her priests" (4:13).
5. "Remember, O LORD, what has befallen us; look, and see our disgrace!" (5:1).
6. "Our fathers sinned, and are no more; and we bear their iniquities" (5:7).
7. "The joy of our hearts has ceased; our dancing has been turned to mourning" (5:15).

8 “Restore us to yourself, O LORD, that we may be restored! Renew our days as of old” (5:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 4 begins with a symbol of dimmed gold, used for the precious stones of the temple, now scattered at the head of every street. The precious sons of Zion, “worth their weight in fine gold,” are regarded as clay pots. Even jackals nurse their young, but the daughters of Jerusalem are cruel like ostriches in the wilderness. The poet describes starvation, even to the point of cannibalism, which Deuteronomy 28 had warned of. Nothing is spared.

The cause is again the sin of the leaders: “the sins of her prophets and the iniquities of her priests, who shed in the midst of her the blood of the righteous.” The people who should have led them to God led them astray.

The last chapter turns from description to prayer. “Remember, O LORD, what has befallen us.” The community pleads. They list their losses: inheritance turned over to strangers, orphans without fathers, water bought for money, wood sold at a price, slaves ruling over them. They acknowledge, “Woe to us, for we have sinned!” But they also affirm God’s rule: “But you, O LORD, reign forever; your throne endures to all generations.” Even in disaster, the throne of God is secure. This is the anchor of the book.

The prayer ends with a petition: “Restore us to yourself, O LORD, that we may be restored!” The initiative is God’s. They cannot return by themselves. Repentance itself is a gift. And then the book ends with a question that remains open: “Or have you utterly rejected us? Are you exceedingly angry with us?” Jewish tradition repeats verse 21 after the last verse, so as not to end on a note of despair. The unsettled ending is honest. It leaves the reader waiting for the answer, which the prophets Ezekiel and Daniel, and eventually Christ, will give.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:2 says Jesus endured the cross for the joy set before him. Revelation 21:4 promises that God will wipe away every tear. Acts 3:19-20 says, “Repent, therefore, and turn back, that your sins may be blotted out, that times of refreshing may come from the presence of the Lord.” 2 Corinthians 7:10 says godly grief produces repentance that leads to salvation. Romans 8:35-39 assures us that nothing can separate us from God’s love.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for a place where there is famine or war, and give practically if you can.

Use the prayer of 5:21: “Restore us to yourself, O LORD, that we may be restored.” Pray it for yourself and for your church.

Rest in the truth that God’s throne endures even when ours do not.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to remember his people and restore them.
- Tell him he reigns forever.
- Ask him to turn you back to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

“The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness.”

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 461 · WEEK 66

Ezekiel 1:1-3:27

The vision of God's throne, glory above the exile

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 1:1-3:27. A priest in exile by a canal in Babylon sees a vision of God's throne, eats a scroll, and is made a watchman. Read chapter 1 as a picture rather than a puzzle, and ask what it tells Ezekiel about where God is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ezekiel was a priest, taken to Babylon with the first group of exiles in 597 BC, together with King Jehoiachin. In the fifth year of that exile, at the age of thirty, the age when priests began their service, he saw the vision. He had no temple to serve in, but God came to him by the river Chebar in a foreign land. Ezekiel prophesied for about twenty-two years, and his book is full of visions and sign-acts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The heavens were opened, and I saw visions of God" (1:1).
2. "Out of the midst of it came the likeness of four living creatures" (1:5).
3. "And above the expanse over their heads there was the likeness of a throne, in appearance like sapphire" (1:26).
4. "Such was the appearance of the likeness of the glory of the LORD. And when I saw it, I fell on my face" (1:28).
5. "Son of man, stand on your feet, and I will speak with you" (2:1).
6. "And whether they hear or refuse to hear… they will know that a prophet has been among them" (2:5).

7. “Son of man, eat whatever you find here. Eat this scroll… and it was in my mouth as sweet as honey” (3:1, 3).

8. “Son of man, I have made you a watchman for the house of Israel” (3:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezekiel’s first vision is overwhelming, and all details point to one great truth: God is on his throne, and he is not confined to Jerusalem. A great storm cloud comes from the north, with flashing fire. Within it are four living creatures with faces of a man, a lion, an ox, and an eagle. Beside each is a wheel within a wheel, full of eyes, moving in every direction. Above is an expanse like crystal, and above that a throne with a figure like a man, surrounded by a rainbow. It is the glory of the LORD.

The point of the vision is clear to anyone who knows the situation. The exiles thought God had stayed in the temple in Jerusalem. They were in a foreign land, far from his presence. But God’s throne is mobile. It comes to Babylon. He is not limited to one place. The wheels move in any direction. He is sovereign over the whole earth.

Ezekiel falls on his face. God calls him “son of man,” a title used about ninety times in the book, emphasizing his humble humanity. He is raised by the Spirit and sent to a people who are “rebellious,” “hard of heart” and “stubborn.” The prophet is warned that they will not listen. His job is to speak, whether they hear or not.

Then he eats a scroll with words of lament, mourning, and woe, and it tastes sweet as honey. The word of God is sweet even when its message is bitter. In the Bible, to eat the word is to take it fully in before speaking it.

At the end of chapter 3, God makes him a watchman. If he warns, and they do not listen, he has saved himself. If he does not warn, he will be held accountable. The prophet is given seven days of silence, overwhelmed by the task. And then God binds his tongue, so that he speaks only when God gives him a word.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 4:6-8 shows four living creatures around the throne, and Revelation 1:12-18 shows the glorified Christ. John 1:14 says the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, “and we have seen his glory.” Matthew 28:19-20 sends the disciples into all the world and promises his presence. Revelation 10:8-11 shows John eating a scroll, as Ezekiel did. Acts 20:26-31 shows Paul acting as a watchman, innocent of the blood of all.

STEP 6

Application

Pause and remember that God is not confined to the places you associate with him. Pray to him wherever you are today.

Eat the word: take a short passage and read it slowly until you taste it.

Think about whom God has made you a watchman for: family, friends, a church. How are you warning and encouraging them?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for being seated on his throne.

Thank him that he came to the exiles in Babylon, and to you.

Ask him to give you ears to hear his word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 462 · WEEK 66

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Lamentations 3:22-23 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

REST

Meditation

Few verses have comforted more people in grief than this one. It is surprising because of where it appears: in the center of a book of mourning over a destroyed city.

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases." The word for steadfast love, hesed, is the covenant word. It means loyal, faithful, committed love. It is the love of God that holds to the covenant even when his people have broken it. And "never ceases" means that it does not run out, even after disaster. The city has fallen, but God's love has not. The people had been tempted to think that they had exhausted God's patience. This verse says that his love is not a resource that can be used up.

"His mercies never come to an end." Mercies are acts of compassion, plural, as in many small acts. They are tender, like a mother's compassion for a child. They never come to an end. The two phrases say the same thing in two ways, as Hebrew poetry often does: God's love and compassion are inexhaustible.

“They are new every morning.” Each day brings fresh supplies. The mercy we need for today is not leftover mercy from yesterday. It is given new. This is a daily rhythm. We do not need to carry yesterday’s failures or tomorrow’s worries, because mercy is renewed with every sunrise.

“Great is your faithfulness.” The conclusion is a statement of praise, which gives us the title of the famous hymn. Faithfulness is God’s reliability. He keeps his word. Say this verse every morning this week, as you wake. Let it set the tone for the day.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you moved from the end of Jeremiah into the exile itself. You prayed Psalm 119’s closing stanzas as the prayer of one who clings to God’s word and then confesses that he is a lost sheep, and the first two Songs of Ascents, which move from distress to the confidence that the LORD is our keeper. You read all five poems of Lamentations, which give words for grief: the weeping widow, the cry of “Is it nothing to you?”, the center that remembers God’s steadfast love, and the final plea, “Restore us to yourself, O LORD.” Then you began Ezekiel, a priest in exile, who saw the glory of God on a mobile throne in Babylon, ate a scroll that tasted sweet as honey, and was made a watchman. The week taught that grief is a form of prayer, that God’s mercy is new every morning, and that God is present even in exile.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Lamentations gives a voice to grief. What sorrow have you not yet brought to God in prayer, and what might it look like to do so?

The hope in the center of Lamentations comes from remembering who God is. What is one truth about God’s character that has held you in a hard time?

Ezekiel saw God’s glory in a foreign land. Where do you feel far from God, and how does this vision speak to that place?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his mercies are new every morning.

Name a way he was faithful this week.

Rest in him today.

DAY 463 · WEEK 67

Psalm 73

Asaph was nearly slipping; then he entered the sanctuary

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 73. A believer almost loses his faith because the wicked seem to prosper. You have read this psalm before. Read it now as the prayer of someone in exile, who has lost the temple but finds God's presence anyway.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 73 is the first psalm of Book 3, a psalm of Asaph. It begins with a confession: "But as for me, my feet had almost stumbled." The psalmist envied the arrogant when he saw their ease. The turning point is when he entered "the sanctuary of God." For the exiles, the question was sharper: what could it mean to enter the sanctuary when the sanctuary was a ruin? The psalm answers that what matters is the presence of God himself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Truly God is good to Israel, to those who are pure in heart" (v. 1).
2. "But as for me, my feet had almost stumbled, my steps had nearly slipped" (v. 2).
3. "For I was envious of the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked" (v. 3).
4. "All in vain have I kept my heart clean and washed my hands in innocence" (v. 13).
5. "But when I thought how to understand this, it seemed to me a wearisome task, until I went into the sanctuary of God; then I discerned their end" (vv. 16-17).
6. "I was brutish and ignorant; I was like a beast toward you" (v. 22).
7. "Nevertheless, I am continually with you; you hold my right hand" (v. 23).
8. "Whom have I in heaven but you? And there is nothing on earth that I desire besides you" (v. 25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is autobiographical. The writer was a believer who nearly gave up. He looked around and saw that the arrogant seemed to have no pain. Their bodies were fat, they were free from burdens, they spoke with malice, and they said, “How can God know?” Meanwhile, he had kept his heart clean, and had been plagued all day long. It seemed that holiness was in vain.

This is the question of the whole book of Jeremiah and Lamentations too. Why do the wicked prosper and the faithful suffer? The psalmist says that he tried to figure it out, but it was too hard for him. “Until I went into the sanctuary of God.” In God’s presence, his view changed. He saw the end of the wicked: slippery ground, sudden ruin. And he saw himself. He realized that his envy had made him “brutish and ignorant.” The sanctuary did not give him a theory. It gave him God.

Then comes the great turn. “Nevertheless, I am continually with you; you hold my right hand.” The psalmist realizes that his security was never that he held God, but that God held him. And he declares: “Whom have I in heaven but you? And there is nothing on earth that I desire besides you.” God is the one thing that cannot be lost. “My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever.”

For the exiles, there was no sanctuary in Jerusalem to enter. But there was the sanctuary of God’s presence, which Ezekiel had just seen by the river Chebar. To “enter the sanctuary” is to come into God’s presence and see things from his perspective. The psalm ends with a summary: “For me it is good to be near God.” It is a mark of mature faith. The best thing is not the removal of trouble but nearness to God.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father’s good pleasure to give you the kingdom” (Luke 12:32). Hebrews 10:19-22 says we may enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus. Philippians 3:7-8 says that Paul counted everything as loss compared to knowing Christ. John 10:28-29 says no one can snatch us out of the Father’s hand. Matthew 5:8 says the pure in heart will see God. 2 Corinthians 4:17-18 contrasts the momentary affliction with eternal glory.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a time you envied someone. Take that envy into the sanctuary of God’s presence in prayer, and ask what he shows you.

Say verse 25 aloud, and ask whether it is true: “Whom have I in heaven but you?”

Thank God that he holds your right hand when you cannot hold his.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess your envy and tell God where your feet nearly slipped.
- Tell him what you saw when you entered his presence.
- Tell him he is the strength of your heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

“My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever.”

PSALM 73:26

DAY 464 · WEEK 67

Psalm 77

I cry aloud to God; then I remember

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 77. You have read this psalm twice before, in Unit 6 and in Unit 11. Read it a third time as a prayer for the exile, and notice the line about God's footprints. This time hold it beside Ezekiel's vision of the chariot throne you have just read.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 77 is a psalm of Asaph. Earlier readings looked at it as a lesson in remembering, and as the lament of the northern kingdom. Now, in the exile, a third reading is possible. Ezekiel has just seen that God's throne moves on wheels and is not tied to Jerusalem. The psalmist says God's way was through the sea, and his footprints were unseen. God is at work even when we cannot trace him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I cry aloud to God, aloud to God, and he will hear me" (v. 1).
2. "In the day of my trouble I seek the Lord; in the night my hand is stretched out without wearying" (v. 2).
3. "Selah" appears after verses 3, 9, and 15, three pauses (vv. 3, 9, 15).
4. "Has God forgotten to be gracious? Has he in anger shut up his compassion?" (v. 9).
5. "I will ponder all your work, and meditate on your mighty deeds" (v. 12).
6. "Your way, O God, is holy. What god is great like our God?" (v. 13).
7. "You are the God who works wonders; you have made known your might among the peoples" (v. 14).

8 “Your way was through the sea, your path through the great waters; yet your footprints were unseen” (v. 19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three Selahs mark three pauses in the psalm, and they trace a journey. The first, after verse 3, comes after the psalmist says that remembering God makes him groan. The second, after verse 9, follows the string of questions about God’s compassion. The third, after verse 15, comes after the declaration that God has redeemed his people. The psalm moves from groaning, to doubt, to testimony, and each pause gives time to think.

The center of the psalm is verse 13: “Your way, O God, is holy.” The Hebrew can also mean, “Your way is in the sanctuary.” Both are true. God’s way is holy, set apart and pure. And it is found in his presence, not in our understanding. When the psalmist cannot explain what God is doing, he does not deny his goodness. He says the way is holy. He may not see all of it, but he trusts it.

This fits what Ezekiel saw. The living creatures and wheels moved in every direction, full of eyes. God sees all. His movements are not random, even though they are beyond our grasp. When the exiles felt that God had lost control, Ezekiel showed them his throne in the midst of the storm.

The final image of the psalm is quiet. “Your way was through the sea, your path through the great waters; yet your footprints were unseen.” God passed through the sea, but left no trace. And then the last line: “You led your people like a flock by the hand of Moses and Aaron.” The great Redeemer led through two ordinary men.

In the exile, God was still leading, through prophets like Ezekiel, through the hidden hand of providence, through the covenant he had promised not to forget. The footprints were unseen, but he was walking ahead.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 11:33 says, “How unsearchable are his judgments and how inscrutable his ways!” Job 23:8-10 expresses the same hiddenness: “If I go forward, he is not there… but he knows the way that I take.” Isaiah 55:8-9 says that his thoughts are higher than ours. Luke 24:13-35 shows Jesus walking beside the disciples unrecognized on the road to Emmaus. Romans 8:28 says that God works all things together for good. John 13:7: “What I am doing you do not understand now, but afterward you will understand.”

STEP 6

Application

Look back at a hard period and ask where God's footprints might have been unseen at the time.

Trace one "pause" in your own faith: groaning, doubt, or testimony. Where are you now?

Pray "Your way, O God, is holy" as an act of trust in something you do not understand.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry aloud to God, and tell him what troubles you.
- Remember his wonders and rest on them.
- Praise him as the God who works wonders.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

"My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

PSALM 73:26

DAY 465 · WEEK 67

Ezekiel 4:1-7:27

Signs of Jerusalem's siege; judgment is certain

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 92 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 4:1-7:27. God commands Ezekiel to act out the siege of Jerusalem in strange and difficult ways. Read these chapters as sermons without words, and then listen to the words in chapters 6 and 7, which say that the end has come.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ezekiel's early prophecies, from 593 to 586 BC, are warnings of the fall of Jerusalem. The exiles in Babylon hoped that the city would be spared. Ezekiel's task was to break that false hope. The sign-acts in chapter 4 and 5 are acted out for the exiles. He is bound, silent, and lying on his side, while they watch. The message is that the siege is coming and God himself is the enemy.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Take a brick and lay it before you and engrave on it a city, even Jerusalem" (4:1).
2. "Then lie on your left side… and I will lay the punishment of the house of Israel upon you" (4:4).
3. "And behold, I will put cords upon you, so that you cannot turn from one side to the other" (4:8).
4. "This is Jerusalem. I have set her in the center of the nations, with countries all around her" (5:5).
5. "Behold, I, even I, am against you" (5:8).
6. "And they shall know that I am the LORD" (6:7, a repeated refrain).
7. "An end! The end has come upon the four corners of the land" (7:2).

8 “Their silver and gold cannot deliver them in the day of the wrath of the LORD” (7:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezekiel’s sign-acts are strange. He draws Jerusalem on a clay brick and sets up a model siege around it. He lies on his left side for 390 days to bear the iniquity of Israel, and on his right side for 40 days for Judah. He eats rationed food baked over dung, a symbol of the defilement of exile. He shaves his head and beard with a sword and divides the hair into thirds: burned, struck with the sword, and scattered to the wind. The meaning is clear. Jerusalem will be besieged, starved, and destroyed. Only a few will survive.

The reason is in 5:5-8. Jerusalem was set in the center of the nations, to be a light. Instead, she has been more rebellious than the nations around her. “Therefore thus says the Lord GOD: Behold, I, even I, am against you.” This is the stark reality: the one who had fought for Jerusalem is now fighting against her.

Chapter 6 addresses the mountains, because the people worshiped on the high places. It is an oracle to the land itself: the idols will be broken and the bones scattered. The refrain begins to appear: “Then you will know that I am the LORD.” This phrase occurs about sixty-five times in Ezekiel. The purpose of everything is the knowledge of God. Judgment and later salvation both serve this end.

Chapter 7 announces the end: “An end! The end has come.” The language is of a flood approaching. No one will go to battle, because God’s wrath is on all the multitude. Money and gold will be worthless. Famine and plague will fill the city. Even the temple will be profaned.

Why does Ezekiel tell us all this? Because the exiles needed to know that God does not lose control. The destruction of the temple was not a defeat for God. It was an act of God, the same God who loves them, and who will, in later chapters, restore.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus predicted the siege of Jerusalem in Luke 19:43-44 and Luke 21:20-24. In Mark 13, he warns that not one stone will be left. Hebrews 12:25-29 says our God is a consuming fire. John 8:28 shows that people will know who he is when the Son of Man is lifted up. Romans 11:22: “Note then the kindness and the severity of God.” Revelation 6:15-17 describes people hiding from the wrath of the Lamb.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the gravity of sin. Take time to confess something you might be treating lightly.

Ask what God might be teaching you through the “acts” of your own life, such as your family, work, and church.

Remember that every judgment in Ezekiel serves the purpose that people will know the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from treating his word lightly.
- Ask him to teach you to fear him.
- Tell him you know judgment is real.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

“My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever.”

PSALM 73:26

DAY 466 · WEEK 67

Ezekiel 8:1-11:25

The glory departs from the Temple

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 96 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 8:1-11:25. In a vision, Ezekiel is carried to Jerusalem and sees the idolatry inside the temple. Then the glory of the LORD leaves. Read it slowly, and let the departure of the glory register. Then read the promise at the end of chapter 11.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In 592 BC, Ezekiel is sitting in his house with the elders of Judah when the Spirit lifts him up in a vision to the temple in Jerusalem. He sees four abominations, each worse than the last. Then the glory of the LORD, which had dwelt in the temple since Solomon dedicated it, rises from the cherubim and moves out of the city. This is the central event of the first part of Ezekiel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Son of man, do you see what they are doing, the great abominations that the house of Israel are committing here, to drive me far from my sanctuary?” (8:6).
2. “Every form of creeping things and loathsome beasts, and all the idols of the house of Israel, engraved on the wall all around” (8:10).
3. “They say, The LORD does not see us, the LORD has forsaken the land” (8:12).
4. “Behold, there sat women weeping for Tammuz” (8:14).
5. “Mark the foreheads of the men who sigh and groan over all the abominations that are committed in it” (9:4).
6. “Then the glory of the LORD went out from the threshold of the house” (10:18).

7. “And I will give them one heart, and a new spirit I will put within them. I will remove the heart of stone from their flesh and give them a heart of flesh” (11:19).

8. “And the glory of the LORD went up from the midst of the city and stood on the mountain that is on the east side of the city” (11:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezekiel is shown four scenes of corruption in the temple. First, an idol of jealousy at the north gate. Second, seventy elders of Israel offering incense to carved creatures on the walls, saying, “The LORD does not see us.” Third, women weeping for Tammuz, a fertility god. Fourth, twenty-five men with their backs to the temple, bowing to the sun in the east. The leaders, the priests, the women, and the men are all involved. The house built for the worship of the one true God is a pantheon of idols.

God’s response is judgment. In chapter 9, a man in linen marks the foreheads of those who grieve over the abominations. They will be spared. Then others follow to strike. It is a picture of discerning judgment. Even in the midst of destruction, God knows those who are his.

Then comes the heartbreaking departure of the glory. In chapter 10, Ezekiel sees the cherubim and wheels again, and the glory of the LORD rises from the threshold. It moves in stages: from the cherubim to the threshold, to the east gate, up from the city and onto the Mount of Olives. It is an act of reluctant departure. The glory leaves slowly. It is as though God lingers, hoping that they will turn.

In the midst of judgment, in chapter 11, the promise breaks through. God will gather them from the nations. He will remove the heart of stone and give a heart of flesh, with one heart and a new spirit. “Then they will be my people, and I will be their God.” Even though the temple is empty, he promises to be “a sanctuary for a little while” in the countries where they have gone.

This is the theological center: the presence of God is not tied to a building. And it points forward to a day when God’s glory will return, not to a stone temple but to a people with new hearts.

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:14 says the Word became flesh and “tabernacled” among us, and we have seen his glory. The glory that left the temple through the east gate stood on the Mount of Olives. Jesus ascended from the Mount of Olives (Acts 1:9-12) and will return there (Zechariah 14:4). 1

Corinthians 3:16 says that believers are God's temple. Revelation 7:3 and 9:4 echo the sealing of foreheads. 2 Corinthians 3:3 says we are a letter written on hearts of flesh.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what "idols in the temple" might be in your life: hidden things you do where you think God does not see.

Remember that God knows those who sigh and groan over sin. Do you grieve over sin in your own life and in the world?

Thank God that he has taken away your heart of stone and given a heart of flesh. Ask him to keep it soft.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the idols in your heart.
- Ask him to give you a heart that grieves over sin.
- Thank him that he sees all that you do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

"My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

PSALM 73:26

DAY 467 · WEEK 67

Ezekiel 12:1-14:23

The rebellious house; false prophets

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 12:1-14:23. Ezekiel packs his bags to dramatize exile, condemns false prophets who say “Peace,” and exposes idols in the heart. Read especially 14:1-11 and 14:12-23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The exiles in Babylon were hearing prophets who told them that the fall of Jerusalem was far off, or would not happen. Ezekiel’s sign-acts and words in these chapters answer them. Chapter 12 shows him leaving his house like an exile. Chapter 13 attacks false prophets and prophetesses. Chapter 14 deals with elders who come to inquire of the LORD while hiding idols in their hearts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Son of man, you dwell in the midst of a rebellious house, who have eyes to see, but see not, who have ears to hear, but hear not” (12:2).
2. “None of my words will be delayed any longer, but the word that I speak will be performed” (12:28).
3. “Woe to the foolish prophets who follow their own spirit, and have seen nothing!” (13:3).
4. “They have misled my people, saying, Peace, when there is no peace, and because, when the people build a wall, these prophets smear it with whitewash” (13:10).
5. “Son of man, these men have taken their idols into their hearts, and set the stumbling block of their iniquity before their faces” (14:3).

6. “Repent and turn away from your idols, and turn away your faces from all your abominations” (14:6).

7. “Even if these three men, Noah, Daniel, and Job, were in it, they would deliver but their own lives by their righteousness” (14:14).

8. “I have not done without cause all that I have done in it, declares the Lord GOD” (14:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezekiel’s sign-act in chapter 12 is an exile’s departure. He packs his baggage in daylight, digs through a wall in the evening, covers his face, and goes out in the dark. It dramatizes what will happen to the prince in Jerusalem: Zedekiah will try to flee through a hole in the wall, and be caught. The people ask, “The vision that he sees is for many days from now.” God says, “None of my words will be delayed any longer.” The false comfort of delay is removed.

Chapter 13 attacks those who profit from false hope. The prophets “prophesy from their own hearts.” They are like jackals in the ruins, not repairing the breach in the wall. They are like those who whitewash a flimsy wall. When the storm comes, it falls. A wall looks solid but cannot stand. The false prophetesses use magic bands to ensnare souls. The common thread is that they lead God’s people away from reality.

Chapter 14 is one of the most searching passages in the Bible. Elders come to Ezekiel to inquire of the LORD. God says that they have idols in their hearts. They are outwardly respectable and inwardly corrupted. “Should I be consulted by them at all?” God will answer such a person himself in a way that will frighten him. The call is to repent. God does not want a religious show but a turned heart.

The chapter ends with four judgments: famine, wild beasts, sword, and plague. Even if Noah, Daniel, and Job were there, they would save only themselves. Righteousness is personal. No one can be saved by the faith of another. Yet there will be survivors, and when they arrive in Babylon, the exiles will see how wicked they were and be comforted. The last line gives God’s reason: “You shall know that I have not done without cause all that I have done.” The judgment is just.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus warned against false prophets in sheep’s clothing (Matthew 7:15) and said, “You are like whitewashed tombs” (Matthew 23:27). 1 John 5:21 says, “Little children, keep yourselves from idols.” Colossians 3:5 says that covetousness is idolatry. 2 Timothy 4:3-4 speaks of teachers who say what itching ears want to hear. James 4:8 says, “Cleanse your hands, you sinners, and purify your hearts.” Romans 14:12: “Each of us will give an account of himself to God.”

STEP 6

Application

Ask: What idol have I taken into my heart? Name it honestly before God.

Are there places in your life where you whitewash a weak wall: appearances, excuses, or comfortable lies?

Be wary of comfort that does not come from the word of God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to search your heart and show you your idols.
- Repent and turn from them in your own words.
- Ask him to keep you from false teachers.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

"My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

PSALM 73:26

DAY 468 · WEEK 67

Ezekiel 15:1-17:24

The vine; the unfaithful wife; the two eagles

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 59 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 15:1-17:24. Three parables: a useless vine, an unfaithful wife, and two eagles with a cedar. Read the second one, in chapter 16, carefully. It is among the most intense chapters in the Bible, and it ends with an everlasting covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ezekiel uses a series of images to explain Jerusalem's history. Chapter 15 compares Israel to the wood of a vine, which is good for nothing but fire. Chapter 16 tells the story of a foundling girl who was rescued by God, adorned, married, and then unfaithful. Chapter 17 uses two eagles and a cedar shoot to describe Zedekiah's rebellion against Babylon. They explain why Jerusalem is falling and prepare for the promise of restoration.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "How does the wood of the vine surpass any wood, the vine branch that is among the trees of the forest?" (15:2).
2. "On the day you were born your navel cord was not cut… No eye pitied you… but you were cast out on the open field" (16:4-5).
3. "I passed by you and saw you wallowing in your blood, and I said to you in your blood, Live!" (16:6).
4. "I spread the corner of my garment over you and covered your nakedness; I made my vow to you and entered into a covenant with you, declares the Lord GOD, and you became mine" (16:8).
5. "But you trusted in your beauty and played the whore because of your renown" (16:15).

6. “Yet I will remember my covenant with you in the days of your youth, and I will establish for you an everlasting covenant” (16:60).
7. “I will take a sprig from the lofty top of the cedar and will plant it” (17:22).
8. “And all the trees of the field shall know that I am the LORD; I bring low the high tree, and make high the low tree” (17:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The vine in chapter 15 is a short parable with a clear point. A vine is valuable for its fruit. Its wood is useless for building. A vine that does not bear fruit is only for fire. Jerusalem’s status as God’s vine does not protect her. If she does not bear fruit, she is fuel. The people had grown proud of their position. Ezekiel says that position without fruit is worthless.

The story of chapter 16 is a long and unsettling picture. A baby is abandoned in a field, unwashed, uncut, with no one to pity her. God passes by and says, “Live!” He raises her, and when she is grown, he enters into a covenant with her, clothes her in fine linen and jewelry, and makes her queen. This is the history of Israel from Abraham, a rescued foundling. She is adopted and adorned. Then she trusts in her beauty and uses her gifts to play the prostitute with every passerby: Egypt, Assyria, Babylon. She even sacrifices her children. She is worse than Sodom.

The chapter is hard to read, and it is meant to be. It shows the ugliness of idolatry from God’s point of view: not just rule-breaking but betrayal of love. Everything Israel had was a gift, and she used it against the giver.

Yet the end of the chapter is astonishing. “Yet I will remember my covenant with you in the days of your youth, and I will establish for you an everlasting covenant.” God will make atonement for her. “That you may remember and be confounded, and never open your mouth again because of your shame, when I atone for you for all that you have done.” Grace is the final word.

Chapter 17 ends with another promise: God himself will take a sprig from the top of the cedar and plant it on a high mountain, where it becomes a noble cedar. It is a messianic promise, the Davidic king who will shelter all birds.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I am the true vine” (John 15:1-6) and warned that branches that bear no fruit are thrown into the fire. Ephesians 5:25-27 says Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her to present her to himself in splendor. Romans 5:8 says that God showed his love for us in

that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. Mark 4:30-32 describes the kingdom as a mustard seed that becomes a tree where birds find shelter. Hebrews 13:20 speaks of the blood of the eternal covenant.

STEP 6

Application

Remember where you came from: you were like the abandoned baby in the field, and God said “Live!”

Think about the gifts God has given you. Are you using them for him?

Receive the promise of an everlasting covenant, and rest in the atonement made for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for finding you cast out, and telling you to live.
- Thank him for covering you and entering into covenant.
- Confess where you have been unfaithful.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

“My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever.”

PSALM 73:26

DAY 469 · WEEK 67

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 73:26 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

PSALM 73:26

REST

Meditation

This verse is the climax of Psalm 73, written by a man who almost lost his faith. After all his struggles, he comes to this confession.

"My flesh and my heart may fail." He is honest about his limits. Flesh is the body, with its weakness and mortality. Heart is the inner life, with its feelings and strength. Both can fail. The prosperous wicked looked so strong, and the psalmist felt so weak. But he does not say that his flesh and heart will not fail. They may. He admits it.

"But God is the strength of my heart." The word for strength can mean rock. God is the rock of my heart. When all else gives way, he is solid. Notice the difference: it is not that I am strong, but that God is my strength. The psalmist did not discover an inner reserve of courage. He discovered that God holds him up.

“And my portion forever.” A portion was a share of inheritance. In the land of Israel, each family received a portion. The Levites received none, because the LORD was their portion. The psalmist makes this his own. He says that God is his inheritance. Everything else may be lost, but God is his share. And it is forever, beyond death.

This is a verse for the weak and the weary. It does not ask you to be strong. It invites you to rest your weakness on the one who is. Say this verse when your body is tired, when your heart is troubled, or when you fear the future. God is the strength of your heart, and he is your portion forever.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you prayed two psalms of crisis: Psalm 73, where Asaph nearly stumbled when he saw the prosperity of the wicked until he entered God’s presence and declared, “Whom have I in heaven but you?”, and Psalm 77, where God’s footprints were unseen but his way was holy. You walked through the first part of Ezekiel. You saw the prophet act out the siege of Jerusalem, and watched the idolatry in the temple in his vision. You watched the glory of the LORD depart from the temple in reluctant stages, and heard the promise of a heart of flesh and a new spirit. You read God’s warnings against false prophets who whitewash a weak wall, and against idols in the heart. And you read the parables of the useless vine, the faithless wife, and the cedar sprig, which ended with an everlasting covenant. The week taught that God takes sin seriously, that his glory is not confined to a building, and that he promises a new heart.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Asaph’s view changed when he entered God’s presence. What would it look like to bring a question or envy into God’s presence this week, and wait?

Ezekiel saw the glory of God leave the temple, and then promised a heart of flesh. What hardness in your heart do you most need God to soften?

God says “Live!” to the abandoned child in chapter 16. How does this image of grace shape how you understand your own story?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what is failing in you, and tell him he is the strength of your heart.

Thank him for the new heart he has promised.

Rest in him.

DAY 470 · WEEK 68

Psalm 122

I was glad when they said, "Let us go to the house of the LORD"

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 122. It is a Song of Ascents of David, a joyful song for a pilgrim arriving in Jerusalem. Read it as a hope for the exiles, who longed to go up again.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 122 is the third of the Songs of Ascents you have started reading. Pilgrims sang these as they climbed to Jerusalem for the festivals. For exiles in Babylon, it was a memory and a promise: someday they would stand in those gates again. The psalm is about three things: the joy of going to the house of the LORD, the city as a place of unity and justice, and the prayer for its peace.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I was glad when they said to me, Let us go to the house of the LORD!" (v. 1).
2. "Our feet have been standing within your gates, O Jerusalem!" (v. 2).
3. "Jerusalem, built as a city that is bound firmly together" (v. 3).
4. "To which the tribes go up, the tribes of the LORD, as was decreed for Israel, to give thanks to the name of the LORD" (v. 4).
5. "There thrones for judgment were set, the thrones of the house of David" (v. 5).
6. "Pray for the peace of Jerusalem! May they be secure who love you!" (v. 6).
7. "Peace be within your walls and security within your towers!" (v. 7).
8. "For the sake of the house of the LORD our God, I will seek your good" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with gladness. The psalmist was glad when others said, “Let us go.” It is a statement about the joy of communal worship. We do not usually travel alone to God’s house. Someone invites us, and we go together. And he remembers the first words: “Let us go.” There is something about being invited into worship that stirs the heart.

The second verse is the arrival. “Our feet have been standing within your gates.” The journey is over, and they are in the city. For the exiles, this verse must have been bittersweet. They had no gates to stand in. But they could dream of it, and the psalm gave them words.

Jerusalem is described as a city “bound firmly together,” a place of unity. The tribes go up together to give thanks, and justice is administered there. The city is the center of the covenant community. It is a picture of what God’s people are meant to be: united, worshiping, and just.

The psalm ends with a prayer for peace. “Pray for the peace of Jerusalem!” There is a word play on the city’s name, which means “foundation of peace.” The peace prayed for is shalom, wholeness and well-being, within the walls and in the towers. And the motive is love: “For the sake of my brothers and companions, I will say, Peace be within you!” And the highest reason: “For the sake of the house of the LORD our God, I will seek your good.”

For Christians, Jerusalem is not just a geographic place. The church is described as the new Jerusalem, the “Jerusalem above.” This psalm teaches us to love the gathered people of God, to take joy in worship, and to pray for the church’s peace and unity.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:22-24 says that believers have come to Mount Zion, “the heavenly Jerusalem.” Galatians 4:26 speaks of “the Jerusalem above” as our mother. Revelation 21:2 describes the new Jerusalem coming down from heaven like a bride. Hebrews 10:24-25 calls us not to neglect meeting together. Ephesians 4:3 urges us to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace. John 14:27: “Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you.”

STEP 6

Application

Be glad in going to church this week. Pray ahead of time for those you will meet.

Pray for the peace and unity of your own church by name, as the psalm prays for Jerusalem.

Invite someone to worship with you, as in verse 1: “Let us go to the house of the LORD.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you are glad to go to his house.
- Ask him to bind his church together in peace.
- Pray for your own church by name.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 471 · WEEK 68

Psalm 123; Psalm 126

Eyes on the LORD; restored fortunes

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 123 and Psalm 126. Psalm 123 lifts the eyes to God in humble need. Psalm 126 celebrates the return from captivity and then prays for more. Read them together as songs of people who depend completely on God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These are two more Songs of Ascents. Psalm 123 is a short, almost whispered prayer of a people who have been treated with contempt. Psalm 126 is a classic song of return: it looks back on the joy of release from exile and forward to the harvest still to come. In the context of this unit, they offer a glimpse of what lies on the far side of the exile.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “To you I lift up my eyes, O you who are enthroned in the heavens!” (123:1).
2. “Behold, as the eyes of servants look to the hand of their master… so our eyes look to the LORD our God, till he has mercy upon us” (123:2).
3. “Have mercy upon us, O LORD, have mercy upon us, for we have had more than enough of contempt” (123:3).
4. “When the LORD restored the fortunes of Zion, we were like those who dream” (126:1).
5. “Then our mouth was filled with laughter, and our tongue with shouts of joy” (126:2).
6. “The LORD has done great things for us; we are glad” (126:3).
7. “Restore our fortunes, O LORD, like streams in the Negeb!” (126:4).
8. “Those who sow in tears shall reap with shouts of joy! He who goes out weeping, bearing the seed for sowing, shall come home with shouts of joy, bringing his sheaves

with him" (126:5-6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 123 is a prayer of upward gaze. The psalmist lifts his eyes to the one "enthroned in the heavens." He compares his people to servants who watch their master's hand, waiting for a signal. The servant does not make demands. He watches, ready, depending on the master for provision. So Israel's eyes are on the LORD until he shows mercy. The reason is contempt: "We have had more than enough of contempt... the scorn of those who are at ease." It is the cry of a people who have been mocked and who have only one place to look.

There is humility here that is rare. The servant does not need to understand. He only needs to see the hand. In a world where we are encouraged to look to ourselves, this psalm teaches us to look to God.

Psalm 126 begins with a memory of a joy so great that it seemed like a dream. "When the LORD restored the fortunes of Zion, we were like those who dream." The return from Babylon was too good to be true. The nations noticed: "The LORD has done great things for them." And they said so too. Laughter and shouting filled the people.

But then, in verse 4, the psalm becomes a prayer: "Restore our fortunes, O LORD, like streams in the Negeb." The Negeb is a dry desert region where streams flow only after the rains, suddenly and abundantly. The people have returned, but the restoration is incomplete. They ask for more. And the psalm ends with a great promise: "Those who sow in tears shall reap with shouts of joy!" The sower weeps because seed is precious in a famine. Yet he goes out and sows. And he will come home carrying sheaves. The tears are not wasted. Sowing in tears is an act of faith that the harvest will come.

For exiles reading these psalms from afar, they are both a hope and a pattern: depend on God, and remember that sowing in sorrow will end in joy.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Blessed are you who weep now, for you shall laugh" (Luke 6:21), and "Your sorrow will turn into joy" (John 16:20). 2 Corinthians 9:6 says whoever sows bountifully will reap bountifully. Galatians 6:9 says, "Let us not grow weary of doing good, for in due season we will reap." Hebrews 12:2 says that Jesus, for the joy set before him, endured the cross. Revelation 7:17 promises that God will wipe away every tear.

STEP 6

Application

Choose to look to God today as the servant looks to the master's hand. Wait for his direction.

Think of something you have been "sowing in tears," such as a hard prayer, a difficult relationship, or a sacrificial act. Continue.

Remember a joy that felt like a dream, and thank God for it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Lift your eyes to God as a servant looks to his master.

Ask him to show mercy to you.

Thank him for restoring fortunes.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 472 · WEEK 68

Ezekiel 18:1-20:49

Individual responsibility; elegy for Israel's princes [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 104 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 18:1-20:49. This is a survey day. Chapter 18 is the great chapter on individual responsibility and God's desire for repentance. Chapter 19 is a lament for Israel's princes. Chapter 20 is another review of Israel's history. Focus on chapter 18.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The exiles had a proverb: "The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children's teeth are set on edge." They were blaming their ancestors for the exile and saying that nothing they did could change it. God answers through Ezekiel with one of the most important chapters on personal responsibility and repentance. Chapters 19 and 20 then give two more views of Israel's story: laments for her kings and another review of her history of rebellion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "What do you mean by repeating this proverb... The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children's teeth are set on edge?" (18:2).
2. "Behold, all souls are mine; the soul of the father as well as the soul of the son is mine: the soul who sins shall die" (18:4).
3. "If a man is righteous and does what is just and right... he shall surely live, declares the Lord GOD" (18:5, 9).
4. "Have I any pleasure in the death of the wicked, declares the Lord GOD, and not rather that he should turn from his way and live?" (18:23).
5. "Yet you say, The way of the Lord is not just. Hear now, O house of Israel: Is my way not just?" (18:25).

6. “Repent and turn from all your transgressions, lest iniquity be your ruin” (18:30).
7. “Make yourselves a new heart and a new spirit! Why will you die, O house of Israel?” (18:31).
8. “For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live” (18:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The proverb about sour grapes expresses fatalism. The exiles felt trapped by their ancestors’ sins. God rejects the proverb and states a principle: each person is accountable for their own sin. “The soul who sins shall die.” The chapter gives three cases: a righteous father who lives, his violent son who dies, and his righteous grandson who lives. The grandson does not die for the father’s sins. Each stands on his own.

The point is not that God abandoned the principle of corporate solidarity, which appears elsewhere. It is that no one can blame the past to avoid responsibility. And it is also a word of hope: a wicked person who turns from sin will live. “None of the transgressions that he has committed shall be remembered against him.” Repentance is real. The way is open.

The question God asks in verse 23 is among the most beautiful in the Bible: “Have I any pleasure in the death of the wicked… and not rather that he should turn from his way and live?” God does not enjoy judgment. His desire is that people turn and live. The exiles complain that “the way of the Lord is not just,” but God replies that his ways are just. It is their ways that are unjust.

The chapter ends with an invitation: “Make yourselves a new heart and a new spirit!” It sounds like a command to do the impossible, since later chapters will promise that God himself gives the new heart (36:26). Both are true. We are commanded to turn, and God enables the turning. “For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone; so turn, and live.” The gospel is already audible.

Chapter 19 is a dirge about Judah’s last kings, as lion cubs trapped and a vine uprooted. Chapter 20 reviews God’s mercy and Israel’s rebellion from Egypt, closing with a promise to gather them and be sanctified in them.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Peter 3:9 says that the Lord is “not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance.” 1 Timothy 2:4 says he desires all people to be saved. Romans 14:12 says that each of us will give an account of himself to God. John 9:2-3 shows Jesus rejecting the idea

that suffering always traces to a particular person's sin. Acts 3:19 calls us to repent. Romans 6:23: "The wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life."

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you are using someone else's sin or your past as an excuse. Take responsibility, and then turn to God.

Write down Ezekiel 18:32 and carry it with you as a reminder of God's heart.

Offer the invitation of this chapter to someone who feels trapped: "Turn, and live."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you blame others or your past.
- Turn from a specific transgression and tell him so.
- Thank him that he has no pleasure in anyone's death.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 473 · WEEK 68

Ezekiel 21:1-24:27

The sword of judgment; Ezekiel's wife dies, sign act

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 117 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 21:1-24:27. A sword is drawn against Jerusalem, a rusty pot boils on a fire, and Ezekiel's wife dies at God's command. Read chapter 24 slowly. It is one of the saddest passages in the prophets.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is now 588 BC, and the siege of Jerusalem is beginning. On the very day, Ezekiel, far away in Babylon, is told to write down the date. The rest of this section describes the sword of the LORD and the sins of the city. Chapter 24 ends the first main part of the book. God tells Ezekiel that his wife will die, and he is not to mourn publicly. His grief becomes a sign to the exiles of what will happen to them when the temple falls.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, I am against you, and will draw my sword from its sheath" (21:3).
2. "A sword, a sword is sharpened and also polished" (21:9).
3. "I will make you a ruin, ruin, ruin… until he comes, the one to whom the judgment belongs, and I will give it to him" (21:27).
4. "And I sought for a man among them who should build up the wall and stand in the breach before me for the land, that I should not destroy it, but I found none" (22:30).
5. "Son of man, there were two women, the daughters of one mother" (23:2).
6. "Son of man, write down the name of this day, this very day. The king of Babylon has laid siege to Jerusalem this very day" (24:2).

7. “Behold, I am about to take the delight of your eyes away from you at a stroke; yet you shall not mourn or weep” (24:16).

8. “So I spoke to the people in the morning, and at evening my wife died” (24:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 21 shows the sword of the LORD, polished for slaughter. The king of Babylon stands at a fork in the road and uses divination to decide whether to attack Jerusalem or Rabbah. God directs the lot toward Jerusalem. It is a reminder that even pagan decisions serve God’s purpose. And the last line hints at hope: “until he comes, the one to whom the judgment belongs.” This is a messianic hint. The rightful king will come.

Chapter 22 lists the sins of the city: bloodshed, idolatry, contempt for parents, extortion from the sojourner, oppression of the fatherless and widow, profaning the Sabbath, adultery, bribery. The leaders are blamed: priests, princes, prophets, and people. Then comes the saddest verse: “I sought for a man among them who should build up the wall and stand in the breach before me for the land, that I should not destroy it, but I found none.” God was looking for an intercessor, someone like Moses. There was no one. The absence of a mediator is a deep need.

Chapter 23 tells the story of two sisters, Oholah (Samaria) and Oholibah (Jerusalem), who gave themselves to foreign lovers. It is a harsh allegory of political and religious unfaithfulness.

Chapter 24 begins with a boiling pot. The rusty pot, full of choice pieces of meat, is set on a fire until it is empty and burned clean. It shows Jerusalem under siege, with her bloodguilt cooked in her. Then comes the personal blow. God tells Ezekiel that his wife, “the delight of your eyes,” will die. He is told not to mourn publicly. The next day, he does as commanded. When the people ask why, he says that when the temple, “the delight of your eyes,” is taken, they too will be struck silent. His grief was a sign.

We should not skip past the cost to Ezekiel. He is a person with real feelings, who loves his wife. Prophetic ministry is not detached. It can mean personal loss. And in his silence, we hear the weight of the judgment.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Timothy 2:5 says, “There is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus.” Hebrews 7:25 says he always lives to make intercession. Isaiah 59:16 says God saw that there was no one to intercede, and his own arm brought salvation. Jesus stood in the breach on the

cross. Romans 12:15 says to weep with those who weep. 1 Thessalonians 4:13 says we do not grieve as those who have no hope.

STEP 6

Application

Be someone who stands in the breach for others. Pray earnestly for a specific person, family, or situation.

Think about the cost to those who serve God faithfully, and pray for pastors and missionaries who have suffered loss.

Thank Jesus, the one mediator, who stood in the breach for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for standing in the breach for you.
- Pray for someone you can stand in the breach for.
- Ask him to keep you from indifference.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 474 · WEEK 68

Ezekiel 25:1-28:26

Oracles against the nations [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 25:1-28:26. This is a survey day. These are oracles against Ammon, Moab, Edom, Philistia, and above all Tyre and its king. Look for the reasons given, and for one of the clearest echoes of the story of the fall of Satan.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the fall of Jerusalem is announced, Ezekiel turns to the nations around Judah. They had gloated over Jerusalem's fall. The long oracle against Tyre in chapters 26 to 28 is the central part. Tyre was a wealthy commercial city on the Phoenician coast and the center of Mediterranean trade. Its king is addressed with language that goes beyond any human ruler.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Because you said, Aha! over my sanctuary when it was profaned... I will give you to the people of the East" (25:3-4).
2. "Behold, I am against you, O Tyre, and will bring up many nations against you, as the sea brings up its waves" (26:3).
3. "You were the signet of perfection, full of wisdom and perfect in beauty" (28:12).
4. "You were in Eden, the garden of God" (28:13).
5. "You were an anointed guardian cherub. I placed you; you were on the holy mountain of God" (28:14).
6. "You were blameless in your ways from the day you were created, till unrighteousness was found in you" (28:15).

7. “Your heart was proud because of your beauty; you corrupted your wisdom for the sake of your splendor” (28:17).

8. “Thus says the Lord GOD: When I gather the house of Israel from the peoples among whom they are scattered… they shall dwell securely in it” (28:25-26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first oracles are brief. Ammon, Moab, Edom, and Philistia are each condemned because they mocked or took vengeance on Judah. “Because you said Aha!” God takes personally what is done to his people. The vindication of his name is the repeated purpose: “Then they will know that I am the LORD.”

Tyre’s sin is arrogance. It rejoiced in Jerusalem’s downfall because it expected to profit from the loss of a trade rival. God promises the city’s destruction, with many nations coming against it like waves. Nebuchadnezzar besieged the mainland city for thirteen years, and Alexander the Great later destroyed the island fortress. Chapter 27 is a magnificent lament over Tyre as a great merchant ship laden with goods from all the world, which sinks.

Chapter 28 addresses the prince of Tyre first as a man who said, “I am a god, I sit in the seat of the gods.” He is mocked: “You are indeed wiser than Daniel; no secret is hidden from you.” Then, in verse 12, there is a lament for the “king of Tyre,” and the language soars beyond any human king. He was in Eden. He was an anointed guardian cherub on the holy mountain of God. He was blameless until iniquity was found in him. He was cast out in pride. Many readers, from early church writers on, see in this an echo of the fall of Satan, the power behind pride. Whether or not the language refers directly to him, the pattern is the same as in Isaiah 14: pride goes before a fall.

The chapter ends with a promise to Israel. God will gather his people, and they will dwell in security, with no more pricking briers or painful thorns among their neighbors. The enemies who mocked will be removed, and God’s holiness will be shown.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 10:18: Jesus said, “I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven.” 1 Timothy 3:6 warns that a recent convert may fall into the condemnation of the devil through conceit. Revelation 18 laments the fall of Babylon in terms like Ezekiel 27. Proverbs 16:18: “Pride goes before destruction.” James 4:6: “God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.” Philippians 2:5-8 shows Christ, who humbled himself, the opposite of the king of Tyre.

STEP 6

Application

Examine where pride or self-sufficiency has crept in. Humble yourself before God.

Do not rejoice when others fall. Ask God to guard your heart from the spirit of "Aha!"

Look to Jesus, who did not count equality with God something to be grasped, but humbled himself.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to guard you from pride in gifts and wealth.
- Ask him to keep you from rejoicing in another's downfall.
- Thank him for giving grace to the humble.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 475 · WEEK 68

Ezekiel 29:1-32:32

Oracles against Egypt [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 100 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 29:1-32:32. This is a survey day. These chapters are oracles against Egypt and its Pharaoh, including the famous images of the crocodile in the Nile and the great tree cut down. Read for the theme: pride before God is brought low.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ezekiel's seven oracles against Egypt fill these chapters. Judah had often looked to Egypt for help against Babylon, and Egypt had often failed her. The oracles say that God will humble Egypt, and that she will never again be a source of false security for Israel. They are dated to the siege of Jerusalem and afterward, between 587 and 571 BC.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, I am against you, Pharaoh king of Egypt, the great dragon that lies in the midst of his streams, that says, My Nile is my own; I made it for myself" (29:3).
2. "You have been a staff of reed to the house of Israel" (29:6).
3. "And it shall be the most lowly of the kingdoms, and never again exalt itself above the nations" (29:15).
4. "And they will know that I am the LORD" (29:21, one of many repetitions).
5. "Wail, Alas for the day!" (30:2).
6. "Whom are you like in your greatness? Behold, Assyria was a cedar in Lebanon" (31:2-3).
7. "Therefore thus says the Lord GOD: Because it towered high… I will give it into the hand of a mighty one among the nations" (31:10-11).
8. "They lie among the uncircumcised, with those who are slain by the sword" (32:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Egypt is addressed as a great crocodile in the Nile who claims, "My Nile is my own; I made it for myself." It is a claim of self-creation, the essence of pride. God will pull him out with hooks in his jaws and leave him in the desert. Egypt had been a "staff of reed" to Israel. When Judah leaned on it, it splintered and pierced their hand. The lesson is that trusting in political alliances rather than in God is a broken support.

The oracles describe Egypt's fall in various images: a land laid waste, a sword coming on Cush and Put, a Pharaoh with a broken arm. God will scatter the Egyptians and bring them back after forty years, but as a lowly kingdom that never again rules. The reason is not only for judgment, but "then they will know that I am the LORD."

Chapter 31 compares Pharaoh to the great cedar of Lebanon, a tree that towered above all others in the garden of God. All the birds nested in its boughs. But it was proud, and God cut it down. The lesson is for Egypt by comparing it to Assyria, which had been another great tree and was cut down. If Assyria fell, so will Egypt.

Chapter 32 contains two laments over Pharaoh and a picture of his descent to Sheol, among the uncircumcised and the slain, in the company of Assyria, Elam, and others. The nations are brought down to the pit, one after another. It is a solemn picture of the equality of death. All who exalt themselves will lie among the dead.

The main message in all of these oracles is simple: God rules over the nations. No power, however great, is beyond his hand. It is a comfort for those who feel crushed by empires, and a warning for those who think they are secure.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 12:21-23 shows Herod struck down for accepting worship as a god. Isaiah 31:1 warns against going down to Egypt for help. Luke 1:52: "He has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate." Psalm 20:7: "Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God." Matthew 2:13-15 shows God calling his Son out of Egypt.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a "staff of reed" you have leaned on: a person, a plan, or a resource that has broken. Place your weight on God instead.

Pray for nations experiencing the pride of power and for those who suffer under it.

Remember that God rules history, and that no power is permanent.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as ruler over every nation.
- Ask him to forgive where you lean on reed staffs.
- Tell him whom you trust, and give it to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 476 · WEEK 68

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ezekiel 18:32 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

REST

Meditation

This verse is both a word of judgment and a word of love. It stands at the end of the chapter about individual responsibility, and it is God's own explanation of why he calls people to repentance.

"I have no pleasure in the death of anyone." This is a statement about God's heart. Many people think of God as someone who is eager to punish. This verse says the opposite. When someone dies in sin, God takes no delight in it. Judgment is real, and God carries it out. But it is his "strange work," as Isaiah calls it. It is not his joy.

"Declares the Lord GOD." The title used here, Adonai Yahweh, is the strongest possible way to say that the Master and covenant God is speaking. The statement is not a casual opinion. It is a sworn declaration.

“So turn, and live.” This is the invitation. The command to turn is a command to repent, to change direction. The result is life. Notice the simplicity: turn, and live. The exiles had been saying that their situation was hopeless. God says the way is open. Turn.

The Christian reads this verse in light of the cross. God’s desire for people to live is shown in the fact that he sent his Son. “God so loved the world that he gave his only Son.” In Christ, the call to turn is also a call to come to the one who has taken the death we deserved.

Say this verse for yourself when you are tempted to think that God is only waiting to condemn you. Say it for others when you pray for them. God does not want anyone to die. Turn, and live.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you prayed three Songs of Ascents: Psalm 122, the joy of going up to the house of the LORD, and Psalms 123 and 126, the servant’s eyes on his master and the promise that those who sow in tears will reap with shouts of joy. You read Ezekiel 18, in which God rejects the proverb about sour grapes, declares that each soul is accountable, and says that he has no pleasure in the death of anyone. You read about the sword drawn against Jerusalem, God’s search for someone to stand in the breach, and the death of Ezekiel’s wife as a sign of the grief to come. You surveyed the oracles against the nations: Ammon, Moab, Edom, Philistia, Tyre and its proud king, and Egypt with its crocodile and fallen cedar. The week taught that each person is responsible before God, that he delights in repentance, and that pride before him is brought low.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Ezekiel 18 insists that no one can blame the past for their present. Is there an area where you have been tempted to say, “The fathers have eaten sour grapes”?

God looked for someone to stand in the breach and found none. Who is someone you could stand in the breach for through prayer this week?

Psalm 126 says that those who sow in tears will reap with shouts of joy. What is something you are sowing in tears right now, and what would it look like to trust the harvest?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he has no pleasure in anyone's death.

Thank him for the cross where he stood in the breach for you.

Turn to him and live.

DAY 477 · WEEK 69

Psalm 128; Psalm 129

Blessed is everyone who fears the LORD

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 128 and Psalm 129. These are Songs of Ascents. Psalm 128 describes the blessing of a family that fears the LORD. Psalm 129 remembers a long history of affliction and survival. Read them as the two sides of pilgrim life: peace at home, and enemies on the road.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These two psalms are placed side by side in the Songs of Ascents. Psalm 128 is a wisdom psalm that was likely sung at weddings and family festivals. Psalm 129 recalls how Israel had been attacked "from my youth" yet never overcome. Together they speak to people who had been through exile and survived: God blesses the faithful, and he preserves his people through persecution.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is everyone who fears the LORD, who walks in his ways!" (128:1).
2. "You shall eat the fruit of the labor of your hands; you shall be blessed, and it shall be well with you" (128:2).
3. "Your wife will be like a fruitful vine within your house; your children will be like olive shoots around your table" (128:3).
4. "Behold, thus shall the man be blessed who fears the LORD" (128:4).
5. "The LORD bless you from Zion! May you see the prosperity of Jerusalem all the days of your life!" (128:5).
6. "Greatly have they afflicted me from my youth" (129:1).

7. “Yet they have not prevailed against me” (129:2).

8. “The LORD is righteous; he has cut the cords of the wicked” (129:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 128 is a short portrait of a blessed life. The blessing is not described in terms of wealth or power, but of ordinary things: work that is fruitful, a family that is flourishing, and a table with children around it. The source is “the fear of the LORD,” a reverent trust that shapes daily life. The man who walks in God’s ways finds that his labor is blessed, and his home is a place of joy.

The picture of the fruitful vine and olive shoots is of life and growth. A vine in a home was a sign of abundance. Olive shoots, around a table, were a sign of vitality. The psalm does not promise that every godly person will have a large family or comfortable job. It describes the shape of God’s blessing in the ordinary life of his people, and it places that blessing within the larger blessing of Zion: “May you see the prosperity of Jerusalem all the days of your life! May you see your children’s children!” Personal and communal blessing go together.

Psalm 129 is a contrast. “Greatly have they afflicted me from my youth.” Israel’s history from Egypt on has been one of oppression. “Yet they have not prevailed against me.” It is a statement of survival. Plowmen plowed on my back, and made long their furrows. But the LORD is righteous. He cut the cords of the wicked. And the psalm closes with a curse on those who hate Zion: let them be like grass on the housetops, which withers before it grows, and which no reaper can use. Even in affliction, the people were not destroyed.

Together, these psalms speak to the situation of the exiles. They had survived. They were returning home to rebuild homes and families. The God who had kept them through persecution would bless them in ordinary life.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 6:33 says to seek first the kingdom of God. Ephesians 5:22-33 and 6:1-4 teach about the family under God. Psalm 1:2-3 describes the blessed person like a tree by the water. Romans 8:35-37 says that in all things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us. 2 Corinthians 4:8-9: “We are afflicted in every way, but not crushed.” Matthew 16:18: the gates of hell shall not prevail against the church.

STEP 6

Application

Give thanks for ordinary blessings: your work, your table, your family or friends. Name them to God.

Pray for the families in your church to flourish in the fear of the LORD.

Remember the afflictions you have survived. Say, “Yet they have not prevailed against me,” as a testimony.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to bless your work and your home.
- Thank him that he is righteous and cuts the cords of the wicked.
- Bless the families of your church.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

“And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.”

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 478 · WEEK 69

Psalm 131; Psalm 133; Psalm 134

Childlike trust; unity; blessing

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 131, Psalm 133, and Psalm 134. These are three of the shortest psalms in the Psalter, and they are full. Read each one slowly. They teach childlike trust, brotherly unity, and a blessing at night.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Three more Songs of Ascents. Psalm 131 is a psalm of David about quieting the soul. Psalm 133 celebrates the unity of God's people. Psalm 134 is the last of the group of pilgrim songs before the final two, a call to the servants of the LORD who stand by night in the house of the LORD. Together they are a tender picture of what the pilgrim learned on the journey to Zion: humility, fellowship, and worship.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, my heart is not lifted up; my eyes are not raised too high; I do not occupy myself with things too great and too marvelous for me" (131:1).
2. "But I have calmed and quieted my soul, like a weaned child with its mother; like a weaned child is my soul within me" (131:2).
3. "O Israel, hope in the LORD from this time forth and forevermore" (131:3).
4. "Behold, how good and pleasant it is when brothers dwell in unity!" (133:1).
5. "It is like the precious oil on the head, running down on the beard, on the beard of Aaron" (133:2).
6. "It is like the dew of Hermon, which falls on the mountains of Zion!" (133:3).
7. "For there the LORD has commanded the blessing, life forevermore" (133:3).

8 “Come, bless the LORD, all you servants of the LORD, who stand by night in the house of the LORD!” (134:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 131 is a prayer of humility and rest. David says, “My heart is not lifted up.” He is not proud and does not chase after impossible things. Then he describes how he has calmed his soul like a weaned child with its mother. A weaned child no longer fusses for milk but rests content in the mother’s arms, not because of what she provides, but because of who she is. This is a mature form of trust. It does not demand answers or benefits. It rests in the presence of the one who loves. The psalm ends with a call to Israel: hope in the LORD. Humility and hope go together.

Psalm 133 is a short celebration of unity. “Behold, how good and pleasant it is when brothers dwell in unity!” The image is of two kinds of abundance. The first is the anointing oil poured on Aaron’s head, running down to his beard and the collar of his robes, a picture of a lavish, fragrant blessing that covers the whole person. The second is the dew of Hermon falling on Zion. It is refreshing and life-giving. The meaning is that unity among the people of God is not something small but a rich gift from God. And “there the LORD has commanded the blessing, life forevermore.” God commands blessing where his people dwell together.

Psalm 134 is the last of the set before the closing pair. It is a call to worship, spoken to the temple servants who keep watch by night. “Come, bless the LORD.” Their work is praise. They lift up their hands in the sanctuary and bless the LORD. Then the response comes: “May the LORD bless you from Zion, he who made heaven and earth!” The blessing goes both ways.

The whole sequence of pilgrim songs ends with a night watch and a blessing. After a long journey, the people arrive, and the end of the journey is worship.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Unless you turn and become like children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven” (Matthew 18:3). Matthew 11:28-29 invites those who are weary to take his yoke, for he is gentle and lowly in heart. John 17:20-23 shows Jesus praying that his people may be one. Ephesians 4:1-6 urges the unity of the Spirit. Colossians 3:14 says love binds everything together in perfect harmony. Revelation 7:15 shows the multitudes serving God day and night in his temple.

STEP 6

Application

Quiet your soul today. Sit for five minutes, like a weaned child with its mother, asking for nothing.

Work for unity in your church or family. Is there someone you need to forgive or reconcile with?

Pray Psalm 134 at the end of the day, as a night watch, blessing the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to quiet your soul like a weaned child.
- Thank him for the gift of unity among his people.
- Bless the LORD in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

"And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh."

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 479 · WEEK 69

Ezekiel 33:1-35:15

The watchman renewed; the shepherds; the mountains of Israel

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 33:1-35:15. The news that Jerusalem has fallen reaches Babylon, and Ezekiel's tone changes. God renews the watchman's call and then turns on the false shepherds of Israel and promises to be the shepherd himself. Read chapter 34 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In 585 BC, a fugitive from Jerusalem arrived in Babylon with the news that the city had fallen. Ezekiel's long silence ended, and he began to speak with a new message: hope. The first part of his book was about judgment. The next is about restoration. Chapter 33 reconfirms his role as a watchman and renews God's appeal to repent. Chapter 34 is one of the greatest chapters on shepherds in the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "So you, son of man, I have made a watchman for the house of Israel" (33:7).
2. "As I live, declares the Lord GOD, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked, but that the wicked turn from his way and live" (33:11).
3. "Behold, you are to them like one who sings lustful songs with a beautiful voice and plays well on an instrument, for they hear what you say, but they will not do it" (33:32).
4. "Woe to the shepherds of Israel who have been feeding themselves! Should not shepherds feed the sheep?" (34:2).
5. "The weak you have not strengthened, the sick you have not healed, the injured you have not bound up" (34:4).
6. "Behold, I, I myself will search for my sheep and will seek them out" (34:11).

7. “I will make them lie down, declares the Lord GOD. I will seek the lost, and I will bring back the strayed” (34:15-16).

8. “And I will set up over them one shepherd, my servant David, and he shall feed them” (34:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The news of Jerusalem’s fall releases Ezekiel from his silence. God renews his commission as watchman. The principle is repeated: if the watchman sees danger and warns, he has done his duty. If not, the blood is on his hands. And God restates the call to repentance of chapter 18: “Turn back, turn back from your evil ways, for why will you die, O house of Israel?” The people still say, “Our transgressions are upon us… how then can we live?” God’s answer is always the same: turn and live.

Verse 32 is a sober observation. The people come to hear Ezekiel as if he were an entertainer. They enjoy the sermon like a beautiful song, but do not act on it. Hearing without doing is the persistent danger.

Chapter 34 is the heart of this section. God condemns the shepherds, meaning the leaders, who have fed themselves and not the flock. They have not strengthened the weak or healed the sick or sought the lost. They have ruled with force and harshness. As a result, the sheep were scattered. God declares that he is against the shepherds. Then comes the most comforting passage: “I, I myself will search for my sheep and will seek them out.” Again and again God says what he will do: search, rescue, gather, bring, feed, make them lie down, seek the lost, bind up the injured, strengthen the weak. He will be the shepherd himself.

And then the promise: “I will set up over them one shepherd, my servant David.” God will shepherd through a king of David’s line, and make a covenant of peace, so that the wild beasts cease from the land, showers of blessing come, and the sheep live securely.

The people of God are described as “my sheep, human sheep, and I am your God.” It is among the most intimate pictures of the relationship between God and his people.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus says, “I am the good shepherd” (John 10:11), and lives out chapter 34: he seeks the lost (Luke 19:10), heals the sick, and binds up the brokenhearted. Luke 15:4-7 tells the story of the shepherd who seeks the one lost sheep. Matthew 9:36 shows him having compassion on the

crowds because they were “like sheep without a shepherd.” 1 Peter 5:1-4 calls elders to shepherd the flock willingly, as examples, and promises the unfading crown from the chief Shepherd. Hebrews 13:20 calls him the great shepherd.

STEP 6

Application

Thank Jesus for being the shepherd who searched for you.

If you have a role of leadership, ask whether you are feeding the flock or feeding yourself. Pray for pastors and church leaders.

Look for a “strayed” or “injured” sheep near you, and reach out to them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank the Good Shepherd for seeking the lost and binding up the injured.

Ask him to strengthen you where you are weak.

Pray for the shepherds you know.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

“And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.”

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 480 · WEEK 69

Ezekiel 36:1-37:28

The new heart; the valley of dry bones, Spirit and resurrection

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 63 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 36:1-37:28. These are among the most important chapters in the Old Testament. God promises to cleanse his people, give them a new heart, and put his Spirit within them. Then Ezekiel sees a valley of dry bones that come to life. Read both slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the central passage of Ezekiel's message of hope. The exiles are in despair: "Our bones are dried up, and our hope is lost." God's answer is a series of promises that go beyond a mere return to the land. He will transform the people themselves, from within. These chapters were written around 586 to 570 BC, and they are quoted in the New Testament as a description of the work of the Spirit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you shall be clean from all your uncleannesses, and from all your idols I will cleanse you" (36:25).
2. "And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh" (36:26).
3. "And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes and be careful to obey my rules" (36:27).
4. "You shall be my people, and I will be your God" (36:28).
5. "It is not for your sake, O house of Israel, that I am about to act, but for the sake of my holy name" (36:22).

6. “Then he said to me, Son of man, can these bones live? And I answered, O Lord GOD, you know” (37:3).
7. “Behold, I will cause breath to enter you, and you shall live” (37:5).
8. “And I will put my Spirit within you, and you shall live, and I will place you in your own land. Then you shall know that I am the LORD” (37:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 36 begins with the mountains of Israel and God’s promise to restore the land. But the central part is about the people. God says that he is acting for the sake of his holy name, which had been profaned among the nations. The restoration is not because Israel deserves it. It is for God’s glory. This is the root of grace.

Then come the promises. First, cleansing: “I will sprinkle clean water on you.” Second, a new heart: “I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.” The stone heart is hard, unresponsive. The flesh heart is soft and alive. Third, the Spirit: “I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes.” This is the answer to Jeremiah’s promise of the new covenant: the law written on the heart. It is accomplished by the Spirit. The command in chapter 18, “Make yourselves a new heart,” is now fulfilled by God’s gift. The result: you will be my people, and I will be your God.

Chapter 37 gives the valley of dry bones. Ezekiel is set down in a valley full of bones, very many and very dry. God asks, “Can these bones live?” Ezekiel replies, “O Lord GOD, you know.” He is told to prophesy to the bones, and they come together, bone to bone. Sinews and flesh appear, and skin covers them. But there is no breath. He then prophesies to the breath, and the breath comes, and they stand on their feet, an exceedingly great army. It is a picture of national revival: “Our bones are dried up… we are cut off.” God says: “I will open your graves and raise you from your graves.”

The two chapters together show the means: the word of God and the Spirit of God. The same Word that prophesies and the same Spirit that gives life. Ezekiel ends with the vision of the two sticks, Judah and Israel, joined into one in the hand of the LORD, with David as king and an everlasting covenant of peace, and the sanctuary in their midst forever.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said to Nicodemus, “Unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God” (John 3:5), echoing Ezekiel 36:25-27. Titus 3:5 speaks of “the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit.” 2 Corinthians 3:3 and Romans 8:9-11 describe

the Spirit within us. Ephesians 2:1-5 says we were dead in trespasses, and God made us alive. John 5:25 says the dead will hear the voice of the Son of God and live. Romans 11:15 speaks of life from the dead.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Ezekiel 36:26, and pray it for yourself and someone you love.

Reflect on the phrase, “Can these bones live?” Where do you feel spiritually dry? Answer as Ezekiel did: “O Lord GOD, you know.”

Ask the Holy Spirit to breathe on a dead place in your life or your church.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the new heart and the Spirit he has put within you.
- Ask him to breathe life into a dry place in you.
- Ask him to cleanse you from your idols.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

“And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.”

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 481 · WEEK 69

Ezekiel 38:1-39:29

Gog and Magog, God's ultimate protection

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 38:1-39:29. A great invasion by Gog of Magog is described, and God defeats it. These chapters are hard to interpret, so read for the main point: God protects his restored people, and the nations will know he is the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the restoration promises of chapters 33 to 37, these chapters describe a final attack on God's people. Gog, the chief prince of Meshech and Tubal, comes with a coalition of nations from the far north against a people living securely in unwalled villages. The name Gog does not match any known historical king. Interpreters understand the passage in different ways: as a symbol of the final assault against God's people, as a prediction of a particular event, or as apocalyptic imagery. All agree on its main point.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Son of man, set your face toward Gog, of the land of Magog, the chief prince of Meshech and Tubal" (38:2).
2. "I will turn you about and put hooks into your jaws" (38:4).
3. "After many days you will be mustered. In the latter years you will go against the land that has been restored from war" (38:8).
4. "You will say, I will go up against the land of unwalled villages" (38:11).
5. "I will show my greatness and my holiness and make myself known in the eyes of many nations" (38:23).
6. "I will give to Gog a place for burial in Israel" (39:11).

7. “And the house of Israel shall know that I am the LORD their God, from that day forward” (39:22).

8. “And I will not hide my face anymore from them, when I pour out my Spirit upon the house of Israel” (39:29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The attack comes at a time of peace. The people are dwelling securely, apparently defenseless. Gog’s plan is to seize plunder. But God says, “I will turn you about and put hooks into your jaws.” Though Gog thinks he is acting by his own will, God is leading him out. The invasion is under God’s control, and its purpose is to display God’s greatness.

The defeat is dramatic: an earthquake, a plague, torrential rain, hailstones, fire and sulfur. The invading armies turn on each other. Their weapons are so numerous that Israel will burn them for seven years. The bodies are buried in a valley, and it takes seven months to clear the land. All of this serves the aim: “I will make myself known in the eyes of many nations. Then they will know that I am the LORD.”

The big question is how to understand this. Some interpret it as a literal battle in the end times. Others see in it a symbol of the continuing assault of the powers of this world against God’s people, which ends with God’s victory. Revelation 20:7-9 takes up the names Gog and Magog for the final rebellion of the nations after the thousand years, and says fire comes down from heaven and consumes them. In this use, Gog and Magog stand for the last desperate attack on God’s people. Whatever the details, the point is that God has the last word.

The conclusion in chapter 39 is a reminder of why the exile happened and a promise: “The nations shall know that the house of Israel went into captivity for their iniquity.” But now God will restore their fortunes, “and I will not hide my face anymore from them, when I pour out my Spirit upon the house of Israel.” The final note is the Spirit. The people who were scattered will be gathered and filled.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 20:7-10 describes the last rebellion of the nations, “Gog and Magog,” and their defeat by fire from heaven. Revelation 19:17-21 pictures the great supper of God, echoing Ezekiel 39:17-20. Joel 2:28-29 and Acts 2:16-18 speak of the pouring out of the Spirit. Romans 8:31 asks, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” Psalm 2 shows the nations raging and the LORD laughing in heaven. Matthew 16:18 says the gates of hell will not prevail.

STEP 6

Application

Whatever happens in the world, remember that God has the last word.

Do not let fear of the future overshadow your trust in the God who protects his people.

Pray that the Spirit would be poured out on your church and on the people of God worldwide.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you fear from the enemies of his people.

Thank him that he is sovereign over every nation.

Ask him for confidence in the end.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

"And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh."

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 482 · WEEK 69

Ezekiel 40:1-43:27

The new Temple vision begins [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 107 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 40:1-43:27. This is a survey day. A man with a measuring rod leads Ezekiel through a vision of a new temple, and then the glory of the LORD returns. Do not worry about the measurements. Read for the return of the glory in chapter 43.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In 573 BC, the twenty-fifth year of the exile and the fourteenth after Jerusalem's fall, Ezekiel is taken in a vision to a very high mountain in Israel. A man whose appearance is like bronze, with a measuring line in his hand, shows him a great temple complex. This is the last major vision of the book. It is a temple that has never been built in this form. Interpreters differ on its meaning, but it clearly points to a restored worship in which God's presence is central.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In visions of God he brought me to the land of Israel, and set me down on a very high mountain" (40:2).
2. "And behold, there was a man whose appearance was like bronze, with a linen cord and a measuring reed in his hand" (40:3).
3. "Son of man, look with your eyes, and hear with your ears, and set your heart upon all that I shall show you" (40:4).
4. "And behold, the glory of the God of Israel was coming from the east" (43:2).
5. "And the glory of the LORD entered the temple by the gate facing east" (43:4).
6. "Behold, the glory of the LORD filled the temple" (43:5).

7. “Son of man, this is the place of my throne and the place of the soles of my feet, where I will dwell in the midst of the people of Israel forever” (43:7).

8. “This is the law of the temple: the whole territory on the top of the mountain all around shall be most holy” (43:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The measuring of the temple takes up chapters 40 to 42, and its precision is striking. The gates, the courts, the chambers, the altar, the walls are all measured with exact detail. The temple is a perfect square, ordered and holy. The point is not the architecture but its meaning: God intends to dwell among his people in an orderly, holy relationship. The exiles lost the first temple, and this vision gave them hope that God would restore a place of worship.

The vision is a puzzle, because the dimensions do not match Solomon’s temple or the second temple that was later built. Some scholars take it as a literal temple yet to come. Others see it as a symbolic picture of God’s perfect dwelling with his people, fulfilled in Christ and the church, and consummated in the new creation. Revelation 21 describes the new Jerusalem as a cube, with no temple, “for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb.” Whatever view is held, the vision shows that God’s dwelling is not abandoned.

The climax is in chapter 43. Ezekiel had watched the glory leave the temple through the east gate in chapters 10 and 11. Now it returns through the same gate. The sound is like the sound of many waters, and the earth shines with his glory. The prophet falls on his face. “The glory of the LORD filled the temple.” This is the answer to the question that haunted the exiles: Has God left us forever? No. The glory returns.

God says, “This is the place of my throne… where I will dwell in the midst of the people of Israel forever.” And the condition is repentance: they must no more defile his holy name. The restoration includes a call to measure the pattern and be ashamed of their iniquities.

The message for all believers is that God wants to dwell among his people. The distance caused by sin has been overcome, and his glory returns.

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:14 says, “The Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory.” John 2:19-21 shows Jesus speaking of the temple of his body. 1 Corinthians 3:16-17 and Ephesians 2:19-22 call the church God’s temple, built on the foundation of the apostles and

prophets with Christ as the cornerstone. Revelation 21:3 says, “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man.” Revelation 21:22 says there is no temple in the city, for the Lord God and the Lamb are its temple.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God that his glory is not confined to a building, and that through Christ it has returned to dwell among his people.

Think of yourself as part of a temple being built. What does it mean for your holiness and your relationships in the church?

Pray for the return of God’s manifest presence in your worship.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his glory fills his house.

Thank Jesus, in whom his presence dwells among us.

Ask him to make you a holy temple.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

“And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.”

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 483 · WEEK 69

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ezekiel 36:26 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh."

EZEKIEL 36:26

REST

Meditation

This verse is one of the clearest statements in the Old Testament of what God does in salvation. It describes an operation, not a program of self-improvement.

"I will give you a new heart." Notice who is the actor: "I." God does it. The people had been told to make themselves a new heart (Ezekiel 18:31), and they could not. Here, God promises to give one. The heart in Hebrew thought is the center of the whole person: mind, will, and emotions. Salvation reaches that deep. It is not just a change of behavior or beliefs but of the self at its center.

"And a new spirit I will put within you." The new spirit is a new disposition, a renewed inner life. In the next verse, God clarifies that this is his own Spirit: "I will put my Spirit within you." The new life is the life of the Holy Spirit in us.

“And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh.” The heart of stone is the natural condition of fallen humanity, hard, unresponsive to God, impossible to change by willpower. A stone cannot make itself soft. Only God can remove it.

“And give you a heart of flesh.” The heart of flesh is warm, living, and responsive. It can feel, love, trust, and obey. This is what happens at conversion and continues in sanctification. We are given hearts that want what God wants.

For the Christian, this verse is both an encouragement and a prayer. It encourages us because we do not have to manufacture our own spiritual life. It is a gift. And it is a prayer because we constantly need our hearts to be kept soft. Say it for yourself and for those you love who seem far from God. He is the one who gives hearts of flesh.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you prayed three groups of Songs of Ascents on family blessing, survival through affliction, childlike trust, and the beauty of unity. In Ezekiel, you heard the watchman called again and the people warned that they were listening to him like a song but not acting. You read God’s rebuke of the false shepherds and his promise to search for his sheep himself and to set up one shepherd, his servant David. You read the great promises of Ezekiel 36 and 37: cleansing water, a new heart and spirit, and the Spirit within us, and the valley of dry bones that live by the word and the breath. You read of Gog’s final assault and God’s victory, and then the vision of the new temple and the return of the glory by the east gate. The week taught that God himself will do what his people cannot, giving them hearts of flesh and his own Spirit, and returning to dwell among them.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

God says he will give a heart of flesh and put his Spirit within us. Where do you most need him to do this soft, living work in you?

God promises to shepherd his sheep himself, to seek the lost and bind up the injured. Which of these do you need the Shepherd to do for you right now?

Ezekiel asked whether dry bones can live, and answered, “O Lord GOD, you know.” What seems dead in your life or church that you can bring to God in that spirit?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you a new heart.
- Ask him to remove the heart of stone in you.
- Thank him for the Shepherd who seeks you.

DAY 484 · WEEK 70

Ezekiel 44:1-46:24

The Prince; priestly regulations; the inheritance [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 44:1-46:24. This is a survey day. These chapters describe the closed east gate, the rules for priests, the division of the land, and the worship of the prince and the people. Read for the main principle: worship in the restored temple is holy and ordered, and God's people are to approach with reverence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This section follows the return of the glory in chapter 43. The details of the restored worship are laid out: who may enter, who may serve, how the festivals are to be kept. Many of the details are hard to match with any known period of Israel's history, and Christians have understood them in different ways. The common thread is the holiness of God and the order of worship he requires.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This gate shall remain shut; it shall not be opened, and no one shall enter by it, for the LORD, the God of Israel, has entered by it" (44:2).
2. "No foreigner, uncircumcised in heart and flesh, of all the foreigners who are among the people of Israel, shall enter my sanctuary" (44:9).
3. "They shall teach my people the difference between the holy and the common, and show them how to distinguish between the unclean and the clean" (44:23).
4. "I am their inheritance: you shall give them no possession in Israel; I am their possession" (44:28).
5. "The land shall be for the LORD… a holy portion" (45:1).

6. “My princes shall no more oppress my people” (45:8).
7. “You shall have just balances, a just ephah, and a just bath” (45:10).
8. “The people of the land shall bow down at the entrance of that gate before the LORD on the Sabbaths and on the new moons” (46:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The closed east gate is a symbol of God’s presence. The glory entered through it, so it stays shut. It is a picture of the finality of God’s return. Only the prince may sit in the gateway to eat bread before the LORD. The restored community is to be ordered around the holy.

The priests’ regulations are demanding. The Levites who went astray in idolatry are limited to lesser duties, while the sons of Zadok, who stayed faithful, may come near. The priests are to be careful in their clothing, grooming, and conduct. They are to teach the people the difference between the holy and the common, to judge disputes, and to keep the Sabbaths. In 44:28, there is a note that echoes Psalm 73: “I am their inheritance.” The priests have no land because God himself is their portion.

Chapter 45 sets aside a holy portion of land for the sanctuary, for the priests, and for the Levites, and a portion for the city and the prince. The prince is warned not to oppress the people. It is a vision of just leadership. “Enough, O princes of Israel! Put away violence and oppression.” He is to maintain just weights and measures. Worship and justice are joined.

Chapter 46 describes the offerings and worship of the prince and the people. The prince leads the people and enters with them: “When they go in, he shall go in.” He is among them, not above them. The chapter ends with the kitchens where the priests and people boil and bake the sacrifices.

For the Christian, the details are difficult. But we can see the principles. God is to be approached with reverence. The leader must be just and humble. Those who serve are to know God as their portion. And the people are to come together to worship. The New Testament shows that Christ has become our great high priest and our sacrifice, so these shadows find their fulfillment in him.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 8:1-6 and 9:11-14 show that Christ is the high priest of the true tent, and that his blood obtains eternal redemption. Hebrews 10:19-22 invites us to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus. 1 Peter 2:5, 9 calls the church a holy priesthood and a royal priesthood.

Revelation 1:6 says Christ has made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father. Romans 12:1: present your bodies as a living sacrifice.

STEP 6

Application

Approach worship this week with reverence. Prepare your heart before you gather.

If you lead others, ask whether you walk among them, as the prince did, or above them.

Thank God that he is your portion and inheritance, like the Levites.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that his presence is among his people.
- Ask him to teach you to distinguish the holy from the common.
- Ask him to guard your worship.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

"If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 485 · WEEK 70

Ezekiel 47:1-48:35

The river of life; the new land, new creation anticipated

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 47:1-48:35. A river flows from the temple and turns a desert into a place of life, and the land is divided among the twelve tribes, ending with a city whose name is "The LORD Is There." Read the river carefully, and notice what it does.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the last vision of Ezekiel's book. After the return of the glory, a river flows from the threshold of the temple. It grows deeper as it moves toward the Dead Sea, and wherever it goes, it brings life. Then the land is divided fairly among the tribes, including foreigners who live among them. The book ends with the new name of the city, a promise that answers the sorrow of the first part: the glory had left, and now God is present forever.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, water was issuing from below the threshold of the temple toward the east" (47:1).
2. "Again he measured a thousand, and led me through the water, water that was to the ankles... to the knees... to the loins" (47:3-4).
3. "It was a river that I could not pass through, for the water had risen. It was deep enough to swim in" (47:5).
4. "This water flows toward the eastern region and goes down into the Arabah, and enters the Sea. When the water flows into the Sea, the water of the Sea will become fresh" (47:8).
5. "Swarms of creatures will live wherever the river goes... everything will live where the river goes" (47:9).

6. “On the banks, on both sides of the river, there will grow all kinds of trees for food. Their leaves will not wither, nor their fruit fail” (47:12).
7. “You shall divide it for an inheritance among yourselves and for the sojourners who reside among you” (47:22).
8. “And the name of the city from that time on shall be, The LORD Is There” (48:35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The river begins as a trickle under the temple threshold. Following the guide, Ezekiel wades in at the ankles, then the knees, then the waist, and then it is a river he cannot cross. The image is of overflowing, increasing grace. A small source from the presence of God becomes a flood of life. And the direction is downhill into the Judean desert, to the Dead Sea, the most lifeless place on earth. The salty water becomes fresh, and fish swarm there. Fishermen stand on the shore. The river brings life even to death.

On the banks, fruit trees grow every month. The leaves do not wither. The fruit is for food, and the leaves for healing. And the reason is stated: “because the water for them flows from the sanctuary.” All life flows from the presence of God. This is Eden restored.

The rest of the chapter deals with the boundaries of the land and the division among the tribes. Notable is the inclusion of the sojourners: “You shall allot it for an inheritance among yourselves and for the foreigners who reside among you and have fathered children among you. You shall treat them as native-born Israelites.” The covenant community is extended to include outsiders.

Chapter 48 lists the tribal portions, each as a strip running east to west, with the holy portion at the center. The city has twelve gates, named for the twelve tribes. And the book ends with its last line: “The name of the city from that time on shall be, The LORD Is There.” It is a fitting end for a book that began with God’s glory leaving. The glory is back, and it will not leave again.

For the Christian, the river is a picture of the Spirit and the gospel, flowing from the presence of God to the dead places of the world. It finds its fulfillment in Revelation 22.

STEP 5

Connection

John 7:37-39 says that Jesus invited anyone who is thirsty to come, and that out of his heart will flow rivers of living water, referring to the Spirit. Revelation 22:1-2 describes the river of the water of life flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb, with the tree of life on both

banks, “and the leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations.” Revelation 21:3 says, “The dwelling place of God is with man.” Revelation 21:12-14 describes the city with twelve gates. Ephesians 2:19 says that Gentiles are no longer strangers but fellow citizens.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a “Dead Sea” in your life or community. Pray for the river of God’s life to reach it.

Ask whether the grace you have received is deeper than “ankle-deep.” Wade further in.

Welcome a stranger into your community, as the tribes were told to welcome the sojourners.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to let the river of his life flow into dead places in you.
- Thank Jesus, the source of living water.
- Pray for a place that is barren.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

“If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up.”

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 486 · WEEK 70

Daniel 1:1-2:49

Faithfulness in exile; Nebuchadnezzar's dream

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 1:1-2:49. A young man taken to Babylon refuses to compromise, and later interprets a king's dream about a statue and a stone. Notice how Daniel and his friends live as exiles, and notice what the dream says about the kingdoms of the earth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Daniel was taken to Babylon as a teenager in 605 BC, in the first deportation. He and three friends were selected to be trained for the king's service. Daniel is the book that addresses the question of how God's people live in a foreign empire. It is written partly in Hebrew and partly in Aramaic, the language of international affairs (2:4 to 7:28). It moves from stories of faithfulness in the first six chapters to visions of the future in the last six.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But Daniel resolved that he would not defile himself with the king's food" (1:8).
2. "God gave these four youths learning and skill in all literature and wisdom" (1:17).
3. "Let the name of God be blessed forever and ever, to whom belong wisdom and might" (2:20).
4. "He changes times and seasons; he removes kings and sets up kings" (2:21).
5. "No wise men, enchanters, magicians, or astrologers can show to the king the mystery that the king has asked, but there is a God in heaven who reveals mysteries" (2:27-28).
6. "You, O king, were looking, and behold, a great image" (2:31).
7. "A stone was cut out by no human hand, and it struck the image on its feet of iron and clay, and broke them in pieces" (2:34).

8 “And in the days of those kings the God of heaven will set up a kingdom that shall never be destroyed” (2:44).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first chapter shows the pressure of assimilation. The young men are renamed with Babylonian names that honor Babylonian gods, taught a new language and literature, and given food from the king’s table. Daniel draws a line at the food, probably because it had been offered to idols or violated the law. He does so respectfully, asks for a test, and God honors it. Faithfulness here is both principled and wise. They serve the empire well, and God gives them skill. The lesson is that we can serve in a foreign place without compromising our loyalty to God.

Chapter 2 introduces the first great vision. Nebuchadnezzar has a dream that troubles him, and he demands that his wise men tell him both the dream and its meaning. They cannot. The king orders them all killed, including Daniel. Daniel asks for time and prays with his friends. God reveals the dream in the night. Daniel’s response is a hymn of praise: “Blessed be the name of God forever and ever, to whom belong wisdom and might. He changes times and seasons; he removes kings and sets up kings.” Before he tells the king, he gives God the credit. And in front of the king, he says plainly: “No wise men… can show the king the mystery, but there is a God in heaven who reveals mysteries.”

The dream is of a great statue with a head of gold, chest of silver, belly of bronze, legs of iron, and feet of iron mixed with clay. A stone, not cut by human hands, strikes the feet, and the whole statue becomes dust. The stone grows into a mountain that fills the earth. Daniel interprets: the head is Nebuchadnezzar, and the other metals are successive kingdoms. The stone is the kingdom that God will set up, which will never be destroyed. The message is that the great empires of human history will pass, and God’s kingdom will last forever.

Nebuchadnezzar falls on his face and acknowledges Daniel’s God as “God of gods and Lord of kings.” Though the king’s confession is incomplete, it shows that God’s hand can reach even the rulers of the earth.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the stone that the builders rejected (Matthew 21:42-44; 1 Peter 2:4-8). Luke 1:33 says of Jesus, “Of his kingdom there will be no end.” Matthew 6:10 teaches us to pray, “Your kingdom come.” Romans 12:2 says, “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed.” Colossians 2:3 says that in Christ are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge. 1 Peter 2:11-12 calls us to live as exiles with good conduct.

STEP 6

Application

Where do you face pressure to compromise? Decide, as Daniel did, what you will not defile yourself with, and do it graciously.

Pray with friends, as Daniel did, when you face a situation you cannot handle on your own.

Praise God before you ask for his help. Say Daniel 2:20-21 aloud.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless the name of God, to whom wisdom and might belong.

Ask him to help you stand firm in a foreign place.

Thank him that he changes times and seasons.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

"If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 487 · WEEK 70

Daniel 3:1-4:37

The fiery furnace; Nebuchadnezzar humbled

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 3:1-4:37. Three men are thrown into a furnace for refusing to bow, and a fourth appears with them. Then Nebuchadnezzar, the proudest man on earth, is humbled and learns that Heaven rules. Read the three men's reply in 3:16-18 carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 3 happens some years after the dream of chapter 2. Nebuchadnezzar builds a gold statue ninety feet high and commands everyone to bow when the music plays. Three of Daniel's friends, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, refuse. Chapter 4 is a first-person account from the king himself, a testimony of how God humbled him for his pride, then restored him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king" (3:17).
2. "But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up" (3:18).
3. "Behold, I see four men unbound, walking in the midst of the fire, and they are not hurt; and the appearance of the fourth is like a son of the gods" (3:25).
4. "Blessed be the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, who has sent his angel and delivered his servants" (3:28).
5. "The Most High rules the kingdom of men and gives it to whom he will" (4:17).

6. “Is not this great Babylon, which I have built by my mighty power as a royal residence and for the glory of my majesty?” (4:30).
7. “At the end of the days I, Nebuchadnezzar, lifted my eyes to heaven, and my reason returned to me” (4:34).
8. “And those who walk in pride he is able to humble” (4:37).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three men’s reply to the king is among the greatest declarations of faith in the Bible. They do not argue or beg. They say that God is able to deliver them. And they add: “But if not.” Their obedience does not depend on a miracle. They will not bow whether or not God rescues them. This is faith that is not tied to outcome. It trusts God’s character, not his results.

The furnace is heated seven times hotter. It is so hot that it kills the soldiers who throw them in. But inside, there are four men walking, unbound, and the fourth looks like a son of the gods. The rescue shows that God is present in the fire. He does not always spare us from the furnace, but he is with us in it. When they come out, they do not even smell of smoke. The king blesses their God and decrees that no one may speak against him.

Chapter 4 is the king’s personal story. He has a dream of a great tree that is cut down, and Daniel tells him that the tree is himself. For seven periods of time, he will be driven from among men and live like an animal, until he acknowledges that Heaven rules. Daniel gives pastoral advice: “Break off your sins by practicing righteousness, and your iniquities by showing mercy to the oppressed.” A year later, while walking on his roof, the king boasts of Babylon, “which I have built by my mighty power.” The words are still in his mouth when judgment falls.

When his sanity returns, he lifts his eyes to heaven and blesses the Most High. His testimony ends with a statement of the book’s theme: “All his works are right and his ways are just; and those who walk in pride he is able to humble.” The greatest emperor of the age is brought to confess what Daniel’s friends knew all along.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 43:2 says, “When you pass through the waters, I will be with you… when you walk through fire you shall not be burned.” Hebrews 11:34 mentions those who “quenched the power of fire.” Acts 5:29: “We must obey God rather than men.” Revelation 13:15 shows a

similar demand to worship an image. Matthew 1:23: Immanuel, God with us. Proverbs 16:18 says pride goes before destruction. 1 Peter 5:5-6 says, “God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.”

STEP 6

Application

Pray “But if not” for a situation where you do not know how God will act. Commit to obedience regardless of the outcome.

Take comfort that Jesus is with you in your furnace.

Examine your own “Is not this great Babylon?” boast. Where might God be humbling pride in you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what fire you are facing.
- Say, “Even if he does not,” and tell him whom you will serve.
- Thank him that he walks with you in the fire.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

“If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up.”

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 488 · WEEK 70

Psalm 135

Praise the name of the LORD

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 135. It is a hymn of praise that celebrates the LORD's greatness over the idols of the nations. Notice how it echoes Daniel's chapters: the God of Israel against the gods of Babylon.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 135 is a hymn built from other Scripture. It quotes Exodus, Deuteronomy, Jeremiah, and other psalms. It was sung after the exile as the community recalled what God had done. It comes at the right place in this unit, after the stories of Daniel, where the living God confronts idols and kings. The psalm mocks idols and praises God for his choice of Israel. It will appear again later in the plan.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Praise the name of the LORD, give praise, O servants of the LORD" (v. 1).
2. "For I know that the LORD is great, and that our Lord is above all gods" (v. 5).
3. "Whatever the LORD pleases, he does, in heaven and on earth, in the seas and all deeps" (v. 6).
4. "He it was who struck down the firstborn of Egypt, both of man and of beast" (v. 8).
5. "Your name, O LORD, endures forever, your renown, O LORD, throughout all ages" (v. 13).
6. "The idols of the nations are silver and gold, the work of human hands" (v. 15).
7. "They have mouths, but do not speak; they have eyes, but do not see" (vv. 16-17).

8 “Those who make them become like them, so do all who trust in them” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a call to praise and quickly gives reasons: the LORD is good, he chose Jacob, and he is great. The key statement is in verse 6: “Whatever the LORD pleases, he does.” This is God’s sovereignty. Unlike the idols, he acts, in the heavens and on earth. He makes clouds rise, lightning flash, and wind come from his storehouses. In history, he struck down the firstborn of Egypt and defeated kings such as Sihon and Og. He gave their land as a heritage to Israel.

The psalm then contrasts God with idols. The idols are silver and gold, the work of human hands. They have mouths but cannot speak, eyes but cannot see, ears but cannot hear, and there is no breath in their mouths. The list is almost comical, and it is exactly the argument Isaiah and Jeremiah made. And the psalm ends with the most striking line: “Those who make them become like them; so do all who trust in them.” We become like what we worship. People who worship dead things become dead. They lose sight, hearing, and speech. Those who worship the living God become alive.

The final section widens the call to praise. The house of Israel, the house of Aaron, the house of Levi, and all who fear the LORD are summoned to bless him. And the last line is: “Blessed be the LORD from Zion, he who dwells in Jerusalem! Praise the LORD!”

For the exiles, who saw the grandeur of Babylon’s temples and idols, this was an important reminder. The gods of the empire were silent and powerless. The God of Israel, who seemed to be defeated, was alive and in control. The statue of Daniel 2 and the image of Daniel 3 were nothing before him.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 14:15-17 and 17:24-29 use this argument to preach to pagans. 1 Corinthians 8:4-6 says there is no God but one. Romans 1:22-23 says people who exchange the glory of God for images become fools. 2 Corinthians 3:18 says that beholding the glory of the Lord, we are being transformed into the same image. 1 Peter 2:9 calls the church a chosen race, God’s own possession, to proclaim his excellencies. Revelation 4:11 praises the worthy Lord and God.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you tend to worship that cannot speak, see, or hear. What are you becoming like?

Use this psalm as a call to praise. Name what the LORD has done as a list in your own words.

Say verse 6 as a statement of trust: “Whatever the LORD pleases, he does.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as great above all gods.
- Confess any idol of silver and gold, literal or modern.
- Thank him for what he pleases to do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

“If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up.”

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 489 · WEEK 70

Psalm 136

His steadfast love endures forever

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 136. Every verse ends with the same refrain: “for his steadfast love endures forever.” Read it aloud if you can, as a litany, with the second half as a response.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 136 is called the Great Hallel in Jewish tradition and is sung at Passover. It is a liturgy: one voice would say the first line, and the congregation would respond with the refrain. It recounts creation and the exodus and the conquest in the language of God’s steadfast love. After Daniel’s stories, it is a fitting close to Unit 13’s reading of the exile: the God who is sovereign over empires is the God whose love endures forever. It will return later in the plan.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 1).
2. “Give thanks to the God of gods, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 2).
3. “To him who alone does great wonders, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 4).
4. “To him who by understanding made the heavens, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 5).
5. “To him who struck down the firstborn of Egypt, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 10).
6. “To him who divided the Red Sea in two” (v. 13).
7. “It is he who remembered us in our low estate, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 23).
8. “He who gives food to all flesh, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The refrain, repeated twenty-six times, is the heart of the psalm. “His steadfast love endures forever.” The Hebrew word hesed, covenant love, is the theme. The psalm teaches that every act of God, in creation, in redemption, and in daily provision, flows from this love.

The structure is a story. The first section is creation: God made the heavens by understanding, spread out the earth, and made the great lights. The sun rules the day, and the moon and stars the night. The creation is not an accident or a conflict but a gift of love. The second section is redemption: God struck down the firstborn of Egypt, brought out Israel with a strong hand, divided the sea, and led his people through the wilderness. Even the destruction of the enemy kings is told as part of this love. The point is not cruelty but faithfulness to the covenant. The third section is the land given as a heritage.

Then there is a turn in verse 23: “It is he who remembered us in our low estate.” This is likely about the exile and the return. In the lowest point of the people’s history, God did not forget. And so the psalm ends with the universal provision of God: “He who gives food to all flesh,” and a final call: “Give thanks to the God of heaven, for his steadfast love endures forever.”

Reading Psalm 136 after the book of Lamentations is powerful. In Lamentations 3:22, the poet says, “The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases.” Here it is made into a song. After a unit about judgment, exile, and the fall of nations, the closing word is not wrath but love that endures.

STEP 5

Connection

1 John 4:8 says, “God is love.” Romans 8:38-39 says nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord. Ephesians 2:4-5 says, “God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive.” John 3:16 shows God’s love in giving his Son. Matthew 26:30 says that Jesus and his disciples sang a hymn after the Last Supper, probably the Hallel.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Psalm 136 as a litany, aloud, with a friend or family member. One person reads the first line, and the other answers the refrain.

Add your own verses: “To him who … for his steadfast love endures forever.” Name three things from your own life.

Remember a time God “remembered you in your low estate.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God, line by line, for his steadfast love in your own story.
- Remember how he remembered you in your low estate.
- Give thanks to the God of heaven.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

"If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 490 · WEEK 70

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Daniel 3:17-18 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."

DANIEL 3:17-18

REST

Meditation

These words were spoken by three young men facing death. They stand at the center of the book of Daniel, and they define what faithfulness looks like when the stakes are highest.

"Our God whom we serve is able to deliver us." The first statement is about God's ability. They do not doubt that he can save them. They believe in a God who is powerful enough to rescue from a furnace seven times hotter than normal. They call him "our God whom we serve," because their relationship is one of service. It is a statement of confidence.

"And he will deliver us out of your hand, O king." The second statement is of expectation. They think God will rescue them. They are not stoic, bracing for the worst. They hope in God.

“But if not.” These two words are among the most powerful in Scripture. They show that their faith is not conditional. If God does not rescue them, their obedience stands. They do not make their loyalty depend on getting what they want from God. Their faith is in God himself, not in his rescue.

“Be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods.” The conclusion is a clear statement of allegiance. They do not argue about the details of the law. They simply refuse. And what follows is the rescue, with the fourth figure in the fire.

For the Christian, this is a model of faith in uncertain times. We pray for deliverance, believe that God can, and believe that he will. And we commit to obey in either case. Say this verse when you face a situation where the outcome is unknown. The God who is able is also with you in the fire.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the last chapters of Ezekiel and began the book of Daniel. You prayed Psalms 128, 129, 131, 133, and 134, with their blessing of home and unity, their quiet trust, and their night blessing. In Ezekiel, you heard the watchman renewed, God’s promise to be the shepherd himself, the new heart and the Spirit within, the dry bones that lived, the final defeat of Gog, and the vision of the glory returning to a new temple. You read the river flowing from the sanctuary and bringing life to the Dead Sea, and the book’s last words: “The LORD Is There.” Then you met Daniel: the young man who would not defile himself, the dream of the statue and the stone, the three men in the fiery furnace, and the proud king humbled. Psalms 135 and 136 closed the week with God’s sovereignty over idols and his steadfast love that endures forever. The week taught that God himself will make his people new, that he dwells among them, and that faithfulness in exile is possible.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Ezekiel’s river grows deeper as it flows, giving life to the Dead Sea. What place in your life or community needs God’s river of life?

Daniel and his friends lived faithfully in a foreign empire. What are the “Babylonian” pressures in your life, and what would faithful, gracious resistance look like?

The three men said, “But if not.” How does that kind of faith, not dependent on the outcome, challenge or comfort you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that he is able to deliver you.

Thank him that he walks with you in the fire.

Rest in him today.

DAY 491 · WEEK 71

Daniel 5:1-6:28

The writing on the wall; the den of lions

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 5:1-6:28. A king's feast ends with a hand writing on the wall, and an elderly Daniel is thrown into a den of lions for praying. Read the two stories together as the fall of the proud and the rescue of the faithful.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 5 takes place in 539 BC, the night Babylon fell to the Medes and Persians. Belshazzar, the crown prince and co-regent, holds a great feast and uses the sacred vessels from Jerusalem's temple as drinking cups. Chapter 6 takes place under Darius the Mede, in the early years of Persian rule. Daniel is now an old man of about eighty, and his enemies set a trap using his prayer life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Belshazzar... gave command to bring the gold and silver vessels that Nebuchadnezzar his father had taken out of the temple in Jerusalem" (5:2).
2. "Immediately the fingers of a human hand appeared and wrote on the plaster of the wall" (5:5).
3. "You have not humbled your heart, though you knew all this, but you have lifted up yourself against the Lord of heaven" (5:22-23).
4. "MENE, MENE, TEKEL, and PARSIN" (5:25).
5. "You have been weighed in the balances and found wanting" (5:27).
6. "That very night Belshazzar the Chaldean king was killed" (5:30).

7. “When Daniel knew that the document had been signed, he went to his house… and he got down on his knees three times a day and prayed and gave thanks before his God, as he had done previously” (6:10).

8. “My God sent his angel and shut the lions” mouths, and they have not harmed me, because I was found blameless before him’ (6:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Belshazzar’s feast shows the arrogance of a ruler who has learned nothing. His grandfather Nebuchadnezzar had been humbled, yet he drinks from the vessels of God’s temple and praises the gods of gold and silver. The hand appears, and the king is terrified, his knees knocking. The wise men cannot read it. The queen mother recommends Daniel. He refuses the reward and reads the sentence: God has numbered the days of your kingdom, weighed you, and divided it. The words are about weights: a mina, a shekel, and half-shekels. The reading is clear: the kingdom is over. That very night, Babylon fell.

The charge is that Belshazzar knew what had happened to Nebuchadnezzar and did not humble himself. Knowledge without humility is the greater guilt. “The God in whose hand is your breath, and whose are all your ways, you have not honored.”

Chapter 6 is a contrast. Daniel’s enemies, jealous of his rank, can find no fault in him except “in the law of his God.” They persuade the king to sign a decree that no one may pray to any god or man except the king for thirty days. Daniel, hearing it, does exactly what he had always done. He goes to his upper room, opens his windows toward Jerusalem, and prays three times a day. He does not make a show, and does not hide. He simply continues.

He is thrown to the lions. The king, who loves him, spends a sleepless night. At dawn, Daniel is alive. “My God sent his angel and shut the lions” mouths.’ The king issues a new decree: that in all his kingdom people are to tremble before the God of Daniel, “for he is the living God, enduring forever; his kingdom shall never be destroyed.”

Two kings, two responses. Belshazzar lifted himself up and fell. Daniel humbled himself in prayer and was preserved. The difference is not strength but allegiance.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Pray then like this: Our Father in heaven” (Matthew 6:9), and told his disciples to pray always (Luke 18:1). 1 Thessalonians 5:17 says to pray without ceasing. Hebrews 11:33 mentions those who “stopped the mouths of lions.” Acts 5:29 says we must obey God rather

than men. 2 Timothy 4:17 says Paul was rescued from the lion's mouth. Psalm 1:2 says the blessed person meditates on the law day and night. Revelation 14:8 echoes "Fallen, fallen is Babylon."

STEP 6

Application

Establish a regular, consistent prayer rhythm, even if no one sees. Let it be as natural as breathing.

Examine whether you have "weighed" yourself against God's standard. Thank God that Christ was weighed in your place.

Pray for those facing opposition because of their faith.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from lifting yourself against him.
- Ask him to teach you to pray as Daniel did, with steady faithfulness.
- Thank him that your breath and ways are in his hand.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 71

"And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel."

EZRA 3:11

DAY 492 · WEEK 71

Daniel 7:1-8:27

The Son of Man; the four beasts

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 7:1-8:27. The second half of Daniel begins with visions. Four beasts rise from the sea, and one like a son of man comes with the clouds of heaven. Read chapter 7 slowly, especially verses 9 to 14. This is one of the most important passages in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The visions of Daniel 7 and 8 date to about 553 and 551 BC, before the events of chapters 5 and 6, but they are placed here to open the apocalyptic part of the book. The visions use symbolic beasts to describe the empires of the earth. In chapter 7, which is in Aramaic, Daniel sees four beasts and then a heavenly courtroom. In chapter 8, he sees a ram and a goat, which many interpreters understand as Persia and Greece.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Four great beasts came up out of the sea, different from one another” (7:3).
2. “As I looked, thrones were placed, and the Ancient of Days took his seat” (7:9).
3. “His clothing was white as snow, and the hair of his head like pure wool; his throne was fiery flames” (7:9).
4. “A stream of fire issued and came out from before him” (7:10).
5. “Behold, with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man, and he came to the Ancient of Days and was presented before him” (7:13).
6. “And to him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom, that all peoples, nations, and languages should serve him” (7:14).

7. “His dominion is an everlasting dominion, which shall not pass away, and his kingdom one that shall not be destroyed” (7:14).

8. “And the kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven shall be given to the people of the saints of the Most High” (7:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The four beasts are a lion with eagle’s wings, a bear raised on one side, a leopard with four heads, and a terrifying fourth beast with iron teeth and ten horns. They are usually understood as successive empires: Babylon, Persia, Greece, and Rome or a later power. They rise from the chaotic sea. The fourth has a little horn that speaks great things and wages war against the saints. The beasts show the nature of human empires: violent, devouring, and arrogant.

Then the scene shifts. Thrones are set, and the Ancient of Days takes his seat. The picture is of a heavenly court. His clothing is white as snow, and his throne is flames of fire with wheels of burning fire. Thousands upon thousands serve him. The books are opened. The beast is slain, and its body burned. The other beasts lose their dominion.

Then comes the climax: “With the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man.” Clouds are the vehicle of God in the Old Testament. This figure approaches the Ancient of Days and receives everlasting dominion over all peoples. The kingdoms of the beasts rise from the sea. The kingdom of the son of man comes from heaven. Beasts devour, but the son of man is given all authority.

Daniel is troubled by the vision. An attendant explains: the four beasts are four kings. “But the saints of the Most High shall receive the kingdom and possess the kingdom forever.” The Son of Man shares his rule with his people.

Chapter 8 is a second vision of a ram, a goat, and a little horn that desecrates the sanctuary. It looks beyond to the persecution under Antiochus Epiphanes in the second century BC, a type of later enemies. Daniel is overcome by the vision and falls sick. The consistent message: the powers of this world, however terrifying, are limited by God’s decree.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus called himself “the Son of Man” more than eighty times. At his trial, he said to the high priest, “You will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power and coming on the clouds of heaven” (Mark 14:62), and the high priest tore his robes, understanding the claim.

Matthew 28:18: “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me.” Revelation 1:7, 13-14 shows him coming with the clouds, white-haired. Revelation 13 shows the beast, and Revelation 5 shows the Lamb receiving the kingdom.

STEP 6

Application

Spend time meditating on Daniel 7:13-14, and think about Jesus as the one to whom all dominion is given.

When world powers seem terrifying, remember that the Ancient of Days is on the throne and the books are open.

Pray for those who are persecuted, remembering that the kingdom will be given to the saints.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise the Ancient of Days.
- Thank him for the Son of Man whose kingdom will not pass away.
- Ask him to give you courage in the meantime.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 71

“And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.”

EZRA 3:11

DAY 493 · WEEK 71

Daniel 9:1-10:21

Daniel's prayer; the 70 weeks

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 9:1-10:21. Daniel reads Jeremiah, prays one of the greatest prayers of confession in the Bible, and receives the prophecy of the seventy weeks. Then a vision of a glorious man and a message from an angel who was delayed by spiritual conflict. Read the prayer first, and take your time.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 9 is dated to 539 BC, the first year of Darius. Daniel, now an old man, reads Jeremiah's prophecy of seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11-12; 29:10), and realizes that the time is near. He responds by prayer. Chapter 10 is dated three years later, in 536 BC. Daniel is mourning and fasting when he sees a vision of a man in linen, and receives a message about the conflict between spiritual powers.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I, Daniel, perceived in the books the number of years that, according to the word of the LORD to Jeremiah the prophet, must pass before the end of the desolations of Jerusalem" (9:2).
2. "Then I turned my face to the Lord God, seeking him by prayer and pleas for mercy with fasting and sackcloth and ashes" (9:3).
3. "We have sinned and done wrong and acted wickedly and rebelled, turning aside from your commandments" (9:5).
4. "To the Lord our God belong mercy and forgiveness, for we have rebelled against him" (9:9).

5. “For we do not present our pleas before you because of our righteousness, but because of your great mercy” (9:18).
6. “O Lord, hear; O Lord, forgive. O Lord, pay attention and act. For your own sake, O my God, do not delay” (9:19).
7. “Seventy weeks are decreed about your people and your holy city, to finish the transgression, to put an end to sin, and to atone for iniquity, to bring in everlasting righteousness” (9:24).
8. “Fear not, Daniel, for from the first day that you set your heart to understand and humbled yourself before your God, your words have been heard” (10:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Daniel’s prayer is a model. He begins with God’s word: he has read the book and trusts the promise. But the promise leads him to pray, not to relax. He knows that God’s promises are fulfilled in the context of repentance. He fasts and confesses, using the first person plural, “we have sinned,” though Daniel himself is portrayed as blameless. He identifies with the people. He praises God as great and awesome, keeping covenant and steadfast love. He admits that the curses of Moses have fallen because of their disobedience.

Notice what he does not argue. He does not appeal to his own righteousness or to Israel’s merits. “We do not present our pleas before you because of our righteousness, but because of your great mercy.” The appeal is for God’s name’s sake. The prayer is urgent: “O Lord, hear; O Lord, forgive; O Lord, pay attention and act.”

The answer comes by Gabriel, who says that as soon as Daniel began to pray, a word went out. Then the prophecy of the seventy weeks: seventy sevens decreed for the people and the city. Six things are to be accomplished: to finish the transgression, to put an end to sin, to atone for iniquity, to bring in everlasting righteousness, to seal the vision and prophecy, and to anoint a most holy place. These are the great goals of redemption. The details of the timeline are debated, but Christians have long seen in it a pointer to the Messiah, the anointed one, who will be cut off and bring the atonement.

Chapter 10 shows a heavenly dimension. Daniel’s prayer had been heard from the first day, but the angel was delayed 21 days by “the prince of the kingdom of Persia” until Michael came to help. This is a glimpse of spiritual warfare behind the scenes of history. Daniel is strengthened by the angel’s touch: “Peace be with you; be strong and of good courage.”

STEP 5

Connection

1 John 1:9 says, “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins.” Romans 5:6-11 speaks of Christ dying for the ungodly. Hebrews 9:26 says Christ has appeared “to put away sin by the sacrifice of himself,” fulfilling the goals of Daniel 9:24. Ephesians 6:12 says we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against the spiritual forces of evil. Revelation 1:12-18 shows the glorified Christ in a similar picture to Daniel 10.

STEP 6

Application

Use Daniel’s prayer as a pattern. Start with God’s word, confess honestly, appeal to his mercy and not your merit.

Pray for your community or nation, using “we” and not “they.”

Take courage from Daniel 10:12. Your prayers are heard from the first day, even if the answer is delayed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess your sin and the sin of your people in your own words.
- Tell God you do not plead your righteousness but his mercy.
- Ask him to hear and act for his own name’s sake.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 71

“And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.”

EZRA 3:11

DAY 494 · WEEK 71

Daniel 11:1-12:13

The kings of north and south; the resurrection of the dead

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 11:1-12:13. This is a long and detailed prophecy of the conflicts between kings of the north and south. Do not get lost in the details. Read for the ending in chapter 12: the resurrection of the dead, and the final word to Daniel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This last vision comes in 536 BC, and it traces the history of the Persian and Greek empires, and especially the conflicts between the Ptolemies of Egypt (the king of the south) and the Seleucids of Syria (the king of the north). It culminates in the persecution of the Jewish people under Antiochus Epiphanes in the second century BC, and looks beyond to the end times. Chapter 12 gives the clearest statement of resurrection in the Old Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But the people who know their God shall stand firm and take action" (11:32).
2. "And those who are wise among the people shall make many understand, though for some days they shall stumble by sword and flame" (11:33).
3. "At that time shall arise Michael, the great prince who has charge of your people" (12:1).
4. "And there shall be a time of trouble, such as never has been since there was a nation till that time. But at that time your people shall be delivered, everyone whose name shall be found written in the book" (12:1).
5. "And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt" (12:2).

6. “And those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of the sky above; and those who turn many to righteousness, like the stars forever and ever” (12:3).
7. “But you, go your way till the end. And you shall rest and shall stand in your allotted place at the end of the days” (12:13).
8. “Shut up the words and seal the book, until the time of the end” (12:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 11 is a long survey of history in prophecy, with such detail that critics have claimed it must have been written after the events. Believers see in it the sovereign foreknowledge of God. The point is that history is not random. The kings of the north and south rise and fall, make treaties and break them, and God is working through it. The history culminates in the desecration of the temple by a contemptuous king, and then the picture moves beyond him.

In the midst of the persecution, there is a counterpoint. “The people who know their God shall stand firm and take action.” This is the verse of the chapter. Persecution does not destroy those who know their God. They shall stand firm. And those who are wise will make many understand, even though they stumble by sword and flame. The suffering of the saints is not meaningless: it refines and purifies.

Chapter 12 turns to the end. A time of trouble will come, unlike any before. But Daniel’s people will be delivered, “everyone whose name shall be found written in the book.” Then comes the resurrection promise: “Many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt.” This is one of the clearest teachings of the resurrection of the dead in the Old Testament. Both the righteous and the wicked will rise. The wise will shine like the stars.

The book ends with a personal word to Daniel. He is told to seal the book until the time of the end, and then, tenderly: “But you, go your way till the end. And you shall rest and shall stand in your allotted place at the end of the days.” The old prophet will rest and rise. It is a fitting close to the long unit of exile. After everything, the final word is of rest and resurrection.

STEP 5

Connection

John 5:28-29 says that all who are in the tombs will hear his voice and come out, “those who have done good to the resurrection of life, and those who have done evil to the resurrection of judgment.” 1 Corinthians 15:51-58 speaks of the resurrection. Matthew 24:21 echoes the “time of trouble such as never has been.” Philippians 2:15 says believers shine like stars in the world. Revelation 20:12-15 mentions the book of life. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 comforts us with the hope of resurrection.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Daniel 11:32b: “The people who know their God shall stand firm and take action.” Ask how your knowledge of God can lead to firm action.

Take comfort in the promise of resurrection when you grieve.

Seek to be one who “turns many to righteousness.” Ask whom God may be calling you to encourage in the faith.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you know him and stand firm.
- Thank him that your name is written in his book.
- Thank him for the hope of the resurrection.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 71

“And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.”

EZRA 3:11

DAY 495 · WEEK 71

Review and Reflection

Unit 13 review, Exile, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people."
>
> JEREMIAH 31:33

REST

Meditation

This is the unit's anchor verse, the heart of the new covenant promise. After the long account of judgment, exile, and loss, it is the answer God gives to the problem of the human heart.

"I will put my law within them." The old covenant was written on stone tablets. It was holy, righteous, and good, but it was external. The people heard it, agreed to it, and broke it. God did not change the law. He changes where it is kept. "Within them." The law moves from tablet to the center of the person.

"And I will write it on their hearts." To write on the heart is to make obedience a matter of desire, not just duty. It is what Ezekiel describes as a new heart and the Spirit within. Where there was resistance, there is delight. Psalm 40:8 says, "I delight to do your will, O my God; your law is within my heart." The new covenant makes this the normal experience of God's people.

"And I will be their God, and they shall be my people." This is the covenant formula running through the whole Bible. It is the goal of redemption: a people who belong to God, and a God who belongs to his people. It is the language of marriage and family. It is also the language of Revelation 21:3.

Say this verse from memory, and think about the unit as a whole. It began with the fall of Jerusalem and ended with promises of a new heart, a new temple, and a kingdom that will never be destroyed. All of this is fulfilled in Jesus, who said at the Last Supper, "This cup is the new covenant in my blood." If you have trusted in him, this promise is for you.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This unit covered the exile, the darkest period of the Old Testament and one of the richest in hope. Josiah's reform could not undo Manasseh's sin, and Jerusalem fell in 586 BC. Jeremiah, the weeping prophet, warned for forty years, confronted false hope in the temple and in false prophets, and wrote to the exiles that they should seek the welfare of Babylon. At the center of his book is the Book of Consolation, with the promise of a new covenant, in which God writes his law on the heart and forgives sin forever. Lamentations gave voice to grief and found hope in the steadfast love that is new every morning. Ezekiel saw God's glory on a mobile throne in Babylon, watched it leave the temple, and then heard the promise of a heart of flesh, the Spirit within, the dry bones that live, and the return of the glory to a city whose name is "The LORD Is There." Daniel showed what faithful life looks like in a foreign empire: refusing to defile himself, trusting God in the furnace and the lions' den, and seeing the Son of Man receive an everlasting kingdom. The psalms of the unit gave words for lament, trust, and praise.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the New Covenant promise in Jeremiah 31?

Recall the four promises: the law written on the heart, a restored relationship, direct knowledge of God, and complete forgiveness. How is this different from the covenant at Sinai? Look at Hebrews 8:6-13 and Luke 22:20 to see how it is fulfilled in Christ.

What does the glory departing from the Temple in Ezekiel 8-11 mean?

Think about the reasons the glory left (the idolatry in the temple), the slow stages of its departure, and what it meant for the exiles. What is the significance of the glory's return in Ezekiel 43, and how does John 1:14 relate?

What does Ezekiel 36-37 promise about the Spirit's work in the New Covenant?

Consider the cleansing water, the new heart and new spirit, and the Spirit within us who causes us to walk in God's statutes. Consider the valley of dry bones. How does Jesus' conversation with Nicodemus in John 3:1-8 draw on this passage?

Who is the Son of Man in Daniel 7, and why is this title important?

Describe the scene: the beasts, the Ancient of Days, and the one like a son of man coming with the clouds. Why did Jesus use this title for himself, and why did the high priest react as he did in Mark 14:61-64?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for writing his law on your heart.

Thank him for what you have learned through the exile.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.